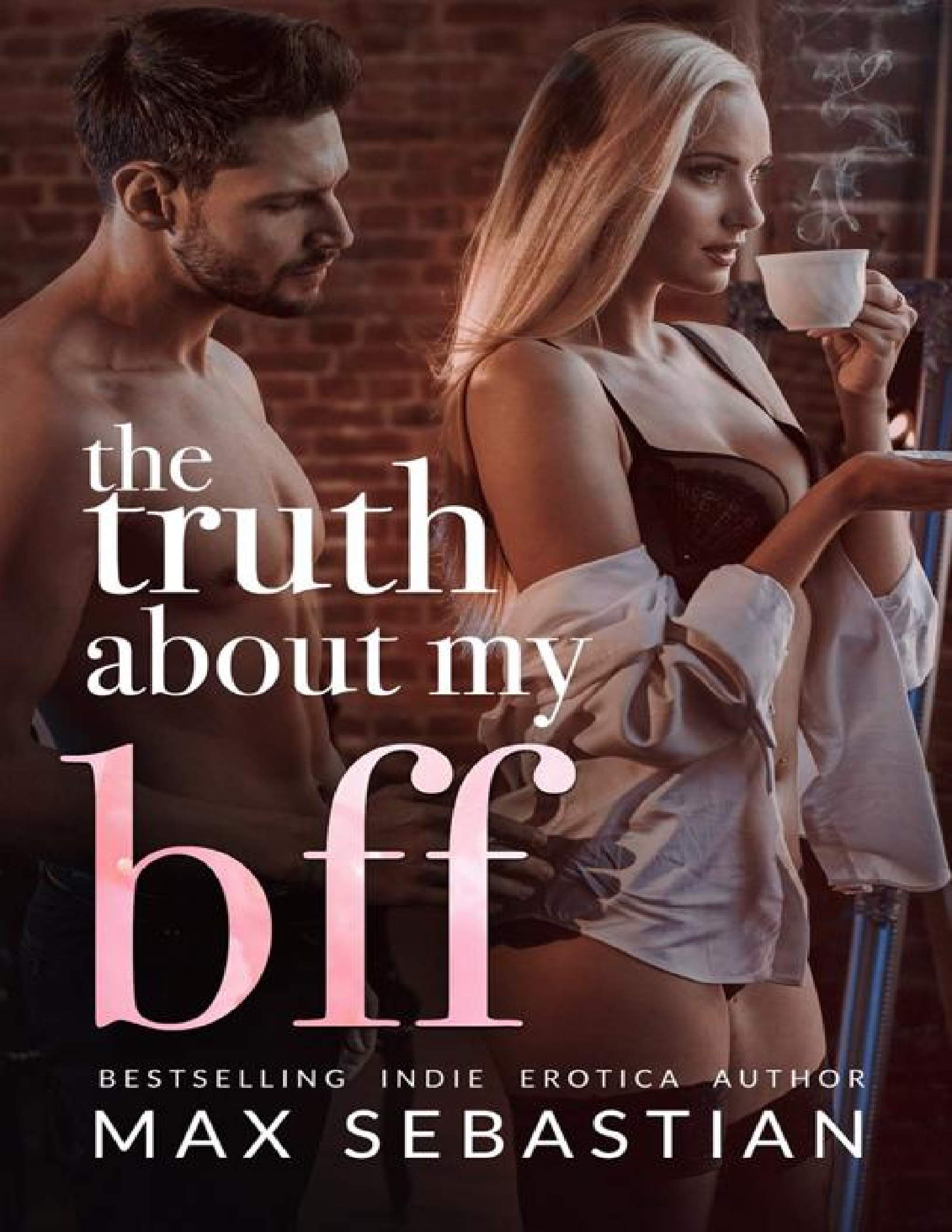




the
truth
about my
bff

BESTSELLING INDIE EROTICA AUTHOR

MAX SEBASTIAN

THE TRUTH ABOUT MY BFF

MAX SEBASTIAN

MAXSEBASTIAN.NET

OceanofPDF.com

Contents

[Chapter 1](#)
[Chapter 2](#)
[Chapter 3](#)
[Chapter 4](#)
[Chapter 5](#)
[Chapter 6](#)
[Chapter 7](#)
[Chapter 8](#)
[Chapter 9](#)
[Chapter 10](#)
[Chapter 11](#)
[Chapter 12](#)
[Chapter 13](#)
[Chapter 14](#)
[Chapter 15](#)
[Chapter 16](#)
[Chapter 17](#)
[Chapter 18](#)
[Chapter 19](#)
[Chapter 20](#)
[Chapter 21](#)
[Chapter 22](#)
[Chapter 23](#)
[Chapter 24](#)
[Chapter 25](#)

OceanofPDF.com

Chapter One

The two of them probably would have been called ‘childhood sweethearts’, if they’d ever have actually dated while they were growing up back in Everett. But as teenagers, Emma Taylor had been a classic tomboy, more interested in competing with boys than dating them, and Drew Mackenzie had always had a mega-crush on cheerleader Ashley Powell.

They’d lived on the same block, played together in the same playgrounds, ridden BMX bikes together, snuck into the movie theater together, and dealt with their earth-shattering personal crises together. Emma’s mom had walked out on the family when she was 12, and Drew’s family had practically adopted her after that, but then Drew’s mom had gotten breast cancer two years later, and not long afterward Emma was helping him grieve.

By the time college came along, they were as good as inseparable, but at the same time, they had only ever seen each other as best friends. When the two of them got interested in dating, the thought never even crossed their minds to try dating each other. They were virtually brother and sister by that stage.

When Emma went off to law school, and Drew ended up staying in Everett to take care of his dad, they lost touch a little. But then a succession

of bar jobs led Drew to the point where he was managing a place down in the South End, and Emma came back to Boston to work for a law firm on Beacon Hill.

So the two of them were able to hang out together like old times, and when an apartment became available in Drew's building, they even got to be neighbors again.

By then, Drew had lost faith in dating, after a couple of broken hearts along the way, while Emma was somewhat hooked on Tinder, and its easy supply of guys eager to make their way into her bed without getting into any kind of commitment.

The two of them hung out most nights, when Drew wasn't working the late shift at the bar and Emma wasn't out on a date with another buff gym bunny. And even when it was date night for Emma, Drew would often hang out with her until she was ready to go out. She liked asking his opinion on which outfit she should wear for the date, his advice on where to take her date once dinner at the pre-arranged restaurant was out of the way.

Then one night, everything changed.

Drew was hanging out in Emma's apartment with their friend Carrie, while Emma was getting ready for a first date with Vincent, a finance jock she'd found on Tinder. Carrie had brought over a couple of bottles of red Bordeaux, and the two of them were watching *The Matrix* on Netflix while helping Emma decide which dress to wear for her night out.

When it came time for her to head out for her date, Emma told the two of them they should just stay and watch the rest of the movie; they didn't need to get up just because she was on her way out.

'It is a great movie,' Carrie said, and then she said to Drew: 'And *your* apartment's always so cold.'

'Ray likes it cold,' Drew said, referring to his roommate. 'Says he can't sleep otherwise.'

Emma said, 'Well, you're welcome to stay, hang out. There's more vino in the fridge.'

'Wonderful.'

'You know this is the first movie I ever saw at the theater?'

'This one?' Drew said. 'We snuck into this one when we were in, what, the fourth grade?'

Emma smiled. 'Yeah. That was the first time I ever went to a movie theater.'

And then Emma was away to her date, leaving Carrie and Drew chilling on the couch with their French wine, while Neo tore up the screen trying to defeat Agent Smith. One bottle led to another, and when *The Matrix* was over, the two of them moved on to *The Matrix Reloaded*, and the evening continued.

Drew never actually registered how far through that second movie Carrie ended up going home. He didn't even register how far he got through the movie himself. But, thanks to copious quantities of fairly hefty cabernet sauvignon, at some point he had nodded off to sleep on Emma's comfortable sofa, in her nice, warm apartment.

The logical explanation was that Carrie had gone home after that—switching out the lights when she went, since he was already asleep.

The next thing he knew, he was waking up in the middle of the night, still on Emma's couch. At first, he was more amused at his own drunkenness than anything, and it didn't seem like too much of a struggle to get up and head out to his own apartment across the hall.

But then he heard the familiar sound of Emma giggling, and the not-so-familiar, deeper sound of a man murmuring.

Vincent.

Oh God, they were back from their date, and there was no doubt what would happen next...

Horried, he sat up to peer over the back of the sofa toward the only source of light in the apartment—the wide-open doorway into the bedroom. And there was Emma with a balding, older guy, standing by the side of her bed, making out like love-sick teenagers.

At first, Drew just felt stupid, embarrassed that he had apparently gotten so drunk he'd passed out on Emma's couch. He wasn't in college anymore, they would all be hitting the big 3-0 in a couple of years. He sighed, and lay back down on the sofa, figuring that he'd just have to wait until Emma, or her date, closed the bedroom door to make his escape. The way the apartment was laid out, you had to walk past the bedroom door to get to the front door, so for now it looked like he was trapped.

He lay there and debated whether he could cope with the humiliation of just walking out—a quick apology as he slipped past them—and later explain to Emma how he had nodded off while drinking too much wine.

Perhaps he'd be better off staying there, pretending to be asleep, clamp the cushions over his ears and hope that it wouldn't be long before Emma and her date were sufficiently distracted so he could scamper past without being detected. Perhaps they'd eventually close the bedroom door.

Only, he cautiously edged upward again to peer over the back of the couch to look for a suitable moment to flee, and what he saw then changed everything.

Vincent had Emma pressed up against the doorway of the bedroom, and was now kneeling down in front of her to kiss her chest where her low neckline exposed a healthy amount of cleavage. Emma had one hand on the back of his shaven head as he kissed her between her breasts, and was moaning quietly.

Drew just stood and stared, stunned.

It wasn't that Emma looked nice – he knew she'd made herself look nice for the date, he and Carrie had helped her to choose the gray satin dress she was wearing. It was that she looked drop-dead gorgeous.

Drew couldn't quite understand it. This was still Emma, his best friend, who he'd known so well for practically their whole lives; it was still Emma, the woman he regularly helped find guys on Tinder, and who he had casually waved goodbye to earlier that evening as she had left for her date, without thinking twice about it. Only now, as some State Street alpha male smothered her breasts with his face, Drew noticed for the first time how beautiful she was—how pretty her delicate, faintly freckly, almost elfin face was, how nice her tidy, dirty blonde hair looked, held back by an Alice band, how incredible she looked in that dress, the arch of her back and the contours of her behind seeming so perfectly designed to arouse his interest.

It was bizarre—he'd never, as far as he could remember, looked at Emma and been genuinely turned on before.

Oh, if you'd have asked him, he would have told you she was attractive. He knew she was. Guys flocked after her. She could walk up to practically anyone in the middle of a crowded bar and get their telephone number, even if they turned out to be married. But Drew, himself, hadn't ever been attracted to her.

Until now.

This was insane. The guy was sucking on her breasts through the thin satin of her dress, making her quietly groan, her eyes shut, her soft mouth open—and Drew really envied him. For the first time, he looked at one of Emma's dates and actually envied him.

Even from here, Drew could smell her sweet perfume. It sent a shiver of desire down his spine.

He couldn't work it out. He'd seen Emma with guys before, on occasion. There had been times she'd been uncertain about a guy, and had asked Drew to be a quasi-chaperone, and he had kept an eye on her from afar at some bar or restaurant, until she texted him to say she felt safe. There had been times when her date had picked her up from her apartment, and they'd all met. But Drew had never reacted to the sight of her with

another guy before—there'd never been envy, or jealousy, or this kind of unexpected arousal.

But right now, he was watching Emma in the throes of passion with Vincent, and for the first time in his life, he wanted her. He felt his heart being squeezed by a brand new, and very forceful, crush.

The strangest thing, though, was that despite these new feelings within him, he still didn't feel any hint of jealousy. He didn't feel an ounce of anger toward Vincent—he didn't even want the guy to stop touching her.

Drew couldn't understand it, but at the same time he couldn't deny that it excited him, watching Emma with this other man.

Then Vincent stood up straight again, and Drew watched him slip the straps of Emma's dress off her shoulders and peel the thing down to expose her bare breasts.

Drew stifled a gasp, and in that moment, Emma turned her head toward him as though she'd heard it.

Drew immediately dropped down onto the sofa, fearing that he'd been caught—expecting that she'd break away from Vincent, wander over to the couch and demand to know what he thought he was doing, hiding away over here. She'd probably fold her arms and pout at him, and the embarrassment would just be excruciating. He'd have to make light of it all, admit that he'd fallen into a drunken stupor after too much of Carrie's wine. Apologize and make his escape, tail between his legs.

She'd probably be angry at him for weeks, maybe months.

But as he lay on that sofa, waiting for the humiliation to begin, nothing happened.

After a moment or two, he even risked sitting up again, carefully, peering over the back of the sofa to find out what was going on.

Emma was kissing Vincent, mouth-to-mouth, her arm draped on his shoulder, her hand behind his neck. She was quietly sucking on his lips, her eyes closed, her body pressed to his, and as far as Drew could tell, she

hadn't heard him at all. That was a huge relief, although Drew now felt guilt bubbling up inside him, countering the overwhelming feelings of desire and arousal to some degree, forcing him to look again at whether any kind of escape might be possible.

There was no way out of the apartment, not yet. He would have had to walk around Emma and her date in order to get out to the door. Even absorbed in each other's kiss, they couldn't miss him attempting to sneak out.

So Drew just sat there, rooted to the couch, his manhood thickening up as he watched his best friend with her date, who had peeled her dress all the way down to her waist by now, exposing her bare breasts, toned stomach, and the glint of silver from her pierced navel. God, her breasts were exquisite, perfect handfuls of creamy flesh, peaked by stiff little pink nipples that were just begging to be sucked into a hot mouth.

She hadn't been wearing a bra on her date? Naughty.

Still kissing her, Vincent now slipped Emma's dress down beyond her waist, revealing her lacy black panties, and she tilted her hips to help him slide the garment down her trim, pale thighs. Drew caught his breath as the dress faltered, and then dropped straight down to the floor, unveiling her black, thigh-high stockings.

Jesus, she looked like a goddess in the flesh.

Drew was so hard, watching her. And yet, strangely, he quietly willed Vincent onward—he wanted to see the guy take her. He delighted in the sight of the guy dipping down to take a pink nipple into his mouth, his hands roaming over the supple curves of her delectable behind, and the way Emma sighed and moaned quietly in response.

Why would I want this guy to sleep with her, if at the same time I want her for myself? Drew thought.

He figured he was just confused, because she was his best friend, and had been virtually a sibling to him for as long as he could remember. He

wasn't supposed to find her attractive, it was just that she was standing there looking plain delicious in nothing but a pair of little black panties and sexy lace-topped black stockings.

He was just mixing up his usual feelings of wanting Emma to have a good time, to enjoy herself, to get the most out of life, with the instinctive sexual attraction he felt as the result of seeing her in such a state of undress. That was all. It was perfectly natural, he told himself.

He should have laid back down, pressed cushions over his ears, and let Emma have her privacy. And yet he couldn't look away. She was the most stunning thing he'd ever seen.

He watched Vincent sucking on her exquisite tits, and was riveted to the spot. He watched the guy straighten up again, to kiss her mouth, and now his hand was slipping down her taut stomach, disappearing into her panties.

He was touching her pussy.

Emma had both her hands on his head, kissing him frantically, while he had his hand between her legs, pawing at her most intimate area, and *he had only just met her that night*. Drew was stunned—and yet he still silently urged the guy on, willed him to go further and further in his sexual exploration of this beautiful woman, and to make her feel incredible along the way.

Did he have his fingers inside her?

Then he had both of his hands on the waistband of her panties, and was pulling the little scrap of black lace down over her hips. He crouched in front of her, helping her step out of her panties, and his face was only an inch or two from her pussy.

Could he smell her excitement? Was he going to bury his face between her thighs, taste her?

From his direction, from the side, Drew couldn't see her actual pussy, but he felt certain that if he'd been in Vincent's place, he couldn't have

stopped himself from going down on her, wedging his face between her thighs, pressing his eager mouth to her sensitive folds.

But Vincent didn't linger. He stood up, dropped his pants and then lifted one of her legs so that he could guide the tip of his big, hard, exposed cock to her entrance.

Drew stifled another gasp. Was that really the guy's cock he could see? Jesus. It was. The two of them hadn't even managed to get inside the bedroom, and he was already sliding that huge thing inside her. Emma held her shapely, stocking-clad leg up against his body as he held her waist and thrust into her.

Drew couldn't believe it. He could see the guy's erect cock sinking into her, again and again. He couldn't see the actual penetration, but the guy's length moving into her again and again... there could be no mistake. He was fucking her. Drew was watching him fuck *Emma*.

And still he didn't feel jealousy. He just wanted a taste of her pussy for himself once she was done with Vincent. He watched her, and he couldn't help but slip his own cock out of his pants, to gently squeeze and stroke it while he watched this other man fucking his best friend right in front of him.

Emma kissed her date, and moaned, and let him enter her again and again, and Drew wondered why she didn't just push him away, then lead him into the bedroom where it would be easier.

He saw her turn her head again, and briefly glance over toward the windows, and Drew dropped down onto the sofa as before, praying that she hadn't seen him. But when he heard her sighing and moaning continue entirely uninterrupted, and the wet sounds of her date's big cock thrusting into her again and again, he felt certain she couldn't have seen him. He peered up over the edge of the sofa again, and saw that she was gazing off out the windows. She wasn't quite looking in his direction.

Then her moaning was rising in pitch, her sighs and moans becoming an urgent panting, then a gasping, crying whimper, as Vincent held her lifted leg tight, and pressed her up against the doorway. He pounded into her until her lithe frame was shivering and shaking, and she yelped as a powerful climax tore through her.

Surprisingly, Drew felt as sexually gratified by the sounds of her orgasm as though he, himself had induced it.

He very nearly came himself, just hearing her.

After she had come, she pushed them both away from the doorway, and Drew felt a sudden jolt to the heart as he feared that she was going to drag her date over to the couch to continue their passionate explorations there—and they'd certainly discover him lurking there.

He started silently contemplating what he might say, how he might act, if they did stumble onto him in the darkness. His best idea was to pretend to be asleep, and if they found him, he could pretend he hadn't seen anything, hadn't heard anything, that he'd been deep in slumber, completely unaware that Emma had even returned from her date.

But there was no sudden discovery, no denouncement of him for being there, hiding behind the sofa like a peeping tom.

There was only quiet, and then a pleasing burst of Emma's giggles, and the sound of them heading into the bedroom. Drew sat up, feeling enormously relieved not to be discovered, and caught the heavenly sight of the bedroom door slowly closing, the shrinking gap starving the rest of the apartment of light.

Then he was alone in the living room, gazing at an easy route toward the apartment front door, completely free and unencumbered by barriers or hazards.

He took a deep breath, and stood up, shaking with nervous energy. Then he tip-toed out of there, taking immense care to quietly open and close the front door behind him, making his escape at last.

And yet as Drew breathed in the cool, cool air of freedom in the hallway outside Emma's apartment, he couldn't help but feel invigorated by what he'd just witnessed.

The question was, the next time he saw her, would he be able to look at Emma the same way he always had? Or had their pure, innocent, perfect friendship been transformed forever?

OceanofPDF.com

Chapter Two

Normally on a Saturday morning, Drew would chill out at home in a pair of sweatpants, some movie or other playing on Netflix, munching on a bowl of cereal until Emma dropped by to shoot the breeze. Then maybe they'd go to the gym to burn off some of the lingering hangover, get some brunch somewhere, or go shopping or something like that.

This morning, however, Drew was up, dressed and out of his apartment before nine o'clock, leaving a message with his roommate Ray that if Emma came by, he was at work, dealing with a paperwork crisis.

'You guys have an argument or something?' asked Ray, who was milling around the kitchen in a bathrobe.

Drew was a little worried that it was too obvious that he wanted some time away from Emma to think. He said, 'No, not at all. It's just... you know, tax season coming up, and I've got to get started on the receipts.'

Ray chuckled. 'You guys can't afford an accountant to do all that? I could give you some recommendations.'

'I have to get the receipts in some kind of order before we can get an accountant to look at it,' Drew said.

Ray nodded. 'Interesting fact: a lot of people don't know this, but accountants are statistically more likely to have big dicks.' Drew gave his

roommate an eye-roll, and headed for the door. ‘The ones I’ve dated did, anyway,’ Ray added.

‘I don’t know how that helps with, you *know*, *accounts*,’ Drew said on the way out.

Ray sighed. ‘Straight guys are no fun.’

Juno’s Bar & Kitchen was over on Columbus Ave., relatively close to the campus of Northeastern University, so they always had a busy student crowd. When he got down there, the new guy—Lachlan—had already opened up, and a skeletal kitchen staff was beginning to set about serving breakfast to hungover customers, and a few who hadn’t even been to bed yet.

Drew gave a little salute to Lachlan as he came in, and then ducked into the office to retrieve the paperwork, before finding an empty booth toward the rear of the place.

A little after he got started on the receipts, Lachlan brought over a coffee and a plate of pancakes, and Drew was grateful for the sustenance. And, if he was honest, for the distraction from thinking about Emma and what had happened the previous night.

‘So, how are you finding it, my friend?’ he asked the new bartender, an Australian who looked like he ought to play rugby or Aussie rules football, or one of those other sports that seemed to involve not much more than mindless violence.

‘Good,’ Lachlan smiled easily. ‘I may be able to take a couple more shifts, actually.’

‘Great! What’s your schedule looking like?’

‘Pretty good, right now. We’re all applying for summer internships, you know? So the workload’s fairly light otherwise.’ Lachlan was currently going through law school at Boston University, with his bar work helping to fund tuition.

Since Drew's thoughts were still revolving around Emma, he couldn't help bringing up the fact that she was an associate at a law firm on Beacon Hill.

'Emma, she's the blonde one, right?' Lachlan said. 'I've seen her around.'

Drew nodded—Emma and some of their other friends often hung out here when he was working. It was no big surprise that Lachlan would know who she was. He'd probably already flirted with her a few times while she was ordering drinks from the bar.

'Maybe she could recommend you for an internship,' he said to the Australian. 'She works at Rogers, Travis & Scott.'

'RTS? Oh, okay,' Lachlan smiled. Then he said, 'Hey, d'you know if she's single?'

Drew laughed, thinking, *are you really more interested in a date with her than the possibility of an internship that could get you into the legal profession?* And yet, Lachlan did look like just the kind of guy Emma would want to date, even if he was on the younger side.

'I'll give you her phone number, if you like,' he said. 'You can decide for yourself if you want to ask her out, or inquire about an internship.'

'Sweet,' Lachlan grinned as he wrote Emma's number on the back of a napkin and handed it to him. Drew got the sense that the sandy-haired Australian had no intention whatsoever of using the number to further his legal career.

And yet, as he watched the guy wander over to some of the smattering of customers munching on ham and eggs, or sausage and pancakes, or coffee and pastries, Drew started thinking, perhaps trying to set Emma up with someone like Lachlan would be just the ticket right now. It might help to lay to rest the ridiculous crush on Emma that Drew seemed to have acquired.

Then, speak of the devil, there was Emma herself, leading Carrie and Fiona into the place, and Drew wondered if he should have avoided telling Ray where he was.

‘Hey, there he is!’ Emma said, smiling sweetly as she laid eyes on him.

Drew felt his heart quiver, and there were butterflies in his stomach just from seeing her. Jesus. What had happened to him? He’d never been nervous to see Emma before. He’d never been anything but entirely comfortable in her presence. Now he felt like an emotional wreck.

‘I had some paperwork to catch up on,’ he said, shoving his plate of half-eaten pancakes out of the way, before grabbing some receipts to try to bolster his cover story.

‘Can’t you get some flunkey or other to do all that?’ Fiona asked as the three of them slid into the booth around Drew.

‘Oh, I don’t employ flunkeys,’ he said, taking in a chestful of Emma’s vanilla perfume as she sat beside him. It made his loins tingle. God, she was only wearing blue jeans and a plain gray t-shirt—and she didn’t even have any makeup on—so how was it that she looked so uncompromisingly gorgeous?

God. Did he really watch her having sex last night?

She smiled warmly as he cast his eyes over her, and then tried to look as though it was no big deal that she was there, sitting right next to him.

Can she tell my feelings for her have changed? He wondered. *Is my crush obvious to anyone else?*

He tried to throw Emma, and anyone else for that matter, off the scent. ‘Hey, Em,’ he said. ‘You met our new bartender from Australia?’

Emma raised a quizzical eyebrow, as though the last thing she’d have expected from Drew was for him to point out another guy.

‘Who, him? Uh... I think I might have spoken to him before, maybe,’ she said.

‘He’s looking right at you,’ Carrie said, pulling out a cigarette before remembering she couldn’t smoke in there.

Drew said, ‘He was asking for your phone number earlier.’

‘Seriously?’ Emma said, and Drew couldn’t tell whether she was delighted or confused by it.

‘You don’t mind that I gave it to him?’ he said. ‘You know, you’d probably like him a lot...’

‘Uh... no, that’s okay.’ She hesitated, slightly, as though there was something she wanted to say to Drew, and then she changed her mind. Then she edged away from him, and said, ‘Maybe I’ll go say hello. See if he wants to grab a drink sometime.’

‘Sounds good.’

Then they were watching her head up to the bar, before getting into a very smiley conversation with Lachlan, and Drew was telling Carrie and Fiona about the guy being in law school, looking for an internship.

‘Jeez, he could be my intern if he wanted,’ said Fiona, though she wasn’t even in the legal profession. ‘You guys would have to swear not to tell Denny, though,’ she added, referring to her husband.

‘What the hell is a guy like that doing in law school?’ Carrie asked. ‘He should be out on a beach somewhere, wearing tiny little speedos, teaching me to surf.’

Drew tried to look as though he was still looking at his receipts, while he was actually watching Emma flirting with the Australian barman. To his slight dismay, setting her up with Lachlan was not distracting him from the little crush he had on Emma. If anything, it was making the crush stronger.

He even felt the familiar warmth, deep down, of arousal as he saw Emma chatting and laughing with Lachlan. And it wasn’t long before his imagination was beginning to drift, and he was thinking of Emma stripping down to her stockings for Lachlan.

Damn, why couldn’t he get all that out of his head?

Then Emma was heading back, smirking at all of her friends for being so desperate for gossip after her chat with Lachlan—and Lachlan was glancing over to Drew, giving him a little thumbs-up signal in appreciation for his sending Emma over to the bar.

‘Did he ask you out?’ Fiona asked her.

‘Uh-huh,’ Emma said, but she seemed oddly uncertain about it.

‘*Goddamn*. Maybe it’s time I said to hell with it, and went blonde,’ said Carrie, who often blamed her dating woes on her thick, curly red hair.

‘You’ll like him, he’s a nice guy,’ Drew said to Emma as she settled in beside him.

Then Emma said, ‘Why are you so keen to set me up with him?’

And to Drew, it was a slightly odd thing to say, since he had set her up with guys numerous times in the past, and often liked to help her search for potential dates on Tinder.

‘I just think he’s an interesting guy,’ Drew shrugged.

‘Since when did she care about interesting?’ Fiona said wryly. ‘The question is, does he have a big cock?’

‘I guess I’ll just have to try and find out,’ Emma said, attempting a smile, and gave Drew another funny little look, which he took to be about the fact that he was probably staring at her chest, remembering how she had looked when Vincent had peeled down her dress.

After breakfast was out of the way, Emma invited Drew to come with them to the farmers’ market over on Copley Square, but Drew insisted he had to stay and finish his paperwork. He felt pretty terrible, but somehow he needed to try and get his thoughts under control.

Why would he feel such a want, a need for Emma, and at the same time find the idea of her sleeping with Lachlan such a thrill?

Emma seemed slightly put out as the three women bade him farewell to head off to the market without him.

Drew was already getting concerned that his relationship with her had been affected by what had happened the other night.

OceanofPDF.com

Chapter Three

That evening, Drew was back home since he'd been on the early shift that day, and he really couldn't bring himself to dig out his phone and find out what Emma and their other friends were up to.

Ray came in, weighed down with shopping bags, and demanded to know what the hell he was doing being a couch potato on a Saturday night.

'I just don't really feel like going out,' he said, shrugging.

'Is Emma out on a date?' Ray inquired, hinting that perhaps Drew relied too much on his friendship with her to keep his social life going.

'I don't know. I don't know everything she does.'

'You're kidding me. I'd say it would be a cold day in Hades if you didn't know exactly what she was up to every single evening. What happened between you two? I am sensing something.'

'*Nothing*, really. Nothing.' Drew insisted, but he was both impressed and dismayed that Ray was picking up that there was something going on between Emma and himself.

'You know what I think?' Ray called, as he took his array of shopping bags into his room.

'I'm guessing you're going to tell me.'

'You're heading for the big three-oh, and you're getting in a funk because you haven't slept *with anyone since college!*'

Drew's lack of dating activity had always bugged Ray, who could never understand why a bad break up would keep him from looking for the next perfect date.

'I'm 28,' Drew laughed. 'I'm nowhere near 30 yet.'

'Two years,' Ray said. 'It'll come around fast, you'll see.'

Drew yawned, but then suddenly Ray dropped something small and hard in his lap, making him jump. It was his phone.

'What's this?' Drew looked at the screen, and saw that Ray had loaded up the Tinder app on it. 'Subtle,' he said.

'*Andrew Fitzpatrick MacKenzie*,' Ray said melodramatically. 'It is high time that you got out there again, and found Ms Right. Or Mr Right, for that matter. I know a few guys who could probably turn you.'

'Fitzpatrick? Where did you get 'Fitzpatrick'? My middle name's Brian.'

'Brian doesn't have any gravitas whatsoever.'

Ray snatched the phone from him, and started flicking his fingers all over the screen. 'You won't get your life back on track by sitting around waiting for Emma to notice you.'

'What? I am not sitting around waiting for *Emma to notice* me!' Drew was impressed at how outraged he made himself sound. A few days previously, he would have been outraged at such a suggestion, because he really hadn't had any interest at all in Emma in terms of any kind of romantic relationship.

But now, things had become subtly different. He just wasn't certain enough about how he felt to tell Ray.

'Then find somebody nice, and make *a move*,' Ray said, and he made it sound so simple.

Drew sighed, and did as Ray demanded. Perhaps he was right, it was time he got back into the dating game. It might be more of a diversion from

his weird little crush on Emma to find someone else on whom to pin his affections, than to play matchmaker for her.

So as Ray got ready to go out himself, Drew was genuinely flicking through the Tinder app, putting together a basic profile for himself, and looking at some of the faces of prospective dates thinking that this might be the way forward.

By the time Ray was gone, he was even trying to put some genuine effort into crafting the kind of profile that could draw some interest.

Then there was Emma, letting herself into his apartment with her own key, dumping herself down on the couch beside him, making him realize it was getting seriously late.

‘Have you been at home all night?’ Emma sounded a touch affected by alcohol.

‘I texted you.’

‘Sorry—I was distracted,’ he said, and it was true enough.

She smelled faintly of alcohol, too, but it was covered by her perfume, and that particular scent made Drew’s heart start beating twice as fast.

Was he ever going to stop responding to her physically from now on? It seemed hard to believe that, even if he met someone else who was amazing, that he’d be able to simply forget feeling this kind of magnetic attraction toward Emma.

‘And I went to the bar looking for you,’ she chided him, peering over at his phone screen. ‘What’re you up to?’

He took a deep breath, feeling that if he was going to tell Emma he was going to start dating, there was no way on Earth she was going to let him give up without giving it a real shot—so this was it, he was doing it.

‘Trying to write a Tinder profile—and failing abysmally,’ he said.

She gave a little gasp, and he wasn’t sure if it was genuine surprise, or if she was playing it up.

‘That’s wonderful!’ she exclaimed, her face lighting up as she leaned over to get a better look at what he’d been writing in his profile field. ‘You decided to start dating again?’

‘Well, pending my ability to craft a profile on here that doesn’t bore the pants off every single female in Boston

Emma giggled.

‘What are you talking about? You are not a boring guy, Mr Life-of-the-Bar.’

She took his phone from him, and started tapping away to edit what he’d written, and add something of her own. She was familiar enough with the Tinder system, of course. But the way she didn’t even seem to miss a beat on this, and the enthusiasm with which she attacked it, actually made Drew feel a strange sense of disappointment.

He concealed a sigh, and told himself it was his ridiculous crush making him feel somber that Emma would so readily help him find another woman.

She read her words as she typed, ‘Drew, 28, I’m the world’s best drinks mixer and the number of drunks who litter the floor of my bar are proof of that. But now I’m looking for the perfect mix of witty, sexy and sassy in a woman who can share my love of movies, music, theater, foreign travel and spend the rest of my life...’

Drew held up a palm to interrupt. ‘Uh... I don’t think I’m looking for someone to spend the rest of my life with,’ he said, but he was amused at what she’d attempted to write.

Emma’s brow creased with puzzlement. ‘You’re not?’

He shook his head. ‘Just... you know, a few dates. Perhaps a little occasional sexy time...’

‘*Sexy time?*’ she laughed. ‘Is that what the kids are calling it these days?’

She teased him about his complete lack of recent dating experience, but that was okay. It was actually fun doing this with her—crafting, debating his new Tinder profile, figuring out which photos to include.

‘Are you kidding me? That one looks kind of creepy.’

‘Seriously?’

‘You’re not looking at the camera—girls want you to look them straight in the eye, otherwise you don’t seem genuine.’

‘It’s just a photo.’

‘Was online dating even a thing the last time you were dating?’ Emma grinned. ‘The photo is the main thing in this profile. No one will even read a thing we just wrote if they don’t like your picture first.’

She even snuggled up to him on the sofa, and despite his crush—perhaps, if he was honest, because of it—it felt nice, and though he might have been feeling a little weird about Emma, it reminded him that she had no qualms about being close with him, about being his best friend.

‘Here, this one, it has to be this one.’

‘God, I look so goofy in that picture.’

‘Women like goofy. Trust me, it beats creepy. Oh no. Use this photo—much better.’

She showed him a picture taken while they’d been touring Venice the previous summer. It showed him a touch out of focus, and half his face was cut off. He never had been much good at taking selfies—most of his pictures from that vacation had been of Italy, and of Emma.

‘That one?’ he asked, bemused that she would think it worthwhile for use on Tinder.

‘At least include it among the photos on your profile,’ Emma said.

‘It cuts off half my face!’

She smirked. ‘Trust me: If you include this photo, you’ll give people something to ask you about if they ‘like’ you, and you’ve already liked

them. You know, if you give them a way to break the ice, they're more likely to break it.'

'You've done this before,' he teased her.

Emma laughed. 'Hey, you know when I went to the bar looking for you earlier? That guy was there.'

'Lachlan?'

She nodded, and smiled. 'We're going on a date, Wednesday night.'

'Wednesday?' He flashed his eyes, his tone teasing her for being unable to control herself when it came to men.

'Hey, you were the one who set me up with him,' she said, pouting.

'Uh-huh,' he said, and actually felt good about pushing her in Lachlan's direction. Was it because he secretly wanted to watch her with him? To repeat his peeping tom act, and see how she responded to the big Australian, how she seduced him, how he made her feel with his hands all over her, his kisses all over her, his cock inside her? 'I bet you'll have fun with him.'

'Are you going to be around, Wednesday night?' she asked.

He laughed. 'Why, you need a chaperone?'

She smiled. 'I think I can trust him, don't you? But... you know... if you were around, we could hang out before I left.'

Drew felt his manhood thickening up in his pants. That was strange, too. He'd hung out with Emma before her dates often enough in the past, it wasn't a big deal. But somehow, now his feelings for her had changed, there was a surprising thrill about the idea of being with her while she was preparing to go on a date. Preparing to seduce another guy.

'Well, I suppose I could,' he nodded.

He saw her smile, apparently grateful, but at the same time, he detected a faint nervousness in her face. 'Everything okay?' he asked her, brow furrowing slightly.

She added a touch of brightness to her smile, and actively dispelled any hint of anxiety. 'Of course,' she said. 'I just... you know, I think I really like him. Lachlan.'

'He is a nice guy,' Drew said, and he felt an odd element of fear creep into the mild excitement he felt about setting up Emma on a date with a member of his bar team. Was he, at last, feeling some kind of jealousy toward Lachlan? And yet, he still wanted Emma to date the guy—still wanted her to sleep with him.

His new feelings for her were fraught with contradictions and confusions, it seemed.

He would just have to manage them until he had his own date to focus on.

Chapter Four

The next few nights he was working, so although Emma did keep texting him to ask whether he'd found anyone nice on Tinder, he didn't get to see her or hang out with her.

He did, however, see Lachlan, while the Australian was working shifts on Monday and Tuesday.

To begin with, Lachlan thanked him for helping get him a date with Emma, and the way he talked to Drew made it feel a touch awkward, like he was getting a potential father-in-law's approval to ask for her hand in marriage.

During quieter moments in the bar, the Australian was asking him, with attempted insouciance, for background on his own relationship with Emma—how long they'd known each other, how they'd met, and so on. He never actually asked whether the two of them had ever dated, but it was clearly there between the lines of what he was asking.

Drew affected a relaxed manner he hoped would reassure Lachlan, telling him he'd known her since childhood, that she was like a sister to him. Almost, without expressly stating so, telling him that it was fine, they'd never dated, there was no possibility that he could step on Drew's toes.

It felt, strangely, as though he wasn't telling the guy the whole truth. It wasn't as though he ever told him a lie, but the way Drew felt about Emma at the present moment seemed like something he was very firmly hiding from the younger man.

And yet there was never any sense that he wanted Lachlan to change his mind about dating Emma. Quite the reverse, in fact: every time he laid eyes on the powerfully-built Australian, he got an odd little thrill, as he thought about the guy going out with Emma on a date, and how he'd make her feel.

Drew felt almost as excited about the upcoming date as Lachlan.

Once Lachlan seemed to have set in his mind exactly what the status was between Drew and Emma, he seemed more relaxed about talking about her with his boss. On Tuesday, he was almost bragging that she'd been texting him, that she'd already been quite flirty with him while they'd been discussing where to meet.

Drew wondered if he needed to warn Lachlan that Emma wasn't exactly the kind of person who dated anyone for very long. But it wasn't his place to interfere, it certainly wasn't for him to make any judgments about Emma, and Lachlan was a big enough boy to handle anything.

It was clear from the get-go that Lachlan was no shrinking violet—when he had sidestepped the question of Emma helping him get a summer internship to go straight for the goal of asking her out.

When it came to the end of play Tuesday night—or, technically, Wednesday morning—and they were shutting up the bar, Lachlan even asked Drew if he had any advice on dating Emma.

Drew laughed. 'As someone who has never dated her, I'm not sure I'm the expert witness you need,' he said.

'Yeah, but you know her better than anybody.'

Drew pondered for a brief moment, and tried to recall any complaints Emma had ever made about dates gone by. Then he said, 'I guess... just make sure you listen to her. You know? I think so many guys just try to

impress her by talking about themselves, and they don't really pay attention to what she's saying.'

'Good tip,' Lachlan said, genuinely grateful.

'Oh, and she really likes Star Trek.'

'Seriously?'

'Big Trekkie. She'll try to hide it from you, but... big brownie points if you can steer the conversation into the Trekiverse.'

'Oh, right,' Lachlan said, nodding, and clearly already thinking about how he would go about such a thing.

'You'll be okay,' Drew grinned. 'Seriously. Just treat her right, and you'll have nothing to worry about.'

When he eventually got to bed, Drew was feeling a buzz of anticipation for Emma's date. He still didn't entirely understand why he was so excited about her going out with Lachlan, but he couldn't deny that he was feeling that way about it. Even giving the guy advice about how to get in Emma's good books felt strangely thrilling.

Why would he feel so keyed up about hooking Emma up with another guy, if he had such a crush on her himself?

It was crazy. He put it down to the odd mix of fledgling attraction coupled with the fact that she had been his best friend for almost their entire lives.

He woke up around lunchtime to find text messages from both Emma and Lachlan.

Emma had texted to say that Lachlan would be picking her up from her apartment that evening, but that while they had agreed where to meet, they hadn't really discussed where they would be going on their date. And that meant she didn't know whether to dress formally, or informally. Should she wear a dress, or pants?

Lachlan had texted to ask Drew whether Emma would be most comfortable going to a pub or casual place like Chili's, or whether she was

the kind of person who would expect upscale finery like Ostra or Sorellina.

Drew could sense the nerves in both of their text messages, and in the case of Emma, it somewhat surprised him. She never normally needed guidance on the level of date she was going on, though she liked a second opinion when choosing between outfits she'd lined up.

He rolled over onto his back in the middle of the bed and sighed, thinking how easy it would be to recommend somewhere wildly wrong for Lachlan to take her, or to advise Emma to wear something massively inappropriate. If he'd had a normal crush on her, like a normal guy, he probably would have been jealous, and motivated to make their date go as awkwardly as possible. But he wanted Emma to like Lachlan, and he wanted Lachlan to succeed in attracting Emma.

He wanted Lachlan to end up in bed with her.

So did that make him some kind of creepy pervert?

He sighed again. He'd always wanted Emma's dates to go well in the past. Whenever she had wanted his advice, he had always given her the best advice he could. That hadn't changed. It was just that now he had a slightly unconventional sexual fascination with her dating.

Perhaps he'd just been single for too long. Once he got dating himself, everything would self-correct.

For now, however, he tried to think that if Emma had total choice on where to go for a first date, where would she want to go? Knowing Emma, she would probably most enjoy somewhere that wasn't too formal. And, considering how strangely nervous she was in going on a date with Lachlan, it might be better to give her an easy start to the date.

He texted Lachlan to suggest they go see a movie at the AMC by the Common, and then afterwards walk through the park to MJ O'Connors for food and drinks. Lachlan responded gratefully, stating that it sounded perfect.

Then Drew started typing a text to Emma, recommending she wear something nice, but definitely not formal, and that pants would be fine.

But then before he hit the send button, he stopped himself.

Thinking, I'm not Lachlan. I'm not the one going on a date with her. And I'm not trying to get her to become Lachlan's friend, I'm aiming to get her laid.

Instead, he texted:

Drew: I think you should wear something that's comfortable, but sexy as hell. ;-)

Well, that was about right.

Then Emma texted back:

Emma: Okay, comfortable or sexy? Can't have it both ways. And you never really said formal or informal. I guess if you're saying 'comfortable', you mean informal?

It made him think she was particularly nervous about this date, if she needed to clarify. He tried to answer her question:

Drew: Informal, yeah. But still sexy as hell.

Emma: What do you consider 'sexy as hell'?

Drew felt his heart rate pick up a little, and his manhood begin to thicken up—her text prompted him to start thinking of her wearing nothing but a pair of black thigh-high stockings and little black lace panties.

The fact was, that Emma could look sexy as hell in anything. But what would really get Lachlan going?

He was beginning to regret advising Lachlan to take Emma to the movies, even though she would no doubt enjoy that. Perhaps he should have suggested somewhere high-end, where she could have worn a killer dress that showed off some serious skin. She was going to feel out of place if she showed off too much skin at the movies.

He texted back: *Maybe some skinny jeans and a nice top?*

Emma replied: *You think jeans and a top is sexy as hell?*

She had added a puzzled-looking emoji at the end of her text message. Drew smiled. Was she being sassy? Drew felt a burst of adrenaline and arousal.

He texted back: *Okay, so try wearing jeans and a nice top, and something sexy underneath ;-)*

He felt a warmth he hadn't really felt before in texting Emma. This was flirting. This was a little beyond the usual best friend stuff. This wasn't merely giving her advice on which dress to wear, or which top to go for—this was talking about saucy underwear. They'd never quite gone that far before.

Emma texted back: *I think I could make that work.*

Drew resisted the temptation to text something else back, with any further suggestions about Emma's underwear, thinking that she would wonder if he'd been drinking or something. He didn't want her to think something odd was going on.

It was quite a hot thought, though, that Emma might decide to put on some kind of sexy lingerie under her date outfit because of something he had suggested. And Lachlan might peel off her comfortable jeans to discover it.

He took a cool shower to attempt to deflate his burgeoning feelings for Emma prior to her date with Lachlan.

Then, before a run to Whole Foods to stock up while he had a day off from work, he had a bite of lunch at Panera, where thoughts of Emma reminded him to check up on his Tinder account.

Over his broccoli cheddar soup, he found that nothing much had changed with the Tinder app except that he had a 'super like' from none other than Emma. He pressed the 'send message' button and tapped in, *Thanks for the Super Like! I guess I need to ask you out, then, since no one else has responded to my profile!*

Almost instantly, a message came back from Emma stating: *LOL. It's Tinder, silly. You need to actually like some people on there before anything happens!*

When he and Emma had worked on his profile, they'd done some flicking through photos of potential matches, weren't people supposed to be able to message you back when you'd 'liked' them on Tinder? He smiled, thinking back to when he'd tried online dating back in college. Things probably hadn't moved on very much in terms of the number of men using Tinder compared to the number of women. The average woman probably received countless 'likes' because there were so many more men casually flicking through Tinder than women.

But, it was kind of fun swiping through photos of possible matches, making instant decisions about people he'd never met, based on nothing other than their photos, and what they'd thought to write as their profile.

It was all easily forgettable, however, as Drew ran a few errands, and as the day proceeded, his thoughts soon returned to Emma's upcoming date.

Was he getting a little nervous about it because, for the first time in a while, she was going on a date with someone he knew? Somehow the stakes were raised—if it all went badly, Emma might be subsequently dissuaded from visiting Drew at work, because Lachlan would be there. He told himself it wouldn't be like that. And, Emma was far braver than that.

No, he knew deep down that the real reason for his nerves were the strange and complicated new feelings he had for Emma. Wanting her, but at the same time wanting her to be promiscuous.

He just didn't quite know how to think, how to act. Suppress all responses to her, that was the only thing he could think of to do. Avoid anything that might alter their relationship dynamic.

There just weren't any real cultural reference points for what he was going through. He'd seen thousands of movies in his lifetime, and he could think of those that featured highly-sexed female characters—but none in

which the male romantic lead wanted them because they slept with a lot of other guys. Even romantic movies about hookers invariably had men falling for them despite their wanton ways, not because of them.

He just had to try to ignore those feelings, he figured. He'd find someone else to date, and then he'd forget about these unhinged feelings for Emma.

OceanofPDF.com

Chapter Five

The light was on under Emma's door as Drew came home from running errands, indicating that she was home from work already.

When he let himself into her apartment, however, Carrie was there, too, slouched on the sofa watching *Reservoir Dogs* with a glass of white wine in one hand, smoldering cigarette in the other. Taking advantage of the fact that Emma's smoke detector did not work.

'You are kidding me, right? They're just sitting around a table talking about some god-awful Madonna track.'

'You have to watch more than this. It gets good.'

Carrie glanced up and gave him a little nod of greeting as he dropped down on the opposite corner of the couch. 'Hey buddy, are you a Tarantino fan?'

Drew shrugged. 'I'm a pre-*Kill Bill* Tarantino fan.'

'Hey, I thought you liked *Kill Bill*!' Emma called from the bedroom, and then she was there in the doorway, a large bright yellow bath towel wrapped around her from shins to armpits, freshly showered and looking delicious. She flashed him a welcoming smile, delighted that he had arrived.

‘Volume Two was better than Volume One,’ he said. ‘But he went really downhill after Jackie Brown.’

‘This one, though,’ Carrie said, wagging her cigarette toward the TV.

‘It’s good,’ Drew nodded. ‘It’s definitely good.’

‘*Thank you,*’ Emma said, as though Drew’s judgment was the final say, and then she disappeared into the bedroom.

‘But look at it,’ Carrie complained. ‘They’re just walking along, in slow motion. What, are we supposed to be impressed by that?’

‘This movie shaped 1990s style,’ Drew laughed. ‘Anyway, it’s just warming up. Wait until the credits are over.’

Then Emma was back, wearing a pair of gray skinny jeans and a white top with polka dots that showed off quite a lot of cleavage. ‘Okay, so this is the first option,’ she said.

Drew enjoyed being allowed to run his eyes all over her nearly as much as he did the smile she gave him when he did so. She almost looked as though she got a kick out of him checking her out in her date outfit. It was, no doubt, some kind of validation, building her confidence before a date—perhaps that was why she had always liked Drew to hang out with her prior to a date.

‘That one just screams Minnie Mouse,’ Carrie said, dabbing her cigarette out on the ashtray perched precariously on the sofa arm.

‘It does a little,’ Drew said, and Emma’s face dropped a touch.

‘Oh,’ she said. ‘I liked this one.’

‘It looks good on you,’ Drew said, knowing that it was often more important to go with how Emma felt about her outfit than how he did. ‘Maybe he’ll just see it as some kind of ironic twist on 1950s Disney-esque femininity.’

But Emma went back into the bedroom, the top already vetoed. Drew glanced over at Carrie and tried not to look as though he was enjoying himself too much.

Carrie brushed her thick, red curls out of her face and said, ‘So Emma tells me you’re checking out the Tinder crowd,’ she said, reaching for her bag to seek out another cigarette. ‘Messaged anyone yet?’

He grinned. ‘Somebody has to decide they like me, first, if I want to message them.’

‘You have to give it some time,’ Emma called from the bedroom. ‘And you have to spend some time liking people on there!’

Now she emerged from the bedroom wearing a pair of black jeans, which were slung low on the hips so that her short white t-shirt showed off some bewitching midriff, although her silver navel piercing was just hidden. Over the white t-shirt she wore a cut-off long-sleeve purple top.

‘Okay, I know he’s a younger guy,’ Carrie grinned, ‘but you think he’s expecting the college look?’

Drew was rather captivated by Emma’s exposed midriff—god, it was so *kissable*—but the look on her face suggested that Emma shared Carrie’s view of the outfit.

‘I’m sure Lachlan would be okay...’ Drew said, but Emma was already turning on her heel, and already unfastening the buttons on the purple top before ducking behind the bedroom door.

On screen, Mr Orange was lying in the back of a getaway car, soaked in blood, screaming after being shot in the stomach, as the driver of the car, Mr White, attempted to keep him from passing out.

Hey, just cancel that shit right now. You’re hurt. You’re hurt really fucking bad, but you ain’t dying.

Carrie said of the movie, ‘Okay... change of pace. I can get into that.’

Drew said, ‘You know, they made this movie for \$1.2 million. There wasn’t exactly a lot of budget for special effects.’

‘Hey, I don’t need special effects. Just, you know, a little more than a bunch of guys sitting around a table, blabbing about Madonna.’

Then Emma came out in a pair of blue jeans, with a white button-down shirt and a large, tan belt. It made her look five years older than the previous outfit, but Drew liked the way she had left enough of the buttons unfastened to offer a tantalizing glimpse of cleavage.

‘Much better,’ Carrie said.

‘Maybe with your charcoal jacket,’ Drew suggested.

Emma grinned at Drew. ‘I’ll just have to try something sexy underneath, huh?’

He felt himself warm up a few degrees as she referred to his text message from earlier that day. Nevertheless, Drew felt himself blushing faintly, and needed to distract himself from any sense that he would be thinking of Emma sexually. Had he gone too far with that text message? Had he revealed his stupid little crush?

‘You know Lachlan’s going to want you, no matter what you’re wearing?’ he said, trying to divert attention to her date.

She smiled sweetly at that, but there was a mischievous glint in her eye that he couldn’t quite interpret.

‘You know there’s plenty of wine in the fridge,’ she told him.

‘Uh... great.’

Carrie said, ‘You know he’s right, guys don’t give a damn what you wear, as long as it comes off easily.’

Emma laughed as she went back into the bedroom, calling out, ‘He’s going to feel unwanted if I don’t look as though I made the effort!’

For a while, Drew and Carrie were just watching the movie. Drew fetched himself a glass of wine—a nice, crisp Sauvignon blanc—hoping it would soften the jangling nerves inside him. Had he ever been this nervous before one of her dates? It was strange. But he wasn’t nervous to the point where he didn’t want her to go on the date. He definitely wanted her to go on the date.

‘The guy’s running down the street waving *a gun*, and that bystander yells at him, ‘*what the fuck is your problem, man*’?’ Carrie was chuckling at him. ‘Jesus. People wouldn’t really do that.’

‘You can pick holes in any movie,’ Drew said.

‘I’m just saying. Tarantino’s supposed to be good at dialog.’

‘Maybe the bystander didn’t see the gun until he’d already said that. I mean... we don’t know what kind of a day the guy was having before he was knocked over by a crazed bank robber on the run...’

Carrie said, ‘They should have an Oscar for Best Extra. I’d watch the fuckin’ entire ceremony if they had that.’

Then Emma appeared at her bedroom doorway again, and this time she was wearing nothing but a pink lacy bra and matching panties.

Drew stifled a gasp, and only just managed to maintain his neutral demeanor as an entirely platonic friend. She looked stunning, the underwear concealing precious little of her trim, perky figure.

‘Okay, so if I have to wear something sexy underneath...’ Emma said, her sparkling green eyes seeming to dwell on Drew’s, teasing him for his earlier text message, but at the same time examining every nuance of his response to seeing her like that. ‘These, or black ones instead?’

She held up a pair of lacy black panties as though they needed help picturing what black underwear might look like.

Breathing shallowly, Drew felt the gentle heat of another flush across his face and chest, and feared she could tell he was flustered. But God, she looked amazing in just her underwear. His crush ignited into blazing-hot flames inside. He had to force his eyes not to wander down to check out her breasts, or worse, between her legs.

Jesus, she was wearing almost nothing.

Carrie said dismissively, ‘Pink. Guys like that want us to be all girly on dates. Makes ‘em feel more manly.’

Drew felt glad of Carrie's comment for offering an ounce of distraction from his own inner turmoil. But then Emma's eyes were back on him.

'You think pink, as well?' And Drew felt the pressure to provide her with an answer.

'I say the black ones,' he said, though looking her straight in the eye was difficult while she was slowly turning around to show him her gorgeous rear view. He did his utmost to remain completely calm. It was almost hard to believe—was she really modeling her underwear for them like she would a dress?

Carrie said, 'Black would show through that shirt.'

Then Drew blurted out, 'Not if...' and then realized what he was saying, whereupon he felt his flush deepen as Emma smirked at what he was suggesting, and her gaze forced him to quietly finish his sentence, '...if you don't wear a bra.'

'*Naughty*,' Emma grinned, teasing Drew again, sensing his awkwardness, but seeming to delight in doing so. Could she tell something had changed in his feelings toward her? Then Emma put her hands behind her back, reaching for the clasp on her bra as though she was going to take it off right in front of them, and Drew caught his breath.

He looked away from her, as though to offer her some kind of privacy, but also to try to reset his own reactions toward her. Then, when he glanced back in Emma's direction to see whether she actually was topless, or had managed to put on the black bra instead, he saw that she wasn't even there anymore. Part of him was disappointed. Part of him was relieved that her teasing of him had stopped.

Carrie said, 'Okay, you can have this one. It's a good movie.'

On screen, Mr White and Mr Pink were arguing over whether there was a rat in their group, and whether one of them was the rat.

After a few moments, Emma re-emerged from the bedroom, and this time she was wearing her white shirt and jeans again, giving Drew an added

sense of relief that she wasn't going to flaunt herself before them in just a pair of black panties. That would have been a wonderful sight for him, of course, but the difficulty of hiding his desire would have been immense.

'What d'you think?' Emma said, presenting herself before them. She'd put on a little makeup, and tied her hair back in a tidy bun, and looked ready to go.

'Perfect,' Carrie said, before finishing up her wine.

'Lovely,' Drew nodded, affecting a tone he hoped would seem casual yet supportive.

'The bra doesn't really show through,' Emma said.

Carrie ducked behind her, checking out her rear view. 'It does a little at the back,' she said. 'But that won't matter.'

There was a buzz on the intercom, and Emma's demeanor suddenly switched into anxiety mode again, knowing that Lachlan was downstairs waiting for her. She pulled out her phone, and said into it, 'Hey. Yeah, my intercom doesn't work properly. I'll be down in a minute.'

Carrie was up on her feet, pulling on her coat, and Drew took a lead from her to get up from the couch to make an exit as well. But Emma said, 'Oh no, you guys can stay and watch the movie if you like.'

Drew felt a slight sense of déjà vu, and wondered if he could possibly get away with pretending to fall into a drunken sleep on her sofa again, to wake up when she returned with Lachlan. But it was probably stalker behavior to do that.

'No, I've got to get going,' Carrie said. 'As much as I've enjoyed this movie... it is on Netflix, right?'

'Uh-huh.'

Carrie nodded, 'I can see the rest another time. I have to go tidy my apartment since my folks are visiting tomorrow.'

Emma looked at Drew, and her expression silently told him it was okay if he wanted to stay and chill out there on her couch, since he was already

comfortable with a glass of wine. But he got a slight sense from her that she wanted him to stay.

Why would she want him to stay?

‘Hope it all goes well,’ he said, getting up, making it clear it was only logical for him to stroll across the hallway to his own apartment if he was going to be on his own anyway.

Emma smirked, and the moment was gone, so that he thought, perhaps, he had imagined her seeming to want him to stay and hang out in her apartment until her return.

‘You won’t even tell me where he’s taking me?’ she said.

‘You’ll have fun,’ he promised her, and as soon as he was out the door, he instantly regretted his decision not to stay in her apartment and hide like the creepiest peeping tom there was.

Chapter Six

*I*t had never been an issue before. Emma went out on her date, and it wasn't a big deal for Drew. Depending on who was around, he might head out for drinks with their other friends, chill in his apartment with Carrie or Ray and a nice bottle of wine. Or, if he was on his own, he might find a movie to watch at the theater, or stay home and order a delivery of some extravagant array of Chinese or Thai cuisine.

Tonight, for the first time, Emma's date did seem like a big deal. He couldn't stop thinking about it. She was out on a date with Lachlan.

Tonight, nobody was around. Ray was on a date himself, Fiona and Denny were doing couple things. Sharon was with friends, Jess at her roommate's birthday party. Drew knocked around his apartment for a while, ate a bite of supper, scanned the listings for movies at the nearby Regal. He could not stop thinking about Emma and her date.

The thing was, his newly-discovered crush had somehow transformed their relationship, even though Emma, herself, probably had no idea about it at all. Somehow, for Drew, he felt a much stronger connection to her—a possession that he knew he did not really have. A romantic bond.

And that made sitting at home, while she was out on a date with Lachlan, a big deal.

That's not to say it was entirely a bad thing—it wasn't that he was jealous, he didn't feel bitter that Emma would so readily go out with Lachlan, while Drew himself was totally confused about how he felt about her. He did feel that strange buzz, a thrill that was clearly at least part sexual, that Emma was out on a date, that she was probably excited, flirting away all evening, gradually progressing to the point where she might kiss him, and she might even invite him into her bed.

But at the same time, he felt oddly vulnerable. As though he was throwing away the chance to be with Emma himself. Even though she wasn't the type to commit to a long-term relationship, Lachlan wasn't quite the normal type of guy she dated. Sure, he was a buff alpha-male with plenty of self-confidence and, doubtless, no reluctance when it came to jumping into bed. But he was also a nice guy, gentlemanly, and perhaps more significantly than anything, he was somebody they knew beyond Tinder.

Anyway, after entirely failing to chill out on the couch in front of Netflix, Drew decided to drop everything and just go into work. At least making cocktails would give him something to focus on, and being around people might take his mind off Emma.

It might not have been his shift that evening, but his presence there didn't raise an eyebrow, and he could fit into the usual routine easily.

It was actually relatively busy for a Wednesday night, which came as some relief to Drew, diverting his mind completely from the matter of Emma and Lachlan.

That was, right up until Emma and Lachlan walked into the bar.

Drew felt a jolt of nervous energy shoot through his chest as he recognized her, walking in with her arm hooked into that of Lachlan's, who towered over her wearing a nice shirt and a pair of smart black jeans.

Neither of them looked over toward the bar, they seemed totally absorbed in each other as they found one of the few empty booths in the

place, and started perusing the cocktail menu. Emma looked sensational, though Drew knew his growing obsession with her was making him respond to her more intensely than usual. She removed her dark jacket, and Drew saw that Carrie had been right, her black bra did show, slightly, through her white shirt. It was kind of sexy, though.

As was the sight of her smiling and giggling and flirting with Lachlan.

Drew was quite surprised how much it affected him, watching her so obviously turning on the charm for Lachlan, flashing him sweet, suggestive smiles, toying with her hair as though trying to make sure he never stopped noticing her.

And Lachlan seemed all puffed up like a peacock, sitting with his back straight as though to emphasize his height, the powerful frame of his body, while he plied her with plenty of smiles, and plenty of eye contact.

Was he going to fuck her tonight?

Jesus. Drew felt a flush of heat as he stood there at the bar mixing a cosmopolitan for a hipster at the end of the bar. Was he getting a god damn erection just from watching Emma flirting with another guy?

He felt embarrassed by it, and his paranoia made him certain that Emma would figure out his weird secret if she laid eyes on him, so after serving his current customers, he quietly moved up to the other end of the bar.

‘Hey, mate,’ came the familiar voice.

Drew turned around to find Lachlan standing in front of him, waiting to order some drinks. He groaned silently inside.

‘Hey!’ he said, smiling in an attempt to conceal his feelings. ‘What are you doing here? I thought you were planning on going to MJ O’Connor’s?’

‘Oh, we were there for a bit,’ Lachlan nodded. ‘But it was really heaving. We couldn’t get a seat in the place.’

‘What can I get you?’

‘Uh... Sam Adams...and a French 75, I guess.’

Drew felt his ears burn at hearing her date ordering her usual cocktail.

‘So you knew there’d be plenty of seats here, huh?’ Drew laughed.

‘It’s usually pretty quiet on a Wednesday night,’ Lachlan grinned.

‘Yeah,’ Drew nodded, looking around at the lively atmosphere in the place. ‘I’m guessing the college kids are on spring break now, or soon enough. So... everything going well with the lovely Emma?’

Drew felt his heart skip a beat just to mention her name, but there was no way he could have avoided asking about the date. It was the elephant in the room for Lachlan and himself.

‘Perfect,’ Lachlan said with a broad grin. ‘She was really happy about going to see a movie—she said guys usually try to impress her with some fancy restaurant or other on a first date, but she’d always prefer go catch a movie.’

Drew felt a little warmth blossoming inside his chest, prompted by Lachlan’s air of gratitude for his recommendation for where to take Emma on their first date.

‘O’Connor’s would have been perfect, too, except that it was so rammed full of people,’ Lachlan added, as Drew slid the drinks over to him.

‘Hey, you should take her to Storyville when you’re done here,’ Drew said, feeling that odd conflict between the part of him that wanted Lachlan to succeed in getting Emma into bed, and the part of him that wanted Emma for himself.

‘Oh, right, dancing, huh?’ Lachlan nodded. ‘She’ll like that?’

Drew laughed, ‘Guaranteed.’

‘Thanks,’ Lachlan said.

‘Hey,’ Drew said as Lachlan was walking away. ‘Don’t tell Emma I’m here, okay? I don’t want her to feel like I’m... you know... like some kind of chaperone.’

‘Done,’ Lachlan agreed.

As the big Australian headed back to Emma, Drew kept his head down, relatively, and plied his trade at the far end of the bar. He couldn't keep from stealing brief glances toward Emma and Drew, however. Why was it such a thrill?

But then, half an hour later, when his guard was down, he was cutting lemon slices when her voice suddenly made him jump.

'I knew you were here,' she said, offering a smile that nearly melted his soul.

He looked up to see her there, looking devastatingly pretty, even in clothes that were not particularly revealing, although he noticed a couple more buttons on her shirt had become unfastened, and he could look down and take a heart-stopping glimpse of cleavage, wrapped in her lacy black bra.

'You're the only one who can make my cocktail as well as that,' she said, with a flirty smirk he'd never seen her direct at him before. Her eyes accused him of deliberately hiding away from her.

Was she purposefully standing at the bar in such a way that he could see down her shirt?

'Hey, I've been here all night,' he grinned, trying to hide his shock at seeing her like this, in the middle of her date.

'I'll have another, please,' she said, pushing her glass forward. 'And I guess he'll have another beer.'

'How's it all going?' Drew asked, as he started to pull another pint of Sam Adams.

'Pretty good,' she smiled, but seemed to be trying to figure Drew out, as though to suss out how much she should tell him about the date.

'Good movie?'

'Uh-huh. Although... did you tell Lachlan I'm into Star Trek?' Emma flashed her eyes at him, and the corners of her pretty mouth curled up in a wry grin. Busted.

Drew laughed. 'I might have... mentioned something...'

She gave a mock groan and a big eye-roll. 'He's been trying to get us talking about it all night,' she complained. 'And I've been pretty diplomatic about shifting the conversation back away from it, but you know... he's been persistent.'

'Poor guy, he's trying really hard,' Drew said, amused that Lachlan had really been hanging on his every word as he had advised the guy about dating Emma.

'You're so cruel,' Emma said, though her eyes didn't quite align with her chiding remark—as though in reality, she was more delighted that Drew had been advising Lachlan on what to do on a date with her than annoyed that he had dropped in some bad info.

'You like him, though?' Drew asked, and felt a surge of heat envelop his heart, along with a touch of embarrassment because he shouldn't have been so interested in her date.

'Yes, I do,' she said, giving him that slightly puzzled look, as though she couldn't work out why he would be so interested in her date with another guy.

'Great. Well, I happen to know he rather likes you too,' he said, feeling himself flush as he said it.

'He does?' she flashed her eyes at Drew. 'Maybe I should just take him home, then.'

She flashed him another smile, this one said she couldn't figure out why Drew was so keen on her being with Lachlan, but she was going to tease him anyway.

'Go, go!' Drew laughed. 'He's going to start worrying about you.'

She smirked and swept away from the bar, knowing that Drew was watching her every step of the way back. Then, when she was back at her table, handing Lachlan his beer, she sat facing the bar, and glanced over at Drew.

I know you're watching me, her sparkling eyes said, and *I love it*.

The look she gave him was so knowing, and somehow so dark and so wicked, that Drew felt his insides freeze, and the overwhelming sense he got was that perhaps, when he'd been accidentally trapped in her apartment after she'd brought Vincent home, Emma *had seen him there after all*.

She'd seen him, and she hadn't even hesitated for a moment in continuing to seduce Vincent.

Had Emma known Drew was watching them? Had Emma quietly enjoyed knowing that Drew was watching her as she fucked that guy?

The thought was earth-shattering for Drew, though he could not confirm whether it was true or not. If she had seen him, did she know that he had stayed to watch the entire performance until they'd both climaxed? Did she know that he'd really been watching her, enjoying every minute of seeing her like that, with Vincent?

No, surely she would have said something. She would have asked him why he'd been there, why he hadn't just apologized and walked away. If she'd known he was there, she would have shut the bedroom door, right?

But there had been a certain tension in the air between him and Emma ever since then. He'd assumed it had only been his own attitude toward their friendship that had altered, however.

Drew watched Emma, and couldn't accept that she had seen him that night, that she had known he was watching her.

But there was no doubting that tonight, she was aware that Drew couldn't quite take his eyes away from her and Lachlan's table. That unless he was actively mixing a cocktail or taking an order, he couldn't help flicking his gaze back toward them.

She knew he was watching her smiling and laughing and flirting with her date. She knew he noticed her sitting up straight to emphasize her breasts, toying with the ends of her hair as she discussed something trivial

with her date, biting her lower lip gently as though unable to keep from thinking about bedding him.

She knew he saw her casually stroking her forearm, and occasionally even laying a hand daintily on her date's.

Did she sense that he had a crush on her?

At one point, she looked over at Drew, and seemed almost to be amused that he had a crush on her, after they'd been best friends for so very long. Amused, intrigued, and *not entirely against the idea*.

And now, Emma knew Drew was watching as she slowly leaned into Lachlan, touched his chin with one finger, then laid her soft lips on his.

Drew caught his breath as he saw her kiss the big Australian, and flames seemed to flare up inside his chest. His manhood thickened up again inside his pants, and he felt perspiration prickling the skin around his hairline.

Jesus.

How was it that when she was with this other man, particularly when she kissed him, Drew noticed her physical beauty so much more? His eyes were drawn to the elegant, refined lines of her jaw, her cheeks, the rise of her chest and the fullness of her breasts. His gaze took in the softness of her neck, the faint goosebumps on her upper chest, the pleasing shape of her shoulders.

Back in college, when he'd dated properly, he remembered being jealous when Kayla, or Lauren, or Brittany, had received any interest from other guys. Yet with Emma, it was nothing like that.

Was it because she wasn't really his?

No. The fact was, he felt like this because she suddenly felt like his. His crush had made him feel some form of possession over her. That was what a crush did. When he'd had a crush on Christina Aguilera as a kid, it had felt like she was his.

And yet in those days, he couldn't even deal with the thought of Christina having an actual boyfriend.

Now, he was watching Emma making out with Lachlan across a crowded room, and he felt all giddy with excitement that they might disappear off into the night, find one or other of their apartments and then slip into bed for a night of raw, red-hot sex.

He wanted Emma to ride Lachlan until they were both exhausted. The thought of it actually happening that night made Drew want her more.

He had to stop himself from staring at them, pull his thoughts away from the two of them making out like horny teenagers. A group of college students were yelling at him, since he had zoned out in the middle of making them a huge batch of margaritas. He returned his attention to the work, and tried to ignore the red-hot date going on at the back of the bar.

When there was a quiet moment, since it was getting quite late by now, he even found himself pulling up his phone to check Tinder for any kind of responses from women he'd 'liked'. There wasn't anything at all. Perhaps he needed to try an old-style dating service. Match, or eHarmony or something like that.

'You found anyone yet?'

He looked up sharply to see her there, leaning on the bar, two empty glasses in front of her. He felt his insides melt at the sight of her smile, and her big, green eyes.

'It's early days,' he said, trying to hide his surprise that she could tell so easily what he had been doing while waiting for the next order.

She flashed her eyes, leaned over and plucked the phone from his clutches. As she reached toward him, he couldn't help but catch a glimpse down her shirt, seeing a hint of her gorgeous breasts press against the bar as she grabbed at his phone. *He was going to Hell, there could be no doubt.*

'You need to like some of them,' she insisted, and started swiping her thumb around his screen, until he could see that she was flicking through pictures of women in their mid- to late-twenties, swiping this way or that as

she did so. Saying, 'Well, she's cute.' Or, 'She's not.' Or, 'She's okay.' Or, 'Hey, this one's nice.'

Drew felt a mild sense of panic, thinking, God, what if all these women come back to him wanting a date?

Realizing that he really didn't know what he was doing when it came to Tinder.

'Aren't I supposed to read their profiles?' he asked, laughing to conceal his concern.

'You read their profiles if any of them come back to message you,' she said, entirely relaxed about how many dozens of women she was currently judging purely on their looks.

'What if some of them you've rejected have winning personalities?'

She smirked. 'They won't know you've passed on them,' she said. 'Then you can focus on getting someone cute to sleep with.'

'Ouch,' he said. Then, after a pause in which her feverishly fast thumb had alerted about a gazillion local women that he found them attractive, he said, 'What if we're gauging my level a little... high... right now...?'

Emma gave him a cutting look. 'You do not need to lower your standards, Mister,' she said, then ran her eyes all over him in a way he found strangely thrilling. 'You're a hottie, you know that?'

'Uh... thanks?'

A moment later, he attempted to distract her from her lightning-quick assessment of half the single women in New England. 'Hey... did you want another drink or something?'

She looked up, and lowered the phone as she took a second to remember what she'd come up to the bar for in the first place. 'Uh... no, I was just going to say... Lachlan wants to take me to Storyville. I just wondered if you wanted to... you know... come with us?'

'On your date?' Drew grinned.

She shrugged, as though to say it *wouldn't be so bad, you joining our date*. 'We'd only be dancing... drinking...' she said, but raised an eyebrow that suggested she'd end up dragging Lachlan to a shady corner for another make-out session.

'I would have to wait until closing,' he said, looking at his watch. Of course, in truth, he could have left Juno's at any point he wanted to, because he wasn't technically on duty that night, and the way things were going, with most of the student crowd seemingly heading for the nightclubs just now, he wasn't needed here.

But while he would have enjoyed watching Emma dancing with Lachlan, and certainly would have got dark thrills from seeing them in the shadows, making out some more, he worried that if he went with them, their date would descend into a simple night out for a bunch of friends. And instead, he wanted to steer them into bed.

The best chance of doing that would be to get Emma dancing with Lachlan alone.

'Well, maybe you could join us later?' she suggested.

'I'd love to... I just think I'll be pretty tired when we've shut this place up for the night.'

She sighed, and gave a little nod of acceptance.

'Well, okay, then,' she said. Then, taking a step back from the bar, added, 'You let me know if any of them messages you.'

'I will.'

'Make sure you do!' She grinned, revealing her enjoyment at helping him with his dating life. Leaving him thinking, was it a good thing if she was trying to encourage him in the whole dating thing?

It was 2am by the time he got away from the bar, and he really did feel too tired to go chasing Emma and Lachlan to a nightclub up by Copley Square.

But when he got home, he found himself waiting up, wondering how things were going between Emma and Lachlan. Perhaps, as 3am approached, he was hoping he might hear them returning from their date.

However, there was nothing to be heard.

He felt quite disappointed.

OceanofPDF.com

Chapter Seven

Thursday, things were quiet at Juno's Bar & Grill. Drew could sit in one of the booths at the back, and sift through a stack of applications for a new marketing manager he wanted to try to help raise the profile of the place.

Mid-afternoon, Lachlan arrived for his late shift, and was certainly bright and breezy, high-fiving fellow bartender Donnie, who was keen to hear how the hot date went.

'Stellar, mate. And I mean totally,' was the verdict.

'So you like her?'

'God, yeah. Seeing her again tomorrow night.'

'*Damn*, you move quick, bro.'

'She's worth it. *Gorgeous*, mate.'

Drew felt his stomach being squeezed. It seemed strange that Lachlan was talking about Emma –*his* Emma. He felt oddly proud that somebody like Lachlan would consider his Emma gorgeous, and he felt a gentle thrill that he'd been on a date with her, and that he was apparently already planning on a second date with her.

And yet at the same time, he wasn't entirely comfortable with the thought of Lachlan going on a second date with her.

Was this jealousy? But it wasn't a sharp pain, it wasn't a burning anger. It was more like a gentle hint of insecurity. He was worried Emma would like Lachlan too much. She'd never shown any signs of wanting a long-term relationship, but suddenly Drew was worried that there was a first time for everything, and Lachlan would end up being her first time.

He wanted the guy to sleep with Emma, but he didn't want Emma to fall for him.

Lachlan didn't notice that Drew was there until he got behind the bar. When he did see his boss over there in the booth, he smiled, and came over. Drew quite liked the gratitude emblazoned all over the big Australian's face.

'How's it going?' Drew grinned knowingly.

'Stoked, mate,' Lachlan said.

'So it went well?'

'Oh yeah. She's incredible.' Drew felt his heart flutter at Lachlan's judgment of her.

He said, 'So you guys went dancing?'

'Yeah, top place. Thanks for the reco.'

'You took her back to your place after?' Drew asked, and as soon as he said it, felt a touch awkward for prying. He was the guy's boss. And Emma's friend.

But Lachlan just laughed, 'One step at a time, right? I'm seeing her again on Friday—tomorrow—though.'

Drew was surprised. So the two of them hadn't slept together?

He wasn't sure whether to be disappointed or not. As far as his weird sexual fascination with Emma having sex was concerned, it was a disappointment to hear that she'd gone without. But, there was the prospect of a second date to keep the excitement building.

However, the whole waiting until the second date was troubling.

He couldn't remember the last time Emma went on a date, even a first date, and didn't end up sleeping with the guy. She didn't believe in waiting around. Either she'd had a terrible time with Lachlan—which Drew knew wasn't the case, since she hadn't texted Drew to help her escape the date early, and she had agreed to a second date soon after the first—or else, maybe she was deliberately taking things more slowly because she wanted something more than just a fling with Lachlan.

That fueled Drew's sense of insecurity.

'So where you going for your second date?' he asked, trying to hide any sense of concern.

Lachlan grinned. 'Her choice, mate. Said she'd surprise me,' he said, raising his eyebrows.

'Sounds good,' Drew laughed, though deep down he was squirming. Surely this guy wasn't going to charm Emma into some kind of commitment thing?

Lachlan went back to work, and Drew managed to act as though he wasn't giving the guy's date with Emma another thought. As things started getting busier in the afternoon, he helped with the service, and a little in the kitchen, but by the time he headed home in the early evening, he was definitely feeling some anxiety about Emma and Lachlan.

Why couldn't he just relax, and enjoy the knowledge that she was building up to some killer sex with the guy?

And what did he have to fear if Emma tried a long-term relationship with Lachlan? It might make her happy. And did Drew want to date her instead? Sure, he had a crush on her, but part of it was about the fact that she was sleeping with other guys.

Back home, he was letting himself into his apartment when he heard a familiar giggle, and looked up to find Emma walking back from the elevator with Carrie beside her. The two of them were wearing workout clothes, which suggested they'd been up in the gym, but Emma was the

only one who looked as though she'd actually been working out, her hair slightly damp and her skin a little shiny from perspiration, her face and chest a little flushed.

'Hey! You want to hang out?' Emma said as she laid eyes on him, offering him a pretty smile.

'Sure,' he said, trying not to look as though he was checking out the sight of her trim thighs in her skin-tight, gray leggings. He concealed his gawping by glancing at Carrie, saying, 'Hey, Carrie.'

Carrie grinned. 'Dude, you need to ask Emma out before she gets totally entangled in Lachlan.'

Drew felt almost as though she had just shoved her hand into his stomach and then reached up to wrench his heart out through the bloody hole. His jaw dropped.

How did she know he was worried about that?

Then after a momentary lapse of control, he tried to seem puzzled, rather than horrified. As though Carrie had said something that made absolutely no sense at all.

'What?' Carrie said, getting defensive. 'Don't look at me. Ray told me you have a huge crush on Emma and you won't admit it.'

Emma laughed, but he couldn't see her reaction to that news, since she turned away from them to unlock her front door.

But Drew was quick to dismiss Carrie's gossip, saying, 'Ray's been smoking crack.'

'I don't know, he seemed fairly adamant,' Carrie said as they followed Emma inside, and Carrie immediately went for the fridge and the inevitable bottle of chilled white.

'Ray's never been entirely comfortable with the fact that I'm Emma's BFF,' Drew said, fishing three glasses out of the dishwasher. 'Everything he knows about heterosexual dating and romance, he got from *When Harry Met Sally*.'

Carrie slumped down on the couch, quoting the aforementioned movie, *‘Men and women can’t be friends. The sex part always gets in the way.’*

‘That’s what he thinks,’ Drew nodded, and took the armchair. Emma had disappeared into her bathroom to take a shower. But from the armchair, Drew noticed that he could see into the bathroom thanks to the positioning of Emma’s full-length mirror in the corner of her room. Or at least, he could see enough of the bathroom to catch Emma looking at herself in the bathroom mirror, and perhaps plucking a rogue eyebrow hair.

God, she looked good in those leggings. The t-shirt she had on was fairly loose, but *God bless whoever invented leggings.*

Drew said, ‘Of course, you’d think someone like Ray would see that the whole theory overlooks the fact that a fairly significant proportion of men do not find women sexually attractive.’

Carrie flicked on the TV, and said, ‘It was the eighties—all movies ignored diversity in the eighties. As far as Hollywood was concerned, there were only white, straight people.’

Drew glanced over toward the bedroom, and felt his heart skip a beat as he saw Emma peel off her t-shirt to reveal her nicely toned stomach and a pink sports bra. He caught his breath, oh dear Lord, she looked good. She turned to switch on the shower, and now he was looking at the sensational shape of her bottom, snug in those tight leggings.

‘Here it is, I told you,’ Carrie was saying, making Drew realize he’d missed something she’d said. She had found *When Harry Met Sally* on Netflix, and now put the movie on.

Drew sipped his wine, trying to look as though he was watching the TV screen instead of glancing off to the side to check out his unauthorized view of Emma.

‘God, I would have loved to be a teenager in the eighties,’ Carrie said as they watched Meg Ryan picking up Billy Crystal at the University of Chicago for a road trip to New York.

‘This part is set in the seventies,’ Drew said, trying to breathe normally even though he could see Emma waiting for the shower to warm up, still wearing her leggings and sports bra.

‘But most of the movie is set in the 80s, right?’

‘Late eighties.’

Oh, Lord. Emma tucked her thumbs into the waistband of her leggings and slowly tugged them down, exposing a hint of black underwear, and the pleasing bare flesh of a buttock and then her thighs. She turned slightly, and he saw both her cheeks, and the fact that she was wearing a thong. It took his breath away.

‘...You know, before the Internet. Before all that Instagram shit. Before influencers. Before all the hate that spews out of Washington...’

She peeled her leggings further down her legs, lifting one foot, and then the other to remove it, turning almost as though she knew the mirror was there in the corner of her bedroom, and she knew Drew could see. Oh God. Her pierced navel made her seem so wild, so sexy. He’d never particularly noticed it before, although he’d known for a long time that she had it—he’d seen her in a swimsuit often enough, when they vacationed together, though he hadn’t had a crush on her back then.

‘...and the hair. Jesus. My hair would have been fashionable back then...’

It seemed to take Emma an age to take her leggings off fully, as though she was teasing him with her strip. Then she was folding them, walking *out into the bedroom* to lay them on her bed, all the while giving him the most wonderful display in her sports bra and thong.

Then she slipped her thumbs into the waistband of her panties, and Drew thought she was about to peel those off as well—she was stretching the material as she looked at herself in the bathroom mirror, tugging it down slightly. Teasing, teasing, teasing...

Then she turned again, giving him a full frontal view—but then closed the bathroom door.

Drew was breathing heavily as his attention returned to the room in which he was sitting, to Carrie and the movie they were supposed to be watching. He had to suddenly stop himself from laboring so much in his breathing, in case Carrie suspected that something was up.

‘So how did her date with Lachlan go?’ Drew asked, trying to ask Carrie something that the Drew of Old might have asked, before his crush on Emma had developed. ‘Did she tell you yet?’

‘Well, she likes him,’ Carrie nodded. ‘But this is why you need to get in there.’

Drew rolled his eyes. ‘Carrie, she’s my friend. Ever since I’ve known you...’

‘Come on—don’t you think Ray’s got a point? You two are so good together.’

‘Because we’re friends.’

‘You don’t think you can be friends and in love?’

‘We’re not in love,’ he said, but felt himself flush as he said those words. Jesus, was he in love with Emma? No, he couldn’t be. Not when he was so fixated on her sleeping with other men.

‘She’s really into that Lachlan guy,’ Carrie warned.

‘That’s great, isn’t it? So...did she... go back to his place last night?’

Carrie shook her head and grinned, waggling her eyebrows suggestively. ‘No, and she didn’t bring him back here, either. They just had a nice, romantic smooch, and then bade farewell until the next time.’ She spoke as though attempting to perform a Shakespeare prologue with as much melodrama as she could muster.

‘Well, that’s nice,’ Drew said, attempting to ignore the butterflies fluttering in his stomach.

‘No, it’s *not nice*,’ Carrie declared. ‘Jesus, she never kisses someone goodnight and then waits until the second date to sleep with him. She really likes this one.’

‘That’s good,’ Drew insisted. Carrie sighed, and Drew said, ‘Jesus, you’re as bad as Ray.’

‘Ray knows *you*. He’s been your roommate for five years.’

Drew wondered what Carrie and Ray would do if he revealed that, yes, he did have a crush on Emma. Would the two of them confront her, and demand that she stop seeing Lachlan, and go on a date with Drew instead? The whole thing was ridiculous. Drew didn’t want to date Emma, not really. He wanted her to date someone else. And then come home and share all the details as Drew gave her a second, and maybe a third orgasm of the night.

God, he was turning into a complete pervert.

For a while, he kept quiet and they just watched the movie.

When Emma emerged from the bathroom, she was wearing a loose white t-shirt and sweatpants—not particularly revealing.

‘So the date went well?’ Drew asked her as she found a spot on the sofa next to Carrie. Carrie flashed him a look, which he attempted to avoid, but which he was aware was attempting to get him to somehow do something to put a block on Emma’s second date with Lachlan.

‘Very well,’ Emma said with a beatific smile. ‘*And* I’m seeing him tomorrow night, too.’

‘Second date, huh?’ Drew nodded, and gave Carrie a little glare that attempted to warn her against dwelling on Ray’s claims about him having a crush on Emma. ‘That was quick.’

‘Well... you know, he’s nice,’ she said, and gently blushed, then looked over at Drew to see how he was responding to what she’d said.

‘He is a nice guy,’ Drew nodded, trying to maintain an air of normality, to reassure her that nothing had changed, he was still her best friend. ‘Well, it’s great you two are getting along.’

She smiled. ‘You know, with him... I think maybe I could try not having just a one night stand.’

‘Well, I think you’re definitely past having a one night stand—you’re already going on a second date.’

‘And you didn’t sleep with him on the first date,’ Carrie pointed out, and then realized, too late, that she’d been a little crude. And yet in the past, when Emma had dated a different guy every week, it wouldn’t have seemed crude.

‘We’re taking things steadily,’ Emma said, blushing a little deeper, and now consciously looked over at Drew, to see how he registered this information.

Was she seeking her best friend’s approval for her new relationship, or was she trying to see if Drew was going to get jealous about her trying for a long-term relationship? It was an odd look.

There was an awkward moment, and then everybody was just watching the movie, as though it was the easy way out of their clunking conversation.

On screen, Harry and Sally were discussing *Casablanca*, with Sally declaring that she would never want to spend her life married to a man who runs a bar.

Harry asked her, ‘*You’d rather have a passionless marriage –*

— and be First Lady of Czechoslovakia —’ Sally interrupted.

‘— than live with the man you’ve had the greatest sex of your life with, just because he owns a bar and that’s all he does?’

Carrie giggled. ‘Hey, *you* own a bar, Drew, huh?’

‘*I manage* a bar,’ he corrected her.

The redhead smiled, and as though trying to commiserate with him for his miserable love life, said, ‘Well, if it was me, I would always go for the guy who runs a bar.’

‘I know one who’s available,’ Emma said in a sing-song voice.

Drew and Carrie looked at each other, semi-stunned for a moment. Then they all broke into laughter.

‘You had any luck with Tinder yet?’ Emma asked Drew.

He sighed. ‘So today, I’m flicking through more of those photos. I ‘like’ some of them. And I get a message from someone: ‘what’s up’.’

‘Great!’ Emma grinned. ‘Is she hot? Was it that blonde one with the big, green eyes? I liked the look of her...’

‘I don’t know... I’m trying to look for her profile, but I’m not hitting the right button, or something. I try to write back, ‘Hey, how are you? How are things with you?’ and she’s like, ‘my roommate thinks you’re hot’. What are you supposed to say to that?’

‘Ask if her roommate’s hot?’ Carrie suggested.

‘I said, ‘That’s nice. So what kind of movies d’you like?’ and she’s, like, ‘OMG’, and then terminates the whole messaging thing.’

Emma laughed, ‘You can’t be put off just because some psycho messaged you.’

‘I don’t know,’ he shrugged, ‘I feel so awkward about it. Like, I don’t know what the protocol is.’

‘Protocol?’

‘I don’t know what you’re supposed to say when you message someone, what you’re supposed to say when someone messages you, what you’re supposed to do. How long until you can say, you feel like meeting up for coffee?’

Emma and Carrie tried to answer at the same time, only Carrie said, ‘Two days’, while Emma said, ‘Ten minutes?’ They looked at each other and cracked up.

Then Emma said to him seriously, ‘You probably just need... you know... to warm up a little. You haven’t dated anyone for so long...’ She looked at him with pity in her eyes, but also, somehow, admiration.

Drew sighed. Carrie gave him another look, this time one that said quite clearly, *what do I have to spell it out? You need to date Emma.*

Emma said, 'You know, I might know someone at work who's single? And she's nice. And cute. Maybe you just need to get back into practice...'

Drew nodded, but he felt strangely disappointed that Emma would want him to date someone else. He sighed, checked himself, told himself to stop being an idiot and just forget about Emma. Forget about Emma and the whole thing about watching her.

'So, Lachlan has a big cock?' Carrie said, not so much breaking the ice as vaporizing it all instantly.

'Carrie!' Emma laughed.

'Who am I kidding?' Carrie said wryly. 'Of course he has a big cock, otherwise you wouldn't be going on a second date.'

Even if he was trying not to think about it too much, it was kind of fun to chat about Emma's date like that.

Chapter Eight

Friday night. He had to pull a few strings, and switch around a few shifts, so that he could be sure to drop by Emma's apartment just as she was getting ready for her second date with Lachlan. The main issue was that Lachlan wasn't available for a shift, either, since he was the one going on the date.

But here he was, getting back home at just about the right time.

He told himself he wanted to see her before her date so that he could adjust to the mindset of Emma actually pursuing a proper relationship with someone—so that he could reassure her, and himself, that it was a great idea. He told himself it was all about moving on from that ridiculous crush he had on her. Trying to be mature.

There was no future in obsessing over one moment when he accidentally witnessed Emma having sex.

At the same time, he couldn't shake the bubbling sense of excitement under his skin as he thought about her getting ready for her date. And how the last time, she had teased him by showing off her underwear.

Well, he could be a secret pervert for a little while longer. Right up until he brought his own dating life back from the dead.

He turned into Emma's apartment, instead of his own, and assumed that Carrie, or Fiona, or Jess, or perhaps even all of those guys, would already

be there with Emma, helping her figure out what to wear for the date.

But the apartment was empty, and very quiet, as he let himself in.

‘Hey!’ Emma emerged from the bedroom dressed in a pale pink satin bathrobe, clearly delighted that he had dropped by.

‘How’s it going?’

‘Good,’ she smiled, and produced two wine glasses and a large bottle of red wine. ‘Now I am, anyway.’

‘Any of the others dropping by before your date?’ he asked.

‘I don’t think so,’ Emma said, offering him a glass of red, before taking a large gulp of her own.

‘Oh,’ he said, feeling suddenly a little vulnerable on his own. Like a tightrope walker going out on a high wire without any kind of a safety net. Of course, there had been plenty of times in the past when it had been just Drew hanging out with Emma before one of her dates, passing judgment on her outfits, discussing expectations for her date, and what she’d learned about the guy before it had come to him asking her out. But now that he had discovered his crush on Emma, having Carrie or someone else around while Emma tried on various clothes to model for him seemed like a good way to hide his growing desire for her.

‘Everything okay?’

‘Fine,’ Drew said, trying to act relaxed, like there was nothing out of sorts whatsoever. ‘This is good wine,’ he noted.

She smiled, and said, ‘I thought I might need to take the edge off my nerves before tonight.’

‘Nerves?’ he grinned as he found his way to the armchair. ‘I would never have thought you’d be nervous before a date.’

‘I *like* him,’ she said, before taking another sip of wine.

‘Well, you have nothing to be afraid of. You know he likes you, too.’

She nodded, but gave him a kind of look that suggested it wasn’t Lachlan she was nervous about—and that gave Drew a little jolt of surprise.

Then she said, ‘No, you’re right, I shouldn’t be nervous. Hey—I bought a whole load of new outfits. I have no idea what to wear.’

Drew laughed. ‘You’re going to have to tell me where you’re taking him. It’s no good otherwise. And he has no idea where you’re going.’

‘We’re having dinner at Top of the Hub,’ she said as she headed into the bedroom, referring to the restaurant at the top of the Prudential Tower, the second tallest building in Boston.

‘Very nice.’

Drew flipped on the TV—at least if none of the others were going to be here to keep them company, he could make it look as though he was just as interested in something on Netflix as he was on Emma modeling various dresses. It was the only way he could think of to soften his obvious need to check her out, to hide his attraction toward her.

‘Have you been there before?’ she called out from the bedroom.

‘No, but I hear it’s a very romantic place.’

When she came out, she was wearing a green dress that was vaguely cute in a 1950s diner uniform kind of way. The shoulders were too square, the material too flat and formless, though it showed a nice amount of her shapely thighs, and had a neckline that plunged sufficiently to show a nice amount of cleavage and even a small amount of her black bra—a glimpse of which gave the ensemble a naughty little frisson that might attract a little male attention while out on a date.

‘I probably should have gotten a size smaller,’ she said, before changing her mind, ‘Except then it would have been too short.’

‘I’m not convinced,’ he said. ‘It looks like a flight attendant forgot her shirt, but was told to work anyway.’

It was a bit of a thrill, to see her dressing up. Things had definitely changed since his crush had emerged. To catch that little glimpse of her cleavage. It made his heart start beating more quickly, and his manhood start thickening up as he sat there in the armchair.

Now, though, she stepped closer to him, her hands moving to her chest as she said, 'I think the top bit here, and the waist, could have been a bit more snug...'

As she said this, she pulled the dress a little more apart, giving him a better view of her cleavage and the black lacy bra she wore beneath. Very nice to see, but he was a little surprised at her doing that right in front of him.

Was she trying to provoke a reaction from him?

'Hey, I forgot the shoes,' she said, before retrieving some heavy black boots that made her about six inches taller.

He laughed. 'Now it just looks like you borrowed your dad's old shirt.'

She gave him a mock frown, 'Okay... next outfit.'

She went back into the bedroom to change, keeping the door almost closed while she did so.

Next came a white strappy dress, which, when she returned from the bedroom with it on, appeared to be attempting to evoke Marilyn Monroe's infamous subway grate scene in *The Seven Year Itch*. But Drew felt certain Marilyn's dress had never shown this much cleavage. Half of her breasts were visible.

It was hot as anything.

'I'm kind of obsessed with this dress,' Emma said, giving him a twirl so the hem of the dress flared out somewhat Marilyn-like. Drew's eyes naturally seemed to return to her cleavage area, though.

'Nice,' he said. 'Although... maybe a little bridal. Maybe even bridal lingerie.'

'You like it?' she grinned wickedly, and it felt strangely as though she was testing his heterosexuality, now that she knew about it.

'I like it...'

'It's quite revealing, but I quite like it. It's cute,' she said.

‘I just worry that... maybe it’s like showing up to your date with a wedding ring.’

Next up came a black dress which had a neckline that dropped almost down to Emma’s navel. She came back into the room with her hands over her breasts, self-conscious, although the black material did cover her nipples.

‘Okay... so...’ she said, acting awkwardly but also somewhat excitedly. ‘This dress is very revealing, huh?’

‘I’d say so.’

‘I think I’d need some kind of tape to keep this together,’ she said, yanking on the material to keep it in place. ‘I like it... it’s got cute little pockets...’

Drew found himself wondering what Lachlan might think of her wearing a dress like this—it was somewhat jaw-dropping.

‘You know he’s going to find it hard to keep looking you straight in the eye,’ he said.

‘Hard?’ she grinned.

‘Difficult. You know what I mean.’ He laughed, but he was almost meditating with deep breathing to try and keep his own hardness at bay just now. It was hot to think of Lachlan gawping at her all night in the dress, desperate to get her out of it.

‘I think I’d put a bra on under it,’ Emma said, and skipped out to do just that. The outfit did look a little more classy with her black lacy bra on, somehow, though classy in a very nightclub kind of way.

‘You like it better like this?’ she asked him, tugging her dress this way and that to test its fit.

‘Uh-huh,’ he said, finding it strange but gently thrilling that she was drawing his attention so much to her cleavage, wanting his opinion on it.

Emma paused a moment, tilted her hips, smiled at him, ‘Isn’t this fun?’ she said, as though she’d needed to convince herself more than him.

‘Yes, it is,’ he said, smiling back, though what she said seemed a little out of sorts. He felt the need to be honest with her, where he could.

She went back into the bedroom, and this time left the door open. She was looking at herself in the bathroom mirror again, still tugging on the black dress to see if she could get it to fit better.

‘You do like it, don’t you?’ she said. ‘Helping me with my outfits, I mean.’

Drew gazed through the open bedroom door—of course he could see her there in the bathroom, reflected in the full-length mirror in the corner of the bedroom. But he felt as though he shouldn’t reveal that he could.

‘Sure,’ he called back. ‘You know I like helping you.’

‘But do you... like what you see?’

He watched her slip the straps of the dress off her shoulders, and let it drop down to her waist to expose her black bra entirely. He caught his breath at such an enticing sight.

‘Of course,’ he called back again, thinking it was a funny time for her to get all self-conscious about her looks. She knew she already had Lachlan virtually eating out of her hand. What could she be worried about?

Then she looked straight at Drew, via the bedroom mirror. He nearly jumped out of his skin in surprise. She could see him watching her in that mirror. She must have known he was watching her the previous night, when she was changing out of her workout gear.

She must think him a complete pervert. A peeping tom.

But she smiled sweetly turning to face him, or at least the reflection of him, saying, ‘You know I love the way you look at me.’

He felt completely flustered. He was busted. There was no getting away from the fact, she knew he’d been ogling her the other night. She didn’t seem upset about it, but Drew suddenly felt deeply embarrassed, deeply ashamed of himself.

‘I... I mean...’ he said, his mind blank. *What am I supposed to say now?*

‘It’s okay,’ she said, pushing her dress further down her body, revealing her black panties, and the gorgeous shape of her derriere. ‘You can watch me, if you want to... I like it.’

He looked away, murmuring, ‘I’m sorry... I didn’t mean... I mean... I didn’t realize...’

He turned away from her, as though to give her privacy now that she was stripping off completely in there. Talk about closing the barn door after the horses had bolted. His heart was pounding away twenty to the dozen. Was she joking around with him, saying what she’d said about his peeping? Getting him to admit what he’d done, so she could justify kicking him out of her apartment, out of her life?

Had their friendship now forever changed?

‘It’s okay, isn’t it?’ she said, her voice much closer now. He turned to find her in her pink bathrobe again, hovering in the bedroom doorway. ‘Two friends can find each other attractive, can’t they?’ she said. ‘And still be friends?’

He attempted a smile. ‘I suppose so.’

She smiled, with genuine affection. ‘Does it bother you that I have a date tonight?’ she asked him.

‘No, of course not,’ he said. ‘Why would I mind?’

Her eyes were roaming all over his face, constantly trying to figure him out. He was silently debating whether to open up to her, to try to explain how he was feeling. How could you explain it? It wasn’t as simple as just saying he had a crush on her, he was in love with her, he wanted to date her himself. It wasn’t like that.

He wanted to watch her strip. He wanted to watch her with another man. He wanted to watch her taken to heaven and back.

‘I’ve known you almost my whole life,’ she said quietly. ‘And I only noticed recently how you look at me.’

‘No, look, you see...’ he said, still mumbling some kind of denial. Mentally, the easiest thing was to deny everything, to try to maintain the ongoing pretense that they were just friends, BFFs, that there was no tension between them complicating everything.

She tilted her hips, perhaps indicating uncertainty. ‘But you look at me... that way... and yet you still encourage me to date other people... you set me up with Lachlan...’

She didn’t understand him. Hey, he didn’t understand himself. Get in line.

‘Because I think you’ll have fun with Lachlan,’ he said. ‘I think he’s a great guy.’

She nodded, and to Drew’s quiet surprise, seemed as though she’d figured something out about him. That she’d come up with some kind of explanation for his behavior.

‘You won’t stop being my friend... just because you find me attractive, will you?’ she said.

‘No,’ he said immediately, not even thinking. ‘Absolutely not.’

‘Great,’ she smiled warmly. ‘And I won’t stop being your friend... just because I enjoy you... looking at me.’

She let the bathrobe fall open, revealing a hint of black material beneath, and then knowing that she had Drew’s rapt attention, she smiled and allowed the robe to fall off her body completely.

Drew caught his breath. It was difficult to remain fully calm, to keep his manhood from thickening. The babydoll was quite sheer—scandalously so. And while she was wearing a pair of black panties underneath, he was aware that he could see her nipples through the lace covering her breasts. Wow.

She was basically letting him stare at her bare breasts.

‘You think he’ll like it if I wear this under my dress?’ she said, and then gave him a slow twirl to show off the rear view.

She was wearing a thong. God. She was really teasing him.

‘I think... yeah... I think he’ll like it,’ Drew said. His throat was so dry, his tongue felt like a fish dying in a dried-up river bed in the middle of the desert.

She smiled again, so beautifully.

Her words whirled around his head: *I won’t stop being your friend, just because I enjoy you looking at me.*

Feeling slightly emboldened to think that she enjoyed him watching her, perhaps even nearly as much as he enjoyed watching her, he said, ‘Do you think he’ll get to see your underwear this time?’

‘I don’t know...’ she said, cautiously lifting the hem of her babydoll, flashing her thong. ‘...do you think he should?’

Drew smiled, and leaned back in the armchair. Well, what was the point in hiding the bulge in his pants now? It was kind of out there, now, that he was turned on by the sight of her. And, he supposed, she was perhaps turned on by him watching her. She flashed her eyes briefly, as though realizing what the bulge in his pants signified. And then she seemed to be trying to keep calm, trying not to reveal the full extent of her feelings about what she could see.

He said, ‘I think you should let him if you want to.’

She let the babydoll fall back into place. It really didn’t hide anything anyway. ‘You wouldn’t feel bad... if I let him see it?’ she asked him, her eyes probing his for signs of jealousy, or for signs that he was trying to hide his jealousy from her.

‘I wouldn’t feel bad at all,’ he said, trying to sound genuine, even though he was being genuine. Trying to reassure her as best he could.

She paused a moment, breathed, and then nodded.

Then she said, ‘Perhaps there’s something else I could wear under my dress. Something better.’

She turned on her heels, and disappeared off into the bedroom again—this time, closing the door behind her.

Drew's heart was pummeling the outside wall of his chest. Was he dreaming? Emma showing off her underwear to him, saying to him, not just that it was okay for him to look at her like that, but that she actually enjoyed it when he looked at her like that.

'Carrie and Ray think we should be dating each other,' Emma called from the bedroom.

Drew smiled. 'They don't understand,' he replied, raising his voice so she could hear from the bathroom.

'No, they don't.'

Drew took another large sip of red wine. It was another French heavyweight—this time a Petite Sirah. All blackberries and pepper, with a hint of chocolate. It made him feel sleepy, just breathing in the bouquet. He felt warm inside from drinking it, and his inhibitions were easing.

He said, 'Ray believes I have a crush on you,' and it felt somehow cathartic to get that piece of information off his chest.

Well, you shouldn't keep secrets from your best friend.

'Does he?' Emma said, opening the bedroom door again to step out in her pink bathrobe.

'Mmm,' Drew nodded, taking another sip of the wine. 'Well... I suppose he had to be right about something.'

Emma flashed her eyes at him as she realized what he was saying.

'And yet you still want me to go out with Lachlan tonight?' she said, still trying to figure him out, though now he could see her sneaking little glances at the bulge in his pants. Was it the wine that meant he didn't care if she knew how hard he was for her? Or because now she knew he had a crush on her, there was no point in hiding it.

'Uh-huh,' he said.

'Wearing something like this?'

She slowly prized open her bathrobe, and underneath was something scarlet. Lacy. Sheer.

Drew couldn't help but react to it.

It was a bodysuit, bright red, and while the lace seemed fancy, it was also almost completely see-through. This time he wasn't just gazing at her bare breasts, he was essentially seeing her entire body completely naked. The lace was little more than an intricate dusting of color over the top of her smooth, pale skin.

'Wow,' he said, instinctively looking away as though to give her privacy.

'It's okay, you can look,' she said gently, reassuringly. 'I like it when you look.'

He returned his gaze to her body, reluctantly as though someone had just told him he could look directly at the sun without fear of burning out his retinas. His whole body seemed to fill with warmth as he took in the sight of her, his heart was positively bouncing, his blood fizzing with adrenaline, his cock as hard as a rock.

She was just stunning.

And he couldn't believe she was just showing him—standing three feet away. Two feet, now: she had stepped closer. He could smell her perfume, and it just made the fireworks going off inside him all the more powerful. He could see the goosebumps on her nipples. He could confirm, in no uncertain terms, that she shaved her pussy, though there was a thicker band of material covering her actual sex.

'So you like this one?' she said, turning so that he could see her from the back. The bodysuit had a thong back—it just seemed scandalous.

'Isn't it more important that he likes it?' Drew grinned as she slowly completed her 360-degree turn, and her eyes met his again.

'Not to me,' she said, and he felt flames scorching his heart.

'Well, I like it,' Drew said, 'so I've no doubt he will like it, too.'

She smiled, and again he could tell she was subtly checking out the bulge in his pants, though she was trying to hide it. 'If we weren't best friends,' she said, 'would you want to date me?'

His heart was hammering. He got the sense that he could actually have just told her to forget about Lachlan, forget about being BFFs their whole life, and jump into bed with him. At the same time, he could tell she understood why they should avoid a romantic entanglement.

'You mean, would I want to take you out to dinner, drinks... see a movie at the theater?' He grinned, mentioning things they did anyway, as friends.

'You know what I mean,' she said, flames in her eyes.

He was concerned that if he told her he wanted to sleep with her, she would want it, would persuade him to do it. But if he said he didn't she would feel rejected.

She sensed his reluctance to answer, and said, 'If I was wearing this, would you want me to fuck you, instead of Lachlan?'

She'd softened her question by making it more about her outfit, than whether Drew wanted to sleep with her just now. But when she uttered the f-word like that, Drew felt his hardness throbbing like crazy.

'Why should it be 'instead'?' he said, without really meaning to, but the thought was right at the forefront of his mind. Emma raised an eyebrow, intrigued, confused. He said, 'You could fuck Lachlan if you wanted to... and then... if you wanted to... me...'

He saw her catch her breath. He saw how stiff her nipples were.

'...if you were wearing this,' he added, with a mischievous smile, bringing the whole issue back to the clothes. Back to the hypothetical.

'What...?' she said, but didn't seem to know how to find the right words.

'If you weren't my best friend,' Drew clarified, reminding her this wasn't about them having sex, that they couldn't. That getting into a whole physical relationship that could—and probably would—fizzle out after a

few weeks would potentially end their lifelong friendship. If the romantic relationship didn't work, they'd feel awkward around each other. Drew would likely suffer a broken heart. They wouldn't want to be around each other anymore.

But Emma asked, 'You would want to...*as well as Lachlan?*'

Suddenly, she was into the whole hypothetical thing.

He shrugged, smiled, regretting what he'd said, but trying to put a brave face on it. The idea that he might enjoy knowing Emma was sleeping with other men clearly wasn't acceptable to other people. To the rest of society. He was a freak, a pervert. He knew it.

'I just... I think if you and me were... you know...' he stumbled over the words, but she looked sharply at him, letting him know she wanted him to explain himself. '...I just wouldn't want to limit you.'

She stepped back, folded her arms over her breasts. 'If you were dating a girl... if you were sleeping with a girl...' she said, twisting the hypothetical so that it was no longer about her, 'You would be okay with her dating other guys as well?'

Well, wasn't that a thought? If *he was sleeping with Emma, would he be okay with her dating other guys as well?*

He shrugged, 'Why not?'

Emma laughed, and turned to pick up her pink bathrobe from the sofa. 'Okay, if you were in *love* with someone, would you be okay with her dating other guys as well?'

'I wouldn't have a problem with it,' he said, 'if she wanted to.'

He leaned back in the armchair, crossed his legs to minimize the obviousness of his bulge, and spoke casually, as though it really wasn't a big deal, this whole challenge to society's dating norms.

She pulled on her bathrobe, smiling. 'You're an enigma, you know that, Andrew Mackenzie?' she laughed. 'I've known you my whole life, I know

you better than I know my own father. But now it's like I don't know you at all.'

'Oh, I didn't mean...' he stammered, worried that this little hint of his dark secret meant he had lost her trust, that perhaps it made her like him less.

But her smile only broadened, 'Oh no, I like it,' she said brightly, 'It just means there's even more for me to discover about you...'

Then she turned, and returned to the bedroom, presumably to finish getting ready for her date.

Drew was left watching Netflix, and it was a few minutes before he even really noticed what he was watching on the streaming service. Mindhunter. He had to back up the show to the point at which he remembered what he was seeing. And then, a few minutes later, he had to switch to a movie he'd already seen, because he really wasn't taking in any information at all.

'Oh, hey, I talked to Laura today,' Emma called from the bedroom. He glanced over to see her wander past the door wearing that black dress again, fiddling with an earring.

'Laura?'

'You know, Laura from work. Remember? I told you she's single...'

'Oh, right. That's her name?'

'She's up for a date, if you're interested,' Drew felt the tips of his ears burn, in that self-conscious way when you learn that people have been talking about you behind your back. Emma took his hesitation to mean he had no idea what she was talking about.

'Seriously?' he felt weird, being set up. Maybe it was just that he wasn't accustomed to it.

Emma leaned out of the bedroom doorway to get a read on what Drew felt about it all. 'It'll be fun,' she smiled.

He felt his heart fluttering. This was a weird place he was in.

‘Okay... am I supposed to call her?’ he said, warily.

‘She’s gonna call you.’

Emma emerged from the bedroom, the dress looking unbelievably good on her, the neckline so low it almost revealed her pierced navel, and left no doubt that her breasts were just perfect. Her hair was brushed back into a neat ponytail now, her pretty face enhanced by a sophisticated touch of makeup. And, she had donned black, high-heeled shoes.

‘How do I look?’ she said.

‘Incredible,’ Drew said.

She beamed. Then her expression of delight morphed into a mischievous smirk, a devilish glint in her eyes. She said, ‘Okay... this is your last chance... I could cancel my date and we could just fuck each other all night...’ She lifted the hem of her dress briefly, to offer him another glimpse of her sheer underwear.

Drew laughed, although inside he was a mass of smoldering, white-hot desire. ‘As much as I’d love to...’ he said, but he didn’t need to explain the whole ‘friends’ thing anymore. She nodded.

‘Besides,’ he added, ‘I just know you’ve been wanting to get your hands on Lachlan’s big—’

‘I have, haven’t I?’ she interrupted him, putting a bounce back into her voice. Not wanting to put a downer on the whole date thing, not wanting to seem like she was suddenly hung up on the idea of sleeping with Drew.

‘He’s going to want to tear that dress off you, as soon as he sees it,’ Drew said.

Emma grinned, picking up her purse from the kitchen counter. ‘I’ll have to bring him home early, then,’ she said.

Drew switched off the TV and stood up, but as he took a step toward Emma, to head back to his apartment as she went out to her date, she said, ‘Oh, you can stay if you like. You know... have a little more wine... enjoy the heat.’

He chuckled at her reference to Ray's love of overly cool air-conditioning, but inside he felt a little jolt of surprise at the way she was looking at him, the way she was suggesting he stay here while she went on her date.

Had she seen him, after all, while he'd watched her having sex that night?

He said, 'It's okay, I need to get to bed early anyway. I have to interview some new recruits in the morning, and I don't want to be tired...'

She smiled, and suddenly the moment was over, and he thought, perhaps, it was just a coincidence that she'd suggested he stay in her apartment with the wine. 'Well, wish me luck!'

'Good luck!' he said, and she leaned in so he could give her a farewell peck on the cheek. He inhaled a chestful of her perfume as he touched his lips to her soft face, and for a moment felt a little giddy.

Thinking, what if we hadn't grown up together? What if we were strangers, and you came up to me in the bar and asked me out. If you were in the mood for something longer-term, more than a one night stand—how long would we last?

But then he was watching her disappear off toward the elevator, and he was left on his own, wondering what might have been.

Chapter Nine

*B*ack in his own apartment, he ate a bowl of cereal in front of *The Silence of the Lambs*, and just about managed to keep Emma from taking over his mind. When he did get to bed fairly early, however, there she was. Stripping in front of him, all over again.

You know I love the way you look at me.

Standing there in front of him, her underwear so sheer she might as well have been wearing nothing at all.

You can watch me, if you want to... I like it.

Giving him indisputable invitations to bed her.

Would you want me to fuck you, instead of Lachlan?

There was no way he was getting to sleep with thoughts like that running through his head, even though he was tired. He took a warm shower, closed his eyes and indulged in the memory of her standing close to him in that scandalous scarlet lingerie. So close that every one of his breaths was laced with her perfume. So close, he could have reached out to stroke her.

God, he'd never seen anything like her.

It's okay, isn't it? Two friends can find each other attractive, can't they?

Then he was standing under the hot flow of the water, one hand pressed against the tiles on the wall to keep himself from keeling over, the other

gripping his long, thick, hard cock as his orgasm hit—picturing Vincent fucking Emma up against the doorway of her bedroom, as stream after stream of thick white cream erupted.

Sleep came more easily after that.

Then it was Saturday, and things got crazy, and he was into work early, interviewing a string of bright young things—and some seasoned pros—who believed they had what it took to propel Juno's Bar & Grill into the big leagues.

And of course, later, it was Saturday night and so busy he wondered why he was even bothering to sign up somebody new to provide marketing support. But there was reason to the rhyme—things were so dead in there, during the week.

By the time Sunday came along, Drew was surprised to get through an entire 24-hour period without even thinking about Emma. Then, there she was, in the bar. Everyone was in the bar, actually, tucking into a big brunch. And, to Drew's surprise, Lachlan was there amongst them all—relaxed, smiling, sitting beside Emma like they were a couple.

Drew felt his heart burn as he saw them together. Then his eyes connected with Emma's, and she gave him a little smirk that said in no uncertain terms:

Jealous?

He felt things thickening up between his legs. Would she really drop everything, abandon Lachlan, and throw care to the wind as far as their lifelong friendship was concerned, if he actually begged her for sex?

But he simply smiled warmly back at her, silently ignoring her provocation, doing his best to radiate approval for her apparently developing relationship with Lachlan.

God, when had she last introduced one of her dates to their friends? When had she ever hung out with them all like this, with a date along for the ride? When had she ever just hung out with a date?

He almost got the sense that she was trying to prove something.

Drew had to work, but he could wander over there from time to time, to show his face and be part of the group. Both Ray and Carrie gave him sharp looks that attempted to warn him that this new guy, Lachlan, was moving in on turf that ought to be his. Drew just gave them both eye-rolls, and they dropped their campaign.

Then they were all disappearing to the four winds, leaving Drew behind the bar, Emma giving him a little smile and a wave before linking her arm in Lachlan's, and exiting the place as an evident couple.

It was okay, he told himself. It's better that way.

That evening, when he got home, there was no light on under Emma's door. She wasn't in, all evening. Where could she be? Another date? Surely she hadn't been hanging out with Lachlan all day? That made Drew feel a little queasy. He wasn't jealous, of *course*. But what if Emma really fell for the guy? What if their relationship became unexpectedly serious, and then she drifted away from Drew?

If she ever got married, her husband wouldn't want her to have a male BFF, would he? Especially if he suspected, with good reason, that the BFF was attracted to her.

It was Sunday evening when Laura called him.

'Hey, is this Drew?'

'Uh... yeah. Who's this?'

'It's Laura. I'm a friend of Emma, we work together.'

'Oh, right, of course. She mentioned you. Hey, Laura. How's it going?'

He felt entirely too awkward. He talked too much, he listened too little, he lumbered through the phone call like some ungainly village idiot, stumbling and floundering and tripping over his own tongue. He'd forgotten just how weird and embarrassing the whole dating thing was. It was one reason why he had never gone for one night stands in the way that Emma had, he had always been a serial monogamist. Only when you were dating

someone for some time did the awkwardness and anxiety of the whole dating thing dissipate.

But Laura seemed friendly, and accommodating, even when he admitted he hadn't dated anyone for years, and had no idea what he was doing.

'That's okay,' she said, 'Emma told me all about you. I'll go easy on you.'

Drew felt his ears burning again. They arranged to have dinner on Wednesday night. And now Drew got the strangest feeling he would miss the boat with Emma, somehow, because he would be dating Laura. Feelings most certainly did not come logically.

*M*onday, Drew was working again, but then so was Lachlan, which made Drew feel strangely reassured—at least the guy wasn't spending more time with Emma. The reassurance lasted roughly until closing time, when it was just Lachlan and himself in the place, and there was no way he could avoid asking how it was going with Emma.

'Great, thanks, mate,' Lachlan nodded, and that was that.

'Great. Good to hear it.'

There was a strange new tension between them. It was subtle, but there: Drew's paranoia wasn't making it up. Lachlan didn't open up about why things were going great, or how well they connected, or anything like that.

Drew had to remind himself that this was usually how men communicated with each other when it came to women.

But there was an unmistakable feeling in the air that this was no longer Drew's domain, that Drew no longer had jurisdiction when it came to discussing Emma's dating activity. Lachlan was here, and he was her *other half* now.

God, it had all happened so quickly.

It was Tuesday night by the time he saw Emma again. And there was, to his relief, some reassurance in the way she let herself into his apartment while he was fixing supper, slumping down casually on his couch to remark on how long it had been since she'd got to actually hang out with him.

'So it must be going pretty well with Lachlan?' he said, and for a moment found himself afraid that Emma would clam up as well, that she had also decided that her relationship with Lachlan could no longer be the subject of discussion with Drew because he was so important to her now.

But Emma groaned—and not in a good way—and sighed, and said, '*It's nice*, of course. I mean, I do really like him.'

Drew grinned, and brought over a bowl of Bolognese for Emma, as well as one for himself, before settling down next to her on the couch.

'I sense there's a 'but' coming...' he said, feeling immensely gratified that there was a flaw in her fledgling relationship with the Australian.

'He wants to spend a lot of time together,' she said, 'but then when it gets to the end of the night, and you know, we're making out... it's really nice, and I can tell he's really into it as well...'

'Uh-huh?'

'...then it all suddenly stops.'

'*It stops?*'

'Yeah. He's like, well, *I'm bushed*... and then he's wishing me a good night.'

Drew looked at her, wide-eyed. 'You have... slept with him already, haven't you?'

She said, with pronounced melodrama, 'Not yet.'

Drew was genuinely surprised. 'You haven't done anything with him?'

She shrugged. 'Well, unless you count necking like teenagers,' she said, taking a bite of pasta and giving Drew a clear look of gratitude and appreciation for sharing his food. 'Oh wait... he did touch my boob at one point. But that might just have been accidental.'

She sighed, but broke out into a smile. 'It's okay,' she said. 'I mean, he's really nice. I do like spending time with him...'

'And you do realize, this is how normal people start relationships?' Drew pointed out. 'I mean, what has it been—a week? Not even quite that?'

'A week!' she exclaimed. 'I have gone a whole week without sex. More than a week, actually.'

Drew laughed. 'Have you gone this long without sex before?'

'Not since I had my braces removed. Oh, hey, what's going on with Laura?'

'Huh?'

Emma looked at him as though he was involved in some kind of scandal. 'She said you guys have a date?'

Drew shrugged. 'We're just having dinner tomorrow night.'

'Uh-huh. Most people would call that *a date*,' she grinned suggestively. 'So what are you wearing?'

'To see Laura? I don't know, I hadn't really thought about it.'

Emma gasped melodramatically. 'Seriously?'

With that, she had him go into his room to show her exactly what he would be wearing on his date. He had to pick out a shirt and pants, and then march out to get her opinion. It was very much shoe on the other foot territory.

'Okay, so where are you taking her?' Emma said.

'The Gallows,' he said, naming a fairly chilled out local watering hole that offered pretty straightforward, but good food.

'That place? It's so dark in there. Okay, so that shirt does not work with those pants. Take it off.'

He went back into his room, but when he pulled off the shirt, he found that she had followed him, and was leaning up against the doorway, watching him change. Well, here it was. The other day she had displayed

herself to him in the kind of sheer underwear that left almost nothing to the imagination. Now she felt some kind of entitlement to check him out.

‘How about this?’ he said, trying not to visibly react to her being there as he pulled a different shirt out of his wardrobe.

She wrinkled her nose. ‘I don’t know... you know she’s a lawyer...’

Then Emma stepped up to him, and started going through his wardrobe herself until she found a charcoal gray shirt Drew hadn’t worn in years. ‘Here,’ she said. ‘But you’ll need different pants.’

She sat on the bed while he changed into various combinations of shirts and pants and he got the distinct impression that she was prolonging the whole thing just because she enjoyed looking at him while he was changing. It was fair enough, considering what he had seen of her. And actually, he quite enjoyed the fact that she seemed to want to check him out. He wasn’t in bad shape, he used the gym fairly regularly. But she kept trying to find tight pants, but he simply didn’t go for the whole skinny jeans look.

Then, when she seemed happy with a final choice of shirt and pants, she said, ‘So what will you be wearing underneath?’

Apparently, she wasn’t happy with his choice of loose boxer shorts.

He had to watch while she sifted through his underwear drawer, complaining that men were never expected to wear sexy undies while on a date.

‘We’re just having dinner,’ Drew insisted. ‘You know, midweek thing. Relaxed.’

Emma said pointedly, ‘You are not going to treat her the way Lachlan’s been treating me. Maybe I should see if Ray has anything...?’

Drew shook his head, ‘I am not wearing Ray’s underwear.’

‘What’s the big deal? Women borrow underwear all the time.’

He just gave her a look to respond to that.

Emma smiled sweetly at him. 'Don't you have anything... even a little tight?'

'She's really not going to be seeing me in my underwear on a first date.'

'Here,' she said, pulling out a pair of boxer-briefs. 'These will have to do.' She handed them to him as he stood up, but then as he moved to change into them, she simply sat down, fully intending to watch it all.

Drew sighed, feeling like he hardly had any right to demand privacy. He turned away from her to whip off his boxers, and slip on the boxer-briefs, but he felt her eyes on him every step of the way. Did she like what she saw? He had to force himself not to recall how she had looked in that sheer underwear, because that was risking things swelling up when he didn't want them to. But trying not to think about dirty thoughts only made him think about them.

When he turned to let her see him in that tight underwear, Emma gasped, and covered her mouth with her hand, her eyes wide with surprise.

'What?' he said, looking down. He wasn't hard, he was managing to keep it down. What had her so shocked?

'No wonder you always wear loose pants,' she said, gazing at the prominent bulge in his underpants. 'And come to think of it, when we're on vacation, loose swim shorts, too.'

'You think I should wear normal boxers instead?' he said.

'No, definitely not,' she said, looking at him as though she was storing up the memory of him in that tight underwear. 'Laura's a very lucky girl...'

Chapter Ten

Wednesday night, he was all dressed up in the outfit Emma had finally approved, and ducking into a small gray-fronted place on Washington Street, to find an attractive brunette sitting at a table waiting for him.

‘Hi, Laura, right? I’m sorry, have you been waiting long...?’

‘No, you’re right on time.’

She was friendly, and smiley, and bright and delightful, and wearing a thin, gray sweater that somehow managed to be both informal and quite form-fitting. Drew was surprised just how attractive she was—and yet he felt so strange having dinner with her. She was a stranger. Were they really going to eat together, talk all evening and then end up in bed together?

He had to remind himself that she wasn’t Emma. Laura probably wouldn’t be expecting sex on a first date.

And yet, it felt strange that they would be sitting there at a smallish table, opposite each other, sizing each other up for a possible sexual relationship.

Had dating always been a slightly weird experience?

‘So Emma tells me you mix the most amazing cocktails.’

‘I don’t know about ‘amazing’...’

‘So what cocktail do you go for yourself?’

‘Usually... well, usually I drink beer. Or wine. Cocktails... make me think too much of work.’

The conversation flowed easily enough, and there were plenty of smiles all round. But though Drew tried to settle into it, it did seem a little like a job interview. Food provided some welcome distraction—gnocchi for her, steak and potato for him—but only later, after a fair amount of alcohol, did he actually manage to feel relaxed, and started noticing that Laura was beginning to flirt with him.

‘So how come it’s been so long since you last dated anybody?’ she was smiling a lot, and playing with her long, wavy brown hair.

‘I don’t know... I guess in college I had a fairly rocky time... and I just got fed up of difficult break-ups.’

She laughed, ‘Difficult because people were breaking up with you, or because you had to break up with them?’

He shrugged, smiled. ‘I don’t know. A bit of both. It’s never easy. And I always ended up getting totally absorbed by relationships, you know?’

‘I’ve been there,’ she said, and the way she was fiddling with the tips of her hair, it made her look almost as though she was pointing his eyes toward her chest. ‘But you can’t let it get to you. You just have to find someone better.’

‘I suppose so,’ he nodded. ‘But you know... I focused on work... and next thing I know, it’s been a few years since I really dated anyone.’

‘Years?’ she giggled.

‘Maybe everything’s done differently now,’ he joked.

‘Hmm... maybe I can help show you how it’s done,’ she said, in a very provocative, sultry tone of voice.

He was about to suggest another drink when he glanced off to the back of the restaurant and saw something that made him stop and do a double-take. At one of the tables sat a woman with red hair who was wearing sunglasses. Yet it wasn’t the fact that she was wearing sunglasses at night—

within an establishment that wasn't exactly brightly lit—that struck him as odd.

Her long, bushy red hair was really very characteristic, and very familiar.

'I'm sorry, I'm going to have to visit the little boys' room,' he said to Laura, trying not to appear as though he was distracted by the woman at the back of the restaurant.

'Sure. I'll order some more wine,' Laura said, the innocent in all this.

Drew quietly got up and wandered casually through the other tables toward the restrooms. At the last minute, he glanced behind him to check that he wasn't at risk of Laura watching him, then steered toward the table where the redhead was sitting.

'And what, exactly, are you doing here?' he said.

Carrie looked up, peering over her sunglasses. 'Well, what a small world we live in,' she said.

Then somebody else wearing sunglasses returned from the restrooms, and even with the wig, it didn't take a genius to see through her disguise.

'You should have given her the wig,' Drew said, taking a seat beside Carrie as Emma removed her sunglasses, giving him a mischievous smirk that said she knew she was busted, but it was too amusing to worry about. It also suggested she'd had quite a bit to drink.

'I told you he'd see us,' Carrie said.

'What?' Emma said with mock innocence. 'It's the first date you've been on in years, you can't blame us for being curious.'

'You do remember she works with you?' Drew reminded her.

'She's not even facing this way,' Emma shrugged.

'And you're risking her catching you... why?'

Emma blushed. 'I have to make sure she's right for you,' she said quietly.

‘But you work with her, you know her better than I do. And you’re the one who set us up.’

Carrie said, ‘Look, you guys. You have to stop beating about the bush.’ The way their redhead friend was drumming her fingers on the table, it was quite clear that she had spent long enough in that restaurant without a cigarette, and desperately needed to get outside so that she could light up.

‘What?’ Emma said, still the picture of innocence. ‘I just want to make sure he’s okay. It’s been such a long time...’

‘You’re both obviously retarded for each other,’ Carrie said, then, to Drew, she said, ‘She’s been going crazy all night talking about you going on this date.’

‘I was *just curious*,’ Emma insisted.

‘He’s your guy,’ Carrie said. ‘He’s your guy, and you can’t handle the thought of him being with somebody else.’

Emma was blushing furiously by now, and trying to avoid Drew’s gaze. He felt an odd mix of emotions—was she really jealous about him dating somebody else? Was he being an absolute idiot in not trying to push for some kind of romantic entanglement with her?

‘We’re just friends,’ Drew told Carrie. Then to Emma, he said, ‘You’re just feeling crazy because nothing’s happened with Lachlan yet.’

Emma nodded, but it was almost as though she was agreeing with him because it was the easy explanation for what she was up to in spying on his date.

‘Come on,’ Carrie said, looking relieved to be given an excuse to get out of there. ‘We’re going to go sex toy shopping. If you’re still crazy after that, then you need to handcuff Drew to your bed until you’re completely satisfied.’

Emma flashed her eyes suggestively at Drew, but then as Carrie strode off toward the door, her expression turned apologetic. Drew smiled, forgiving her instantly.

And yet, after she was gone, he had this awful feeling inside, like there was one of his vital organs missing. The date with Laura couldn't quite survive that particular feeling.

OceanofPDF.com

Chapter Eleven

On his way home from the restaurant, he was thinking how insane he was, ending the date early. Laura had been really nice, and certainly attractive. The chemistry had been pretty good, too.

And ending a date because Emma might be uncomfortable with it was doubly insane—since he had no intention of trying to date her instead. It just wouldn't be right.

How could he feel this way about Emma? He knew she couldn't do long-term relationships. He knew he couldn't do long-term relationships anymore, either. If they were together, and then it all collapsed, he would be just devastated.

He got back to his apartment to find Emma there, watching TV with Ray.

'You're done?' she said, clearly surprised to see him. Also, perhaps, a little relieved? He might have been imagining that, though.

'We had a nice time,' he insisted, glancing at the clock in the kitchen area, which showed it was eleven o'clock.

'I'm sorry, but it's another hour and a half before you qualify for 'nice time',' Ray said dryly. 'So it wasn't destined to be, huh?'

'It's a weeknight,' Drew laughed. 'We both have to work tomorrow. And this was only a first date.'

‘It’s not because... I spoiled your night?’ Emma asked him, the guilt plastered all over her features.

‘I had a great night with her,’ he said, though part of him did wonder if Laura would feel the same way. He had been the one to make the excuses to bring things to a close well before midnight. She’d gone along with it, but she could easily have felt rejected. God, dating was just merciless.

He said earnestly to Emma, ‘Since she works with you, I can’t exactly just make a fool out of myself. You know, slow and steady wins the race.’

Ray patted Emma on the knee and then stood up. ‘You two need to work this out.’ Then, he went off to his room, apparently exasperated, leaving Emma alone with Drew.

‘Ray and Carrie want us to date,’ Emma smiled.

‘It would be convenient,’ Drew laughed, though it was more like a nervous reaction to the sudden awkwardness he felt sitting there on the couch beside Emma just then.

‘I’d have to cancel my date with Lachlan on Saturday.’

‘And you really like him.’

Emma giggled. ‘I’d like him more if he invited me back to his place at the end of the night and then tore my clothes off.’

Drew felt the edge taken off the awkwardness between them. ‘Uh... what happened to the real Emma? Because this Emma I do not know. Since when have you needed a guy to invite you back to his place?’

‘This time it’s different,’ she said, faintly embarrassed.

‘Because he’s not a stranger you met off Tinder?’

‘He’s that kind of guy... he takes his time... he’s a gentleman.’

‘But this is the twenty-first century. And you’re getting desperate.’

‘Hey, speak for yourself,’ Emma laughed.

Later, after a few drinks with Emma, Drew went to bed alone feeling good about his evening’s choices. Who knew what Emma’s real motivations

were? Perhaps she had changed her mind about Laura because she worked with her.

Meanwhile, Emma was becoming noticeably uptight, and even a little crabby at times. To Drew, it seemed as though there was a growing pressure building within her that was threatening to explode if she didn't get some kind of release soon.

He'd never seen her like this before. She could not handle this long without sex.

By Saturday, he felt he had to say something.

'I thought Carrie took you out sex toy shopping?' he said.

'God, no. She only wanted to get out for a smoke.'

'You don't feel... you know... maybe you could... do it for yourself some time?' he asked her.

'Huh?'

'You know... in the shower or something?'

They were in the mall together, Saturday morning. It wasn't unusual for the two of them to hang out while shopping, but today Emma had been a little brusque with some of the shop staff when the right shoe sizes weren't available, or even if staff were a little too in her face about offering her assistance.

She was never like this. It was like she'd had far too much coffee to drink.

'What are you saying?' she asked him, jittery to the point where he wasn't sure she was even able to entirely focus on what he said, at least enough to take in its meaning.

He sighed, and whispered very quietly, 'You don't think you might feel better if you... you know... *masturbate*... some time?'

'Masturbate?' she said, very loudly. More than a few heads turned as people heard her say it.

Drew dropped his eyes to the floor, and grabbed something from a nearby hook as though to demonstrate to people that he had nothing to do with this foul-mouthed young woman who happened to be standing next to him.

After a moment, he said to her quietly, ‘Yeah. You know... you don’t think it would help you... feel better?’

She sighed, and mercifully spoke just as quietly, as she said, ‘It doesn’t really do anything for me.’

‘It doesn’t *really do anything* for you?’ He marveled. ‘Uh... if you don’t mind me saying... are you doing it right?’

She gave him an eye roll, and grabbed what was in his hands—whatever it was he had taken, without looking, from a nearby hook. It turned out to be a pink dress.

‘I guess this is kind of cute,’ she said, holding it up. It didn’t seem like something Emma would wear.

Then he was following her to the changing room, and he worried that he had somehow offended her. They talked about sex often enough, but they’d never talked about masturbation. Not really. Certainly not in relation to Emma. Drew wondered if she had ever needed to even do it.

He waited dutifully outside the changing booth as she tried on the dress.

‘You know,’ he said, wishing he didn’t have to, but feeling more than a little obligated, as her friend, to mention it, ‘everybody does it. It’s not a big deal. It’s nothing... you know... to be ashamed of.’

‘What are you talking about?’ she said, poking her head out of the curtain.

‘You know...’ he said, eyes darting this way and that to see if there was any threat of eavesdropping, before he whispered close to the curtain: ‘*masturbation.*’

She sighed melodramatically, and pulled back the curtain to reveal herself to be wearing the dress. It actually looked pretty good on her—tight in all the right places. Even the color looked unexpectedly wonderful on her. But there was a weird zip running from the neckline between her breasts all the way down to the bottom.

‘That zip goes all the way up?’

‘Easy access, huh?’ she grinned, not least because Drew had found this dress. ‘You can just slip the whole thing off... it’s kind of sexy.’

She gazed at herself in the mirror, which took up one wall of the changing booth. Turning, this way and that, tugging at the dress to get it in the perfect position.

‘You can come in here,’ she said, and when he stepped inside the booth, a touch uncertain, she pulled the curtain back into place to shut out the rest of the world.

Actually, the booth wasn’t so small. There was even a seat he could use. Even so, he wasn’t usually quite this close to her when he gave her his opinion on an outfit.

‘What do you think?’

‘You don’t often wear pink dresses,’ he said, trying to be a little diplomatic, because he wasn’t sure about that zip—whether it was simply quirky, or full-out slutty. ‘It’s kind of different.’

‘I thought it was going to be a little bigger on me, but it actually fits me quite nicely...’

She was tugging on the hem, which didn’t cover much of her thighs at all, but since Emma was intent on dragging Lachlan out to a nightclub by the end of their date—no doubt, in order to get him in the mood for a little more than making out—it did look fairly appropriate.

Drew enjoyed the sight of her in that dress, and the way she was showing it off to him. No matter how many times they’d been shopping together, it had never been like this before. She twirled, and he could really

appreciate the sight of her—and he could tell she enjoyed flaunting herself in front of him, pushing out her chest, tilting her hips, tweaking the outfits this way and that.

In the closeness of that changing booth, however, breathing in her perfume was making him feel a little charged.

‘It’s really thin. It feels really... silky,’ she said. ‘I love the way it feels when I move...’

‘A great one for the dance floor,’ he pointed out.

Then she said, ‘feel how soft this material is, though...’

He didn’t quite know how to respond, what to do. This didn’t usually happen. There’d never been touch involved in any of her pre-date fashion shows. And because the dress was so skin-tight, there wasn’t really any of it Drew could simply reach out and touch, without touching her somewhat suggestively.

‘Come on,’ she said, grabbing his hand as he tentatively held it up toward her.

She placed it on her waist, where it remained for the few seconds she was holding it. Enough to take in the unexpectedly intense heat of her body through the dress, and the softness of the material. That dress really did seem pretty thin.

‘Oh yeah, feels nice,’ he said, looking up and offering a smile that was hopeful of acceptance.

It wasn’t that he didn’t want to touch her, it wasn’t that he didn’t like it that he had touched her. He just felt so self-conscious. He didn’t want a raging erection while they wandered the mall looking for the right dress to propel Lachlan into bed.

‘No, you really have to feel it,’ she insisted, grabbing hold of his hand again, pressing it up against her stomach. ‘See how soft it is?’

She was right—the dress was soft, incredibly soft. But it was also thin, and he was reacting inside to the wonderful warmth of her body, and the

pleasing topography around her navel. It almost felt as though he was touching her and she wasn't wearing anything at all. The sensation was somehow electric, and as he laid his hand on her, her eyes widened, and her mouth opened in wonder.

'It's nice...' he said, in little more than a whisper, and realized that it might have been interpreted as him saying it was nice to touch her.

Her hand was still on top of his, holding it there as they gazed into each other's eyes in mutual surprise. But now she moved his hand up her body, until he was cupping one of her breasts, which seemed like the perfect size for his palm.

She caught her breath as he touched her there, shocked, even though she had put his hand there. He felt his whole body effervescing, and his manhood was certainly thickening up pretty quickly, but he didn't feel able to pull back his hand. He didn't want to make her feel rejected in any way.

'Touching's okay... isn't it?' she said softly. 'I mean... for close friends?'

He could feel her nipple pushing against the thin material of her dress.

'I guess so,' he breathed.

After a beat or two, he felt the moment had been sufficiently long for him to pull back his hand, the justification to hold it there no longer quite as strong. She smiled, a touch awkwardly, a touch apologetically. Both of them were gently blushing. There was a sense of danger, somehow. That they were pushing the boundaries of their friendship—even if they knew Drew was attracted to her, that he enjoyed looking at her, and that Emma enjoyed him watching.

They were friends. She was dating somebody else.

Drew stepped out of the changing booth, replacing the curtain so that Emma could switch out of the dress and back into her regular jeans and white t-shirt combo.

‘I wasn’t sure about that zip,’ she said, as they left the changing area, leaving the pink dress on the hook.

‘Yeah, it might have been a little over-the-top,’ Drew grinned, amused that Emma shared his one key reservation about the dress.

‘Why would you design such a perfect dress and then ruin it by putting such a slutty zip right down the front?’ she laughed. ‘So many dresses—they’re perfect, and then the designer throws some bizarre little detail in there, and it just spoils everything.’

‘It’s retail rules,’ he said, and they were out of one store and into another. ‘If you found the perfect dress the first store you went in, you wouldn’t have to visit all the other stores—and if you found the perfect dress, you wouldn’t have to buy a load of dresses to try on at home until you decided on the one to actually wear.’

In the next store Emma found a black-and-white dress that seemed to be almost a snakeskin print, though what struck Drew more than anything was just how thin the material was.

In fact, a succession of dresses Emma selected to try on were conspicuously made of thin material.

For a couple of them, Emma invited Drew to feel the material on her, but they both seemed a little self-conscious when he was actually touching her, so he didn’t repeat his fondling of her breast. In the last store, a retail assistant spotted Emma inviting Drew into her changing room and gave them a dirty look, which took the edge off the experience completely.

They ended up returning to pick up the pink dress, slutty zip be damned.

‘You think he’ll hate it?’ she asked as they were hopping into an Uber car to head home.

‘No, he’ll love it.’

‘That zip, though.’

‘He won’t be able to take his eyes off it,’ Drew smiled. ‘All evening, he’ll be imagining unzipping it.’

‘I hope he doesn’t limit himself to imagining it.’

She glanced over at Drew, suddenly aware she was talking about another guy potentially having sex with her. But not for the first time, she was aware that Drew wasn’t even a tiny bit jealous, he wasn’t even a smidgeon bitter that she was dating somebody else. He actively encouraged talk of her wanting to seduce Lachlan, to drag the man to bed and dispense with his gentlemanly code of conduct.

‘I’ll have to choose the right underwear to wear with it,’ she said, holding the dress up to the light to show that it was actually a touch see-through.

‘You don’t really need underwear, do you?’ Drew joked.

‘Naughty!’ she said, with a pixie grin.

Then they were back in her apartment, just the two of them, and he was sitting in that armchair again, and Emma was stepping out wearing a bra and panties that were so close in color to her skin tone that Drew had to take a double-look, to make certain she was actually stepping out wearing something at all.

‘This probably won’t show through,’ she said, brushing her hair back over her shoulder with a hand.

‘Okay,’ he nodded, running his eyes over her delectable body, trying not to act in any way shocked at what she was letting him see.

This underwear didn’t hide much of her, but at the same time it was fairly plain. Emma turned to provide him with the rear view, and to him it was so hot that she was showing herself off for him like this, he had to put real effort into keeping calm and attempt to offer some kind of critical reception.

‘Not really sexy, huh?’ she said. ‘Good for dinner, but not so much afterward...’

‘They are a little plain,’ he agreed.

There was another one of those moments where his eyes dwelled a little too long on her breasts—this time, because he was still dealing with the memory of touching her there—and then when he remembered to return his eyes to her face, she caught him staring. But Emma smiled warmly, loving that he had been staring.

Then she was disappearing back into the bedroom, into her bathroom, and he called out after her, ‘You know it doesn’t matter what you wear underneath... as long as you can get him to stick around long enough to see that zip unfastened.’

She called out, ‘I know, but when the dress comes off I want him to be so... you know...*shocked and awed*...’

She returned to the living room sporting her pink bathrobe.

‘...you know, he’ll have no option but to take me to bed.’

Standing in front of Drew, she dropped the bathrobe to reveal an elegant babydoll made of lavish, jade-green lace.

Drew caught his breath.

The lace was fairly thick over her chest, but otherwise it was really sheer, and the tiny matching thong she was wearing was so sheer that there couldn’t be any doubt that she shaved her pussy. In fact, Drew could even see a tiny part of her pussy, and it rather shocked him that she would show him that much.

He said, ‘There’s no way you can wear that under your dress.’

It wasn’t that the underwear was so shocking, it was that the lace was dark enough to be visible through her thin dress. Emma had to have realized that when she put it on, hadn’t she?

‘I know,’ she said, her smile reassuring him that she knew the underwear would never work, that she had simply put it on in a bid to shock him. ‘It’s beautiful, though, isn’t it?’

‘Uh-huh,’ he said, trying not to be caught stealing glances between her legs.

Was she pierced down there? He could see something he wasn’t sure about.

‘Here, feel the lace,’ she said, stepping even closer toward him, filling his chest with the scent of her date perfume. ‘It’s *just gorgeous...*’

Wow.

It was gorgeous. *She* was gorgeous. He had to shift so she wouldn’t see the bulge in his pants. He glanced up at her, and she gave him a little nod of approval, signaling that he should do as she suggested, check out the texture of the lace. He lifted a hand, reached up, rested his fingers against the luxurious garment, and cautiously stroked her stomach, exploring the extravagant texture of the material.

‘I could wear my emergency LBD,’ she said, hinting that she could render their day’s shopping trip almost meaningless by opting for a little black dress she already owned. ‘Then I could wear this.’

The lace was tantalizing for the senses. Drew fell into a slight daze, stroking it, and only snapped back to full consciousness when he realized his touch had strayed rather low on her body. Almost scandalously so.

He pulled his hand away, and glanced up apologetically, feeling himself flush again.

Emma only smiled down at him, silently letting him know it was okay, he could touch her like that if he wanted.

‘Maybe I could just put on a skirt, and wear this as a top,’ she said, stepping back as the spell between them broke, and they seemed to return to something more like normality again.

‘Seriously?’

‘Women wear tops like this in clubs,’ she pointed out. ‘And people think they’re glamorous.’

‘I don’t know... it would look like you forgot your shirt,’ he replied, as she slipped back into the bedroom.

When she reappeared, she was wearing the bathrobe again, still enjoying the sense of drama as she prepared to drop it in front of him to reveal what was underneath.

‘Okay, I think this one might be okay underneath the dress,’ she said, toying with the lapel of the bathrobe to tease him.

He sat up in the armchair, and when she did slip the bathrobe off her shoulders, allowing it to fall to the ground, he caught his breath yet again. This time she was wearing pale pink satin lingerie, but it covered very little of her. The bra wasn’t the most outrageous part, although it only just managed to cover up her nipples—the high-cut g-string was so tiny it almost explained in a single outfit why she shaved her pussy completely.

‘Yeah, that won’t show through the dress,’ Drew said, smiling at how provocative it was.

She grinned, enjoying her ability to shock him, and twirled to show him her delightful rear view, which almost looked as though she wasn’t wearing any underwear at all.

‘Do you think it’s too much?’ she said, as he trailed his eyes all over her delectable behind, taking in how the g-string framed her pert buttocks, covering so little it was virtually pointless.

‘I wouldn’t have used the word ‘*much*,’ he joked.

‘You think I should wear something over it? A babydoll or something...’

‘I’m not sure...’ he said. ‘At this stage, if he manages to get as far as taking your dress off, you probably don’t want to be worrying about being too racy.’

‘Do I look like I’m trying too hard?’ she grinned, turning back to face him, her hips swaying slightly as though to draw his eyes down between her legs.

Drew laughed, 'Women can't try too hard, can they? And how many dates have you been on with Lachlan already, and nothing's happened yet?'

'Too many.'

'He's just going to either think you probably always wear seriously sexy underwear, or else you put this on for the date because you're definitely ready for some action.'

'Right,' she said, running her hands over her breasts. 'God, I love how it feels. So soft...' She stepped up to him, so close his chest was filled with her perfume again. 'Feel how soft it is...'

He felt his body temperature rise several degrees, his heart starting to pump at double speed. She looked just sensational, but her underwear covered so little, the only possibility for feeling the satin was to touch her breasts in a very intimate manner—or run his fingers over the tiny triangle of material stretched over her mound.

He reached up to brush the back of his fingers gently over one of her breasts, and she looked at him with eyes chiding him silently for not doing it properly.

Intrigued by what she wanted him to do, and so aroused by her he couldn't have stopped himself if he'd wanted, he offered her a vaguely apologetic smile and then began to stroke her more deliberately, circling the pads of his thumbs around her stiff nipples, taking in the quality of the satin but also of her breasts.

'Isn't it nice?' she said, and he saw how her breathing deepened, her chest rising and falling more slowly and more noticeably as he continued to touch her.

'I like it,' he said, cupping her breasts, squeezing them, grazing his nails over the points where her nipples pressed against the thin satin.

Emma moaned, and Drew could hardly believe what was happening. He felt a mild sense of panic—what if this touching got out of control?—and his hand dropped away from her.

She opened her eyes, faintly surprised, blushing as she said, 'It's okay, isn't it?'

And she wasn't talking about the underwear.

'Uh... yeah,' he said, attempting a reassuring smile, regretting his hesitation, regretting that he might have made her feel rejected. 'It's nice...'

She smiled, apparently getting the impression that he was okay about what had just happened, he just needed to get accustomed to the idea that he could touch her. Remembering her words from earlier:

Touching's okay... isn't it? I mean... for close friends?

Then, suddenly, she was dashing away again, saying, 'Wait, I have something else.'

He saw that she'd left her bathrobe behind, but this time she closed the bedroom door while she changed. When she opened it again, she ducked her head out from behind the door, asked him if he was ready, and then stepped slowly out, as though she was about to perform an erotic striptease on an actual stage.

'What do you think?'

Once again, she took his breath away. This time, she was wearing white—a small white top and thong panties, lined with elegant lace, which covered much more of her than the pink set, but were so very sheer that it was almost as though she wasn't wearing anything at all.

Drew tried to act calm, though it felt a little difficult to breathe.

'It's bold,' he said, just astounded that she would show herself like this to him.

Sure, he had just been quietly fondling her breasts—but with this underwear, the only way to make it any more explicit would be for her to strip off completely. She might as well have been naked in front of him.

'I like the way this one feels, too,' she said, walking slowly toward him like a catwalk model on slow-mo.

He didn't quite know what to say. He panicked, said, 'You don't think the straps... might be visible under the dress?'

She smiled, crossed her arms over her stomach, and then to Drew's surprise, peeled her top slowly up over her chest, and then off over her head, revealing the sublime spectacle of her bare breasts.

He gasped.

'Better like this, you mean?' she grinned, enjoying the shock she provoked in him.

Her breasts were small, but just gorgeous. Her pink nipples so stiff in the cool air-conditioned air.

'Uh... well, that might work,' he said, when he finally managed to pick his tongue up off the floor.

She stepped closer toward him, and he didn't quite know where to look. She was so beautiful, and yet he was only her friend. Was she trying to take things between them to the next level? Or was she merely attempting to push the boundaries of what was acceptable between them?

He couldn't breathe. Her pussy was right there in front of him, he could see every detail of her lips—and yes, he could see a little silver ring piercing her clitoral hood.

She was so close, practically the only way he could avoid gazing at her pussy was to look up, which he did, and she smiled down sweetly at him, loving how she was making him feel.

'I never knew you were pierced... down there,' he said, spouting the first words that came to mind just to try and cut through the awkwardness he felt about what she was doing, what she wanted from him, what this all meant about their relationship status.

She did remember that she was dating Lachlan, didn't she?

'Do you like it?' she asked him, and this so wasn't about giving her his opinion about how Lachlan might react to her underwear.

'It's... beautiful,' he said, really not knowing what to say.

She smiled, then seemed to take a deep breath, as though she was about to jump into an ice-cold swimming pool. As though she was about to take a big risk.

‘Feel the lace,’ she said quietly, ‘it’s so... intricate.’

He touched two fingers up to the waistband of her thong, trailed them over the lace that edged the sheer material. It was really intricate, really luxurious. It seemed really expensive.

‘Where did you get it?’ he said, and the way she was looking down at him as he explored the edge of her tiny panties with his fingers, he didn’t feel he could stop.

‘New York,’ she said, in barely more than a whisper. ‘Last year when my firm sent me down there to get a deposition.’

‘It’s amazing,’ he said, and now he stroked a finger down the sides of that sheer panel, as though checking out the lace there, though here it was even more intimate, even closer to her pussy.

‘I never wore them for anyone before,’ she said.

He was about to say something about Lachlan being a lucky man, if she’d been saving these for him. But then he felt her hand over his, and she was nudging his fingers over to touch the sheer material that covered her sex.

She pressed his fingers against her pussy, applying pressure so that she was stroking herself with his hand.

Drew was just stunned, looking up at her face to register her eyes so that he could tell what she was doing, what she meant by this—but her eyes were closed. She moaned gently, and he felt he had no option but to continue stroking her there, pressing his fingers up against her pussy, stirring it in little circles, feeling how hot her body was through that thin, sheer material, the contrast between her soft flesh and the hard metal of her piercing.

‘Oh... God...’ she moaned.

She really was desperate—it seemed that she'd gone so long without sex, at least by her standards, she'd gone crazy. But when Drew stopped, wanting to say something to her about going too far, about what this might mean for their friendship, he couldn't find the words anyway—and then she opened her eyes, and there was no doubt what she wanted.

He continued stroking her there, feeling her body responding to the movement of his fingers against her sensitive folds, her breathing turning to an urgent panting in no time, the tiny triangle of sheer material becoming damp, and then positively wet to the touch. And yet he kept his fingers on that material, never straying to touch her skin directly—it was as though he wasn't sure he had her permission to touch her, unless it was through her underwear.

Or else, only touching her through her underwear might help keep their friendship safe within some kind of arbitrary boundary.

‘Oh please... oh please... oh yes...’

The thing was, he didn't need to touch her except through her underwear. She seemed so tightly wound, so pressurized that the barest brush of his fingers against her pussy was enough to illicit increasingly forceful moans. She stood over him, leaning over so that her bare breasts were almost in his face, and she had to prop herself up with a hand clutching the arm of the armchair beside him.

He hadn't touched a woman this intimately for so very long, and yet he knew what he was doing. But there wasn't time for much—he had only just begun to explore the topography of her exquisite, hairless pussy, delving the tip of his finger between her lips, nudging the silver ring to draw out little whimpering yelps of pleasure, when she began to cry out, and her whole body was shaking as though they were being hit by a major earthquake.

And just as he began to marvel at how insanely wet she was getting, she clamped a hand over his, pressing his fingers hard against her pussy, and

she was howling like a she-wolf, her body jerking and shuddering, as though possessed by the devil.

‘Oh Jesus... Jesus... Oh God...’

When, eventually, she released his hand, she was looking at him with undisguised awe, as though he had just performed a miracle.

‘God,’ she said, breathless, grinning, somehow surprised at what had just happened.

‘Feel better now?’ he smiled, trying to make light of the situation somehow, to reassure her that they were still friends, everything was okay.

‘I’m sorry,’ she said, picking herself up, ‘I guess... I was a little bit desperate...’

‘No problem,’ he said with a nonchalant shrug.

She stood there a moment, hips slightly tilted, looking down at him slightly confused. ‘I’m not sure...’ she said, not quite knowing what she wanted to say. Then, ‘Have you... how did you...?’

She took a step back, and said, ‘Have you been secretly dating a ton of women without me knowing about it?’

‘What?’ Drew laughed, sitting back into the armchair.

‘Nobody’s ever... touched me like that before.’ She picked up her white top off the floor.

‘Somebody must have,’ he insisted.

She shook her head, seeming earnest enough. ‘How did you do that?’

‘I was just... you know... you showed me what you wanted... I just kept doing it,’ he said, trying to keep calm, though his manhood was so hard it hurt, and the smell of her perfume, and her arousal, was all around him.

She turned, glanced toward the front door, and said quietly, ‘I have a date,’ as though reminding herself—and him—what was supposed to happen that evening.

Her tone almost seemed to be asking Drew whether she ought to go through with seeing Lachlan that night.

‘You’d better put a little more on,’ Drew said, ‘You’ll get cold if you go out like that.’

As much as he wanted her, physically, it wasn’t only his strange little sexual kink for Emma’s promiscuity that made him want her to go through with her date with Lachlan. There was a new pressure now. Emma was dating Lachlan. Everybody knew it. If she suddenly dumped Lachlan, and started dating Drew, it would feel too much like he was taking her from Lachlan. And Lachlan was too nice for that—and he was a colleague.

That would turn Drew into the bad guy.

Emma gave a little nod—not angry at him, but understanding where he was coming from. ‘You want me to sleep with him, don’t you?’ she said, and the way she was looking at him, it seemed as though she knew exactly what he wanted, she understood him like no one had ever understood him.

‘Yes, I do,’ he said, a little hoarse.

She turned, and said, ‘I’m going to have to wear the pink underwear, I think, these are soaking.’ Then she peeled them off, stepped out of them, and left them abandoned on the floor.

Chapter Twelve

For a long while, he felt as though he was in some kind of dream state. He wandered back to his apartment in a daze. Ray was there, with his on-again, off-again boyfriend, Harry. The two of them were on their way out, and Drew nodded and smiled and wished them a good night, but he seemed to hear nothing they said. Everything was just noise.

Then he was on his own, collapsing on the sofa, hard as a rock as thoughts of Emma in her scandalous underwear whirled around in his head.

Emma, soaking wet, and letting him stroke her pussy through those tiny panties—until he made her come.

It seemed unreal, completely unreal, as though he'd imagined it all. It was all some lucid dream born of sexual desperation and too much wine.

But he wasn't drunk. And her scent was all over his hand—that proved it all.

And then when she'd asked him if he wanted her to sleep with Lachlan—and her tone of voice had been quite clear: *if you tell me, I will sleep with him. If you tell me not to, I won't.*

The way she'd looked at him—she knew. Just like she knew he'd developed a crush on her. She knew how he felt about her sleeping with another man.

So now, she was out on a date with Lachlan, and she had very definite ambitions to drag the guy into bed and fuck the living daylight out of him. But what then? Would she consider herself Lachlan's? Would she date Lachlan until she was bored with him, as she did with every guy she was with? Or was Lachlan different, because she had been on so many dates with the guy waiting for him to get her into bed?

To Drew, what it felt like, strangely enough, was the beginning of a romantic relationship for himself. He had that light-headed feeling, the sense of walking on clouds. He had that slight air of paranoia that he'd misread her signals, that she didn't want him after all.

He sighed, and tried to calm down. His body was reacting, physically, to the sexual connection he had forged with Emma, that was all. In his head, he knew they weren't dating. They were just friends. She had just had a moment of weakness, because she was so desperate for sex. He'd helped her out in that moment of weakness. Perhaps they wouldn't even think of it again, it would be something to forget and move on.

And yet there was the fact that Emma wasn't comfortable with him dating other people. That was strange, wasn't it? It didn't quite fit the logic.

Drew groaned at himself for being so pathetic. Perhaps he had to stop worrying about Emma and give Tinder another try. Emma might not be so offended if he dated a stranger.

He made himself a late-night hot chocolate, and settled down on the couch with Netflix and his Tinder app.

Twenty minutes later, he realized he'd been swiping right on all the women who looked like Emma, and it wasn't helping matters.

Maybe he just needed to forget about dating completely for a while.

All alone, going crazy, Drew had a little moment of weakness of his own that evening. He quietly left his apartment, let himself into Emma's with his key, and then found the sheer white panties that she had taken off just after he'd brought her to orgasm. They were still lying there, right in

the middle of her floor—one more piece of tangible proof that what had happened between him and Emma was not some deranged fantasy he'd made up to cope with his immense crush on her.

He pressed them up against his face. They were still damp, and saturated with her wicked scent.

He had touched her pussy through these panties. He had made her come through these panties. She might be able to forget about all this and move on, as things got going with Lachlan, but Drew never would. He would remember.

He returned to his apartment, stripped off and stepped into the shower, and with a hand gripped tightly around his granite-like erection, soon he had an orgasm of his own.

After that, the tension faded away, and he felt much better. He was even able to sleep.

*I*t was 3am when he woke to the sound of a rattling at his front door. The sound snapped him sharp awake, almost instantly alert—it was the sound of someone breaking into his apartment.

Creeping to his bedroom door, opening it a crack, he heard the sound of a key finally sliding into the lock, no doubt after several drunken attempts. It was probably Ray, he'd had another argument with Harry. Ray tended to get drunk and distraught when he argued with Harry, and Drew could believe that the emotion made him scrabble about to get the key into the lock.

But then the front door opened, and it was Emma letting herself in.

Drew caught his breath. She was still wearing her pink dress, but her hair was a little messy, and no longer tied up, while her makeup was faded and smeared.

Had she finally gone through with it? Had she finally slept with Lachlan?

‘Hey,’ he said, making her jump.

‘You’re still awake?’ she said quietly, concerned she might wake Ray.

‘Uh... yeah, couldn’t sleep,’ he said, a little white lie. ‘Everything okay?’

She smiled, but there was something about her that seemed a little off.

‘Uh... yeah... I just... I wasn’t sleepy, so I just wanted to see if you were still up.’ It wasn’t the craziest notion in the world—Drew was often awake at odd hours. His sleep patterns were so messed up because of the frequent late shifts at the bar, that often he would sleep a few hours and then wake up for most of the night, before getting sleepy again closer to dawn.

‘You had a good time with Lachlan?’ he said as he went to the refrigerator to retrieve some wine. She looked like she needed a drink. She was jiggling her hips slightly, as though she really needed the bathroom.

‘Oh yeah,’ she said, but she wasn’t sitting down. ‘Oh yeah, we had a good time. As ever.’

‘Everything still okay between you two?’

She smiled, nodded, ‘I do really like him...’

‘Great,’ he handed her a glass of red, noticing the slight tremor in her hand. ‘So... you were out pretty late...’

‘We had dinner... and then we went dancing,’ she said, taking a huge swig of wine. ‘And it was so wonderful... dancing up against him... making out... his hands were all over me...’

‘Nice,’ Drew smiled, feeling a growing warmth inside him, certain she was just about to tell him all about her first time sleeping with Lachlan.

‘I could feel he was hard for me,’ she said, taking another swig of wine. ‘I thought...’

So, it hadn’t happened. Drew felt actual disappointment. Had she made a move on him, and he had decided she was taking things too quickly? The

guy was insane.

‘What happened?’

‘We were making out in the taxi on the way back to his place, and I was touching it. You know, stroking him. He was moaning, he liked it...’

Drew had a sudden thought. He said sharply, ‘Did he do something... you weren’t comfortable with?’

‘Oh no,’ she shook her head, took a step back, leaning against the kitchen counter as though she was afraid she’d fall. ‘No, no, not at all. It was me... I guess... I was touching him... and then we had such a long way to get to his place... I unzipped him. I was so curious... and desperate...’

She dropped her wine glass, gasping as she felt it go, yelping as it hit the floor and smashed.

Drew jumped for the kitchen towel.

Emma was very apologetic, ‘I’m so sorry... Oh God, look at me... I can’t hold a damn glass...’

But Drew was shaking his head, quietly picking up the shards of glass—the thing had only broken into four or five pieces—before mopping up the floor around her with a kitchen towel.

‘So he objected to you wanting to touch his cock?’ Drew said, trying to bring the conversation back to the topic at hand, to distract her from the spilled wine.

‘Well, no, not exactly,’ she said, standing over him. He could see up her dress, see her panties. ‘I went down on him...’

‘In the taxi?’

‘Uh-huh,’ she grinned.

‘Okay... so it was good?’ he said, mopping up the last of the spilled wine. Some of it had gone on the edge of the living room carpet, and needed additional dabbing with the paper.

‘I enjoyed it,’ she said, ‘And I guess he enjoyed it... but then we got to his apartment building and he zipped up again... and then he told the driver

my address...'

'He left you in *the taxi*?'

'Uh-huh,' she said, jiggling a little, as though she was really in danger of peeing herself.

'You sucked his cock, and then he sent you home?'

Drew was trying not to laugh, because Emma seemed a little aggrieved by it all.

'He didn't seem upset about it?'

'Not upset,' she said. 'I mean, he smiled at me, told me he'd had a lovely night, and we had to do it again soon... but then he was gone. And I was in the taxi heading back here...'

'Did you make him...'

'Uh-huh,' she said, her tone stressing the injustice of the whole thing. 'Do you know how crazy I'm going right now? And he sends me home without even touching me?'

'You got some wine on your dress,' he said, glancing up.

She lifted the hem of her dress, giving him a nice view of her tiny pink g-string. 'Uh... I don't think that's wine,' she said. 'I guess... in the taxi... I didn't get it all in my mouth.'

He gazed up at her, in awe. It was like he was worshipping her, she was his goddess. She was so desirable. She had just been sucking on another man's cock, making him come in her mouth. Swallowing his come, or most of it.

Why did that make her so devastatingly desirable to him?

'It really gets you going, doesn't it?' she said quietly, and now she was looking down at him in awe. 'It really gets you going to know that I had him in my mouth.'

He was silent, looking up at her, not quite knowing what to say, but unable to deny what she said.

‘It doesn’t freak you out?’ she asked. ‘I mean, I know you’re not jealous...’

‘It doesn’t freak me out,’ he said, now rising to his feet.

‘It turns you on, doesn’t it?’ she said, pulling him toward her. ‘Knowing that I took him in my mouth... and sucked his cock...’

Standing over her, he touched his forehead to hers, breathing in her perfume, gazing at her pretty lips, lips that had stretched around another man’s cock.

‘Was it big?’ he asked her, his hand running down her side, taking in the curve of her waist, her hip, feeling the heat of her body through the thin pink fabric.

‘No,’ she smiled, and then gave a half-amused, half-distraught eye-roll. ‘I mean, I enjoyed playing with it... and it was kind of sweet... but then when he sent me home...’

‘Uh-huh?’ he said, and with his hand on her hip, he could feel the tremors, the little wiggle of sexual desperation.

‘What have I really got to look forward to on our next date?’ she said.

‘He’s cool to hang out with,’ Drew suggested, stroking her hip reassuringly.

‘I have you to hang out with,’ she said.

‘You could hang out with your date, and have sex with your friend,’ Drew joked, but the flames in Emma’s eyes were no joke.

She grabbed his t-shirt, pulled him to her so that his lips pressed against hers. Suddenly, she was kissing him, and he was kissing her, and there was such an intense need between them, it felt as though electricity was flowing between them as they connected. Her lips were so sweet, so soft. And he couldn’t stop thinking about the fact that she’d so recently wrapped them around another man’s cock.

He could even smell the guy on her, couldn’t he? It wasn’t his imagination.

For some reason, it didn't repulse him. Quite the opposite—it seemed to light a spark inside him. He kissed her harder, putting his hands to her jaw, cradling her head as he sucked on her lips. Lachlan had come in her mouth, shot his cream down her throat—it seemed as though that should have put Drew off. It didn't.

'Friends can help each other out, can't they?' he said softly.

'Of course they can,' she said, a little breathless, her smile somewhat surprised, taken aback by their kiss.

He felt her hand close on top of his on her hip, and now she was sliding it over, between her legs. Her little pink panties were already wet. But then, as he gently touched her there, he felt her hand down there too, tugging her panties out of the way of his fingers.

He looked into her eyes and she smiled as he touched her bare sex.

She let out a quiet moan as he brushed the top edge of his forefinger along her slippery groove. Her body quivered as he stroked her there, just fizzing with sexual tension.

'Oh...' she gasped as he pressed his four fingers flat against her pussy, and then slipped the middle digit inside her, feeling her warmth, her copious wetness. 'Oh God...'

As he stroked her there, he edged his face close to hers again, breathing in that strange scent that recalled her earlier encounter with another man's hard cock.

She saw him looking at her, fascinated, and grinned. 'You probably wish he fucked me, don't you?' she said quietly.

'It'll happen soon enough,' he said, pulling up her dress further, exposing her breasts.

'You know I'd give myself to you, if you wanted.'

'You are giving yourself to me,' he said, pushing up her bra to bare her breasts completely, before taking them in his hands.

'I mean only you,' she said. 'If you wanted me all to yourself...'

He smiled, squeezed her nipples between fingers and thumbs to make her close her eyes and gasp. ‘You know you’d never need to do that,’ he said, feeling strange being able to reveal his darkest desires to her—and yet, at the same time, finding the experience fit into a comfortable, familiar pattern. He’d always been able to talk to Emma about anything.

‘You like me seeing other guys,’ she giggled.

‘I don’t see that you should stop something you enjoy on my account,’ he said, stooping to take one of her nipples into his mouth.

‘But it’s not just...’ she moaned as his fingers entered her pussy again, ‘...it’s not just that you’d tolerate me seeing other guys...’

She had to stop for a while as he thrust his fingers inside her—she pressed herself back against the kitchen counter, head tilting back, eyes closed, mouth open, as she gasped over and over.

‘Sorry,’ she smiled, ‘I’m getting carried away...’

‘You have needs,’ he laughed. ‘I’m just helping you out.’

‘I guess I should thank you.’

‘I’m not done yet.’ He kissed her again, and it felt like way beyond the friend thing. He ushered her over to the couch, and she was panting, hard, her chest rising and falling with a real sense of urgency—she needed release, and she needed it now.

He pressed himself against her, tasting her mouth again, sucking on her lips, amazed at just how sweet it was to kiss her. After all the years in which she’d just been a genuine friend, without any hint of attraction, how had he missed how pretty she was, how beautiful her eyes were, how powerfully her smile affected him?

But it was how she responded to him that seemed to draw him the most. The way her breathing deepened, the way she moaned as he touched her, as he kissed her. The way she looked at him with a kind of reverence that he’d never seen before.

Kneeling in front of her, he lifted one of her legs, and began kissing down her inner thigh, and the closer he got to her glistening pussy, the deeper her breathing and the louder her moans.

He gazed at her, and knelt up to remove his shirt, leaving her hanging. She smiled, amused at her own impatience, then admiring his bare chest, and somewhat surprised as he leaned down again, to plant a soft kiss just at the top of her thigh, right beside the edge of her underwear, which had slid back mostly into place over her sex.

‘What are you doing...?’ she asked him quietly.

‘What do you think I’m doing?’ he said, and saw her eyebrow rise up again—intrigued, this time.

He placed his mouth on the thin material covering her pussy, and applied pressure, so that she could feel his heat. Her panties were already soaking wet. He licked her through the sheer material, tasting her wicked sex, making her moan as he grazed his tongue over her sensitive folds, even with the thin barrier in between.

Propping herself up on her elbows, she watched him, surprise and delight imprinted on her face that he would want to do this with her. As though it was such a rarity, despite the number of guys she dated.

He slipped the narrow band of material to the side, and now her gorgeous pussy was completely open to his gaze, her prominent pussy lips flushed and glistening with wetness.

He smiled, and said, ‘You know, I never knew you had a piercing. Not before... you know... the other day.’

She grinned. ‘All those years, you thought I was a good *girl*?’ she joked.

He kissed it, and heard her quiet gasp. ‘Did it hurt?’

‘When I got it? Sure. But it’s been more than worth it ever since...’

Then she sucked in her breath loudly as he slid his tongue along the slippery folds of her exquisite pussy, tasting her tangy flavor, reveling in his

closeness to the center of her sexuality. He loved how she moaned as he began lapping at her lips, how she sighed as he sucked on her lips, as he pressed his face against her, his nose nudging up against her clit, against her silver ring.

He loved how sensitive she was to his every touch, how beautifully she responded to every flick of his tongue, how deep she moaned as he sucked on her, as he penetrated her with the tip of his tongue.

He loved how she looked down on him, in the moments when her eyes weren't screwed tightly shut so she could cope with the sensations he was provoking in her—the way she looked awe-struck, astounded at how he could make her feel.

‘Did this happen on your date, too?’ he smiled, and made her laugh.

‘No,’ she said. ‘Actually... I can't remember when the last time was that someone... ohGod...’

She was panting, gasping for breath, as he increased the intensity of his suction, and the velocity of his tonguing.

How long had he wanted to do this with her? He couldn't believe any of her dates would pass up the chance to do this, to give her this kind of pleasure, to get right up and personal, to taste her divine wetness and hear her sighs and moans from between her thighs.

It was true, he couldn't remember her describing a date going down on her in one of her post-coital briefings. Not for a long time. Most of the men she dated had only wanted her to go down on them, and to get their dicks inside her as quickly as she would allow. Mostly, she had enjoyed that.

But now, she was responding as though she'd only ever had sex in black and white—and this time, for the first time, she was experiencing it in full Technicolor.

‘Oh... God... OhGod...’

Her moans were getting higher and higher in pitch, louder and louder in volume as he continued to lap at her beautiful pussy. She closed her eyes,

lay back and gasped for air, her body writhing, her chest heaving, her hands moving to his head, clamping his face against her hot folds.

‘Oh please... oh please...’ she said, sounding almost as though she was begging for her life.

He was certainly willing to satisfy her demands. He loved her rich, subtle flavor, the thick scent of her powerful arousal, the intense heat of her body, her sex, framed by her underwear and the lace tops of her stockings.

He sucked on her, and fucked her with his tongue, and as her moaning became an urgent, desperate, panting whimper, her breath sharp and stutteringly irregular, he felt her hands crushing him against her, his mouth wedged against her hot wetness, and for a while it seemed like he was doing his utmost just to ride out a powerful storm.

When her climax came, it was like a tsunami reaching the shore, somehow so monumental in scale, so forceful, and completely unstoppable—and yet surprisingly quiet. It wracked her whole system, made her whole body shake and thrash around beneath him with the strength of the feelings flowing through her, and yet she seemed to swallow her scream, as though she hadn’t quite saved enough energy to express her feelings that way.

As the power finally subsided, she was left panting, her chest rising and falling as she tried to recover her breath, one hand placed gently on his head, stroking him affectionately.

‘My God...’ she murmured, quietly, but seemed otherwise at a loss for words.

Drew just stayed there for quite a while, taking in the incredible sight of her from between her thighs, sharing her smile, her amusement at just how powerful the experience seemed to have been for her.

Then, finally, he pulled himself up to sit alongside her, wrapped his arms around her, and just held her. It seemed like the right thing to do, though his own body was crying out for his own sexual closure. She

moaned quietly, completely satisfied but totally spent, and snuggled up against him.

He just enjoyed the closeness with her for a while, not really knowing what to say, not really needing to say anything at all.

When he glanced down, to see how she was feeling, to assess what this all meant, he found to his surprise that she was quietly sleeping. He pulled himself up, then lifted her, and carried her through to her bedroom, where he tucked her up before switching out the light.

OceanofPDF.com

Chapter Thirteen

Sunday, late morning, everybody was in Juno's, enjoying brunch. Fiona, Denny, Sharon, Jess. Even Ray was there, with Harry in tow—the two of them seemed to be getting on like a house on fire, which helped with the energy at the table. And Lachlan was sitting with Emma, looking very pleased with himself.

Drew couldn't help but smile about that—he could tell that the Australian was all buzzed about Emma going down on him in the taxi. But Drew knew for a fact that she would have done more with him if he hadn't sent her home after that BJ.

What was noticeable to Drew was that Emma and Lachlan were sitting very close, very much in the manner of a very loved-up couple.

And the way everyone else was treating Lachlan was very much as part of the group. One of Us.

Drew liked that Emma seemed clearly happy with Lachlan, and enjoying being a couple with him. But for the first time, he felt really insecure about it. He was her best friend, and yet he was sitting almost as far from her as could be—and he felt like he was at the cold edge of the group, farthest from the warm, cozy center of the conversation.

Drew tried, occasionally, to catch Emma's eye. Did she even remember what had happened late the previous night? It wasn't that he wanted her to

pull away from Lachlan and act all ‘coupley’ with him instead, but after taking the risk in turning their friendship into a friendship-plus-benefits arrangement with a physical aspect, he didn’t want Emma to forget all about it.

He knew she’d been asleep when he’d carried her back to her own apartment. But had she really been drunk enough to lose her memory?

Here was Emma, casually telling the group that she and Lachlan were going to check out the SoWa Open Market that afternoon. It really didn’t seem like something Emma would want to do—it was more like a thing to do when you were married, even with kids, touring stalls laden with arty and crafty and foodie things. Were they becoming a proper, bona fide couple?

Then Fiona and Denny were giving them the rundown of the market, and that confirmed it as not Emma’s kind of thing. Drew felt his phone buzz in his pocket. He pulled it out and saw that he’d received a text message—from Emma.

Emma: Should I feel a little bad for cheating on him?

Drew stifled a chuckle, and attracted an odd look from Ray, but he made it seem like he merely had a cough. He glanced at his phone screen again, feeling a warm glow building inside. She remembered, then. He definitely felt good about that. She remembered, and she was thinking about it right now.

He texted her back, subtly, since it wasn’t exactly the most sociable thing to be peering at his phone while having brunch with everyone. He wondered how the hell Emma had texted him without people noticing—he certainly hadn’t noticed her looking at her phone.

Drew: Have you told him you guys are exclusive yet?

A few moments later, and he saw her eyes drop to her lap, and though she hid it well, he could tell she was tapping out a text message reply.

Emma: Not yet, but I think maybe he assumes we are.

Drew: Then you're not cheating on him. And anyway, is it cheating if there's been no penetration?

It wasn't as though he actually believed in the Clintonian model of fidelity, but it was an argument that could just about be used with some people. He found himself thinking how it might be for Emma to pursue a full committed relationship with Lachlan, only to periodically come to Drew for a little sexual release along the way. If it was always limited to oral sex, would he be okay with that?

God, yeah.

But then she texted him back, saying:

Emma: Hasn't been any yet. But might need it soon?

Drew's heart-rate quickened.

'Hey, you okay, buddy?' Ray was looking at him, concerned.

'Uh... yeah,' Drew said, blushing a little, thinking he was totally busted.

'You look... stressed.' Ray was giving him a pitying expression. It was an expression that said, *I know you have a crush on Emma, and now she's found unexpected life-long happiness with Lachlan, what are you going to do?*

'Just... you know... work stuff.'

'You're sure?' Ray sounded as though he was about to recommend a therapist to help him get over his tragic crush.

'You know... they just put up tariffs on whisky...'

Now he typed Emma a reply, saying:

Drew: You know it's not what you have, but what you do with it?

Emma: He doesn't do anything with it!

Drew had to stifle another chuckle. Ray didn't notice this time, thankfully, since he was buried in conversation with Denny about whether the Patriots had put Stephen Gostkowski on IR because he was genuinely

injured, or because it would be cruel to simply release him after everything he'd done for them.

Drew: You need to start off with dinner at your place, and then keep him there. Lock him in, if you have to.

Emma: Lol. I'm not sure he's as kinky as you are, honeybun

He looked over at her, and couldn't believe how she completely concealed her phone use. She looked as though she was really focused on whatever Sharon and Jess were saying. Drew couldn't focus on anything but his phone.

Drew: Give him time, I'm sure he has secrets

Emma: I bet they're not as fun as YOUR secrets

Drew kept trying to catch Emma's eye, to make her smile, or something, just to acknowledge that this little private conversation of theirs was really happening—or maybe to trip her up, to show that she was actually using her phone at all. But she was avoiding his gaze.

She didn't even say a proper goodbye when brunch was over, and Drew had to go to work. A little smile from across the room was about all he got.

And then Drew was working, and presumably Emma was away strolling arm-in-arm with Lachlan through various market stalls. Drew didn't even think much about her plan to seduce the Australian with dinner at her place.

But then, when it was getting to be dinner time—or at least, an early dinner time—she sent him a text message that was a little disappointing.

Emma: Well, we're done touring the market, but the bad news, now we're meeting up with his friends.

Drew glanced at her message in between orders, and while he was mixing Negroni and a Boulevardier he was trying to figure out something he could say back to her that appeared positive. He could hardly tell her that her plan to get him alone in a private space so she could rip off his pants and devour him was now scuppered.

Finally, he came up with something harmless, bland, sounding as though it was plucked straight from the pages of Cosmo.

Drew: Isn't that a good sign for a relationship? He's introducing you to all his buddies?

Emma: I don't want to have dinner with all his buddies, I want to have dinner at home, just the two of us, so I can get him drunk and then jump him.

This made Drew smile, so much so that one of the other bartenders working with him that night—Suzy—asked him if someone had sent him an amusing cat picture. Without even thinking about it, he told Suzy that Emma had said something funny.

Suzy said, 'Isn't she out with Lachlan tonight?'

'Uh... yeah, I think so,' Drew said, feeling suddenly a little self-conscious, a little fearful that Suzy might feel he shouldn't be texting with Emma while she was out on a date with Lachlan.

'Right—apparently tonight's going to be a big one for them,' Suzy flashed her eyes with wicked intent.

Drew was suddenly nervous. 'A big one?'

God. He was actually worried that Lachlan was planning on popping the question. But they'd only been going out a couple of weeks.

Suzy grinned, and just before turning away from him to take another order from a hipster couple at the bar, she did a sly little hand signal that only Drew could see—making a circle out of her thumb and forefinger on one hand, then threading her other forefinger through that circle.

Drew raised his eyebrows in surprise, and it made Suzy laugh. He had to wait until she was done with her order to probe her on what she meant.

'Lachlan tells you that kind of stuff?' he asked her.

Suzy grinned, 'Sure. We do so many mid-week late shifts together, so what else is there to talk about? He's totally into her.'

‘But they haven’t...’ Drew mimicked Suzy’s hand signal from before, ‘... yet?’

Suzy smiled and shook her head. ‘Well, you know, they’ve only been dating a couple of weeks.’

Drew nodded, amused that for normal people it was probably perfectly reasonable to wait a couple of weeks before sleeping with somebody new. For Emma, it was like some kind of apocalyptic disaster that she had to wait that long.

Drew said, ‘But he told you tonight’s the big night?’

Suzy said, ‘Well, maybe not in so many words. But he said he’s introducing her to his friends tonight. That’s, like, the last hurdle to a steady relationship, right? If your friends all seem to approve of your date... well, then you can start to call them your boyfriend, right? Or girlfriend.’

Drew felt his heart burn. Girlfriend. Emma was going to be someone else’s girlfriend. That didn’t seem right. At the same time, Drew realized that if he wasn’t going to risk their friendship and actually try to date her himself, then someday he was going to have to face up to the possibility that she would become someone else’s girlfriend.

It just didn’t seem like Emma. She’d never been with a guy long enough to be ever termed a ‘girlfriend’.

‘And you think that means tonight they’re going to...’ Drew did the little hand signal again. They were like kids talking smutty behind a friend’s back because he or she had a crush on someone.

‘Well, he told me the other day that he was getting the vibes from her, that maybe she’s ready for something...’

Drew had to stifle a laugh. He wondered what kind of vibes Emma had put out that had alerted Lachlan to the fact that she was ready for sex. Perhaps it had been sucking his cock in the taxi.

‘Did she say anything to you?’ Suzy asked him. ‘I mean, she’s your friend, right? You guys tell each other everything.’

‘Oh, she’s ready,’ Drew said. ‘She’s definitely ready.’

For a fraction of a second, Suzy gave him a look that could only be described as excitement. And it only took that fraction of a second, before he was distracted by more customers calling out for drinks, for Drew to realize that Suzy was probably going to go straight to her phone when she next got a quiet moment to herself, to text Lachlan to provide confirmation that Emma was ready.

Suzy had been subtly grilling Drew for information about Emma, on behalf of her date.

Well, the guy obviously hadn’t been picking up any of her body language, even when it was as obvious as oral sex in a taxi. He needed every kind of assistance possible.

But Drew felt quietly excited himself. Had he just given the Australian a green light to have sex with Emma? Not just a green light, a neon flashing sign.

When there was a minor lull in the number of people demanding early evening cocktails, Drew pulled out his phone to let Emma know that something might happen that night. Well, if Suzy could be Lachlan’s intelligence source, he could be Emma’s.

Drew: Good news. I have it on good authority that he might be planning on doing the deed tonight. ;-)

Emma wasn’t long in replying to the message—but then Drew knew how easily she could carry out a text conversation while hanging out with friends without any of them realizing she wasn’t 100% focused on their face-to-face conversation.

Emma: You have it on good authority? Whose authority? Has he been bragging about sleeping with me?

Drew: Suzy said he told her he thought you were giving off the kind of vibes that meant you might be ready for it. You know, he’s close with Suzy. They tell each other everything.

Emma: Are they close, like, he helps her out with the occasional orgasm if she's disappointed with her dates? ;-)

Drew felt his manhood thicken as he read that message—to know that Emma was thinking about how he'd touched her. How he'd gone down on her. And the implication in her message that, perhaps, if she was ever disappointed with her dates again, it might re-occur.

Drew: I'm not sure if they're quite that close. They're not BFFs. But they're close enough.

Emma: Everyone should be that close with their BFF :-P

Drew laughed again, eliciting a probing look from Suzy that made her look more like Lachlan's spy than ever. He felt all warm inside. That Emma referred to him as her BFF, even after everything that had happened between them, made it seem as though they were both on the same page. They could be BFFs and be attracted to each other. They could be BFFs and engage in a little light touching now and again. They were still BFFs.

There was the unresolved issue of Emma not being comfortable with Drew dating Laura, but perhaps that would be resolved by him dating a stranger instead.

Emma's next text seemed very insightful.

Emma: So Lachlan asked Suzy if she thinks I'm ready for it, and she then asked you if you think I'm ready for it. So the question is, what did you tell her?

Drew: I told her you were definitely ready for it.

Emma replied with emojis showing hands clapping, and smiley faces celebrating—well, at least she was happy with the way Drew had responded to Suzy.

Drew: So you think Suzy's going to tell Lachlan what I said?

Emma: Of course. Why else would she ask you? Thank God, I say. It's just a shame I'm not wearing sexy underwear right now.

Drew: I bet that's not true.

He laughed as she sent through a picture—and he had to go seal himself in a stall in the men’s room to really check it out. She had managed to take a selfie up her skirt, even while sitting around a table having drinks with Lachlan and his friends. She was wearing a pair of pale gray Calvin Klein panties—perfectly sexy, but perhaps more of a wholesome, sporty look than the kind of lace or satin that might seem more erotic.

Drew: Looks pretty good to me.

Emma: Maybe I could sneak off to change them when I get him home. Only problem is if he takes me back to his place.

Drew was about to let himself out of his stall and leave Emma to it, but then he had a mischievous idea. He texted her:

Drew: Just take them off, if you’re worried about it.

He went back to work. Twenty minutes later, Emma texted him another picture—this time, she was standing in front of a mirror in a public restroom, looking very respectable in her black top and khaki skirt, except that she was lifting the hem of her skirt to reveal a total absence of panties.

Drew: I didn’t mean take them off right now.

Emma: Feels pretty good, actually. You don’t think he’ll think I’m too slutty?

Drew: Tell him you just like going without panties when you’re wearing a skirt.

Emma: He’ll expect me to do it every time I wear a skirt.

Drew: Thought you said it feels pretty good?

Emma: :-P

A couple of hours later, Drew was taking a break, tucking into a plate of fried chicken in the office, when Emma texted him again.

Emma: We’re all having dinner, it’s quite a nice place. Do you think he’s really going to do it tonight?

Drew: Guaranteed.

Emma: What if it’s really bad? He’s so small.

Drew: Maybe it was just cold in that taxi. You never know.

Emma: It wasn't cold in my mouth.

Drew: It's not what you have, it's what you do with it.

Emma: Yeah, there's limits to that philosophy. Hey. Is it cheating if I sleep with Lachlan... and then I need a little help from my BFF to finish?

Drew: Depends if you guys have decided you're exclusive or not.

After that, he had to get back to work again, but he was buzzing as he went out there. Would Emma really want to repeat what they'd done before, even if her relationship with Lachlan went fully sexual?

OceanofPDF.com

Chapter Fourteen

He was in bed, almost asleep, when he heard the front door open and close. He didn't even move, assuming that it was Ray coming home.

But then Drew's bedroom door opened, and Emma stepped inside the room, almost silently. That made him wake up.

'Hey, you okay?' he said, suddenly fearful that she was upset, that something had gone badly on her date.

But she smiled, and quietly closed the door before slipping off her little khaki skirt. He saw that she had her Calvin Klein panties on, and then when she turned to face him, and walk toward the bed peeling off her black top at the same time, he saw that she was wearing a matching Calvin Klein bra.

'I thought you took them off?' he said.

She laughed as she approached his bed. 'I had to wear something in the taxi home,' she said. 'I didn't want him leaking out of me.'

Drew's eyes widened—and his cock thickened. 'It happened, then?'

She nodded. 'Finally,' she said, climbing into bed beside him. Almost immediately, he breathed in the strong scent of her perfume—but then once he got past the sweet top notes of her fragrance, he found he could detect the clear earthiness underneath that told of her recent physical activity, her arousal, her sex.

‘And how was it?’ he asked, enjoying how comfortable she was in being with him, next to him, close to him.

He could see the slight sheen of drying perspiration on her skin, the dampness in her hair. There could be no doubt—she’d either had a long workout in the gym, or she’d been enjoying a lot of sex.

‘It was nice,’ she said, and he tried not to react with any kind of surprise or shock as she slid her hand down over his bare chest, dipped under the bedsheet, and found the bulge developing between his legs. ‘I mean... I like hanging out with him... I like making him feel good...’

‘But the sex?’

‘He’s just a little *small*,’ she said, with a regretful smile. Drew felt her hand slip under the waistband of his boxer shorts, and her fingers were finding—and curling around—his thickening shaft.

She caught her breath as she first touched it, then looked him in the eyes with a wicked smile spreading across her pretty face.

‘You’ve got the most wonderful... *gorgeous* cock...’ she said, squeezing his rapidly hardening cock.

‘You just think that because your boyfriend’s small,’ he chuckled.

‘Not at all,’ she said, making him moan as she started pumping his shaft under the sheet. ‘I’ve had plenty of experience to provide comparison.’

She was biting her bottom lip, her eyes aflame as she squeezed and pumped his cock. He could only close his eyes and moan, his whole body shaking and fizzing with sexual energy. He couldn’t believe how electric it felt, for her to be touching him like that, so intimately. It had never been like this with any other woman before. Sure, he didn’t exactly have a lot of experience—certainly not any recent experience—but he knew this was different.

Was it his crush? Was it the way his desire for her had been building and building ever since he had accidentally watched her having sex with Vincent?

Or was it the fact that he'd known her his whole life, and all those years of closeness had laid the framework for an explosive crossover into a sexual relationship?

At least part of it was the knowledge that she was sexually active with others—that she had just had sex with Lachlan.

'You make me so wet, you know that?' she said, withdrawing her hand from his cock, only to slip it under the waistband of her Calvin Klein panties, to delve between her own legs.

He watched her stroking herself for a few moments, and could smell a burst of the wicked spice of her arousal. Then she pulled her hand out, sliding her glistening fingers against each other to show him how soaking wet they were.

Then she bit her lip again, and reached for his cock, and he felt her slippery fingers coaxing him, rubbing her juices over his shaft.

Drew couldn't help remembering what she'd said about her underwear: *I didn't want him leaking out of me*. Were her fingers slick with another man's come? It seemed so wrong, so completely counter to standards of common decency. And yet, for some inexplicable, primordial way, the thought turned him on no end. Was her sweet pussy dripping with another man's semen?

'So he... he came inside you?' he asked her.

She grinned. 'Uh-huh,' she said, her face so close to his as she stroked his cock, he could smell another man on her. 'Does it freak you out?'

'No... I don't think so.'

'You don't want me to go take a long, hot shower? Clean myself up?'

'No. Don't.'

She pressed her mouth to his, sucked on his top lip, slid her tongue against his. He could taste a faint saltiness on her, he could breathe in that weird, funky note of cologne blended in with her perfume. She had just

been fucked by someone else. Another man had put his dick inside her mouth, inside her sex.

It should have grossed him out. But it only drove his desire for her to lofty heights.

As she was kissing him, she pushed him down on the mattress so that he was lying flat, and tore off the sheet. Then she was slithering down his chest, kissing him here and there, her hand moving back to grab hold of his huge, rock-hard cock. She moved down to lie between his thighs, and peeled his underwear completely off so that it was just her and his exposed cock.

‘I thought you preferred... sucking on small ones,’ he said, smiling as she looked up at him hungrily, kissing the tip of his cock.

‘I never said I preferred it,’ she said. ‘I said it was easier.’

‘Oh, okay. Easier.’

‘It’s easier to play *Twinkle Twinkle, Little Star* on the piano than Chopin,’ she said, gazing at his flagpole of a cock, ‘but you know... if you can do it... Chopin’s just magnificent...’

She sank down on his shaft, stretching her lips around his full girth, one hand wrapped around the lower half of his cock. She moaned deeply with pleasure as she sucked on him.

‘God...’ Drew moaned as he watched her lick the underside of his cock from base to tip a couple of times before she took him back inside her hot mouth.

‘I can’t believe you’ve been keeping this from me, all these years,’ she said, stroking her cheek against his full length, rubbing her lips around the tip, exploring it as though she couldn’t quite believe it was real.

‘You were always so busy with your other dates,’ he joked. ‘I never thought you would be interested.’

‘If I’d have known what you were packing...’

She sucked him deeply, powerfully, making him gasp.

‘If we’d dated back when we first met, you would still have gotten bored of this eventually,’ he said.

‘How could I get bored *of this*?’ she laughed, pumping him with both hands.

‘I remember you dating enough guys with big cocks...’ Drew chuckled.

‘I told you they had big cocks?’ she was surprised.

‘You tell me lots of things,’ he said. ‘Especially when you’ve had a few glasses of wine.’

‘But none of those guys had anything going for them but big cocks,’ she said.

‘Do you think we would have stayed friends if we’d dated?’ he asked her.

She shrugged. ‘I don’t know. I’d like to think we would have.’

‘But you would have needed to date other guys as well.’

‘Would you have let me?’ she grinned, stroking his cock around her mouth.

‘I don’t know... I mean... I would now... but back then... I’m not sure...’

‘I could have cheated on you,’ she said, flashing her eyes up at him. ‘Would that have been it for our friendship if you’d discovered it?’

‘I’d like to think it wouldn’t have been,’ he said, pulling her up toward him so that he could kiss her sweet mouth. Then he kissed her neck, saying, ‘you know there’s something strangely hot about the thought of you cheating.’

He kissed the rise of her chest, and she pulled his head to her, pressing his face against her breasts. ‘I guess I’m cheating on Lachlan,’ she said.

‘You never told him you were exclusive.’

‘No. But some guys assume when you sleep with them... you’ve decided to be exclusive.’

‘But this is just two best friends helping each other out, isn’t it?’

‘You’re going to help me out?’ she grinned, and pushed him down on the bed only to crawl up his body, so that she was kneeling over him, her sex just an inch or two from his face. He could see the dampness darkening the lower portion of her gray panties.

He reached for her hips, and tugged her panties down, sliding out from under her so that he could drag them down her thighs. Then he pulled them past her knees, her ankles.

By that point she was on all fours in front of him, lowering her head, pushing up her behind to give him a stunning view of her bare pussy, her soaking wet pussy.

He leaned in, and kissed her just beside her pussy, making her quietly yelp with surprise. The powerful scent of sex was just intoxicating, exhilarating, it tickled something deep inside him that he hadn’t ever really felt before. He felt a rush—adrenaline, perhaps, but perhaps testosterone, the male hormone. It made him feel suddenly so strong, so powerful.

So unbelievably hard.

He knelt up, and placed one hand on the small of her back as his other guided the tip of his brutally stiff cock to the glistening pink entrance to her sex. He felt like a newly-crowned alpha-king of the lions, about to claim the prize female in the pride. About to mate with her, after she’d only just mated with the old, defeated king.

Emma said quietly, ‘Please... please...’

Then he leaned into her, and his hardness sank easily into her hot, dripping sex.

‘Oh dear Lord...’ Emma moaned as he thrust into her, stretching her well-used pussy around him, filling her completely.

She gasped as he began to move within her, stirring his hips to work his length out, and then back into her beautifully slick pussy.

It felt just heavenly. Just silky, gliding into her slowly, again and again.

‘I can’t believe it...’ she sighed, her breathing becoming panting. ‘Oh god... Oh God...’

He was fucking her, so soon after another man. Her pussy was wet with another man’s come.

Other men just wouldn’t understand it. Other men would be repulsed, sickened by it. But for Drew, it felt entirely natural, nothing to be concerned by. He was simply taking her for himself. He was using his cock to clear her out. Why else would a cock be shaped that way? It was biology.

She quickly drew close to orgasm—and Drew was getting close, too. It was such an intense experience for them both.

After all these years, he was fucking her. Emma. He was inside his best friend.

But he wasn’t ready to come yet. He pulled back, ducked down, wiped away the traces of Lachlan’s come from around her beautiful sex, and now wedged his mouth against her pussy, tasting her, sucking on her, pressing his tongue against her.

‘Oh Jesus...’ she yelled, reaching back to try to grab his head, to pull him against her tightly so that she could have her release.

But he teased her, pulling back, stroking her with his cock, then kissing her there with his mouth. Getting her close to the edge, and then stepping back, again and again. Still on all fours, she had to support herself with one hand, but the other she used to squeeze her breasts, clamp hold of her nipples, trying to get herself over the crest of the wave, to bring on her full climax.

He didn’t let her come.

Then she was kneeling up, a frantic expression on her pretty face. She pulled him down on the bed, and he allowed her to move him, amused at her desperation. He lay on his back, as she wanted, and then she straddled his face.

There was no teasing now. She was in control. She sat and pressed her pussy down over his mouth, her thighs pressed at his cheeks, locking his head in place.

He gazed up to see her removing her bra while he slipped out his tongue to taste her.

Then she was holding his head with both her hands and riding his face, stirring her hips to grind her wet pussy against his mouth, to control his movement against her while he sucked eagerly at her exquisite sex.

Such a stunning sight, gazing up her body, her skin increasingly shiny with perspiration, her chest rising and falling as she gasped for breath, her nipples jutting out, hard as bullets, as she stroked her soaking pussy over his mouth and nose.

While she held his head in place with one hand, now she leaned back to reach behind her, to take hold of his hard cock in her other hand. She tugged on him for a while until the intensity of the feelings stemming from his mouth on her pussy got to be too much. Then she was leaning forward again, focusing everything on his lips, his tongue, crying out, 'please... please... please...'

He loved making her sigh and moan like that. Her soprano voice was like the finest music as she danced over his face.

'Yeah... yeah... yeah...'

Then her whole body was twitching and shivering over him, trembling and shuddering. Her loss of control made her giggle at first, but then as her orgasm detonated within her, the powerful sensations tearing through her whole frame, she could only gasp and cry, and ride the phenomenal tremors.

She fell back onto the mattress to cope with the intensity of it all, but then she was reaching for him again, urging him to her, to slide his enormous cock back inside her.

'Give it to me,' she said, lying back as he thrust into her.

He plunged into her, lying over her so that he could kiss her mouth. Could she taste herself on his lips? Well, it was only sex. It wasn't a big deal.

They were just two friends, helping each other out.

When she was on top of him again, straddling him, gyrating her hips so that his cock never actually withdrew from inside her burning-hot pussy, it was so hot and sweaty it was like they were simply enjoying a joint workout together.

And yet, somehow, it wasn't just sex. It wasn't just physical. After so long as best friends, there was an emotional intensity to their connection that Drew couldn't have predicted.

Sure, he'd always felt something for the women he'd bedded. He'd always waited a while before sleeping with them. He'd always developed emotional attachments before any kind of penetration could occur. That was why it always shattered his heart to break up with them.

But this time, it was like nothing he had ever felt. Their every touch of each other seemed to summon up electricity. Their every kiss was like fireworks going off around their lips. And when he entered her, the adrenaline made it feel like racing a car at two hundred miles an hour.

When his end finally came, it was like the two of them were a single being, their bodies responding to each other in perfect harmony. And when he felt his orgasm building inside him, it didn't surprise him to hear her building toward something too, her body beginning to shake as the powerful climax approached within her.

He was on top of her again, pounding into her as it hit him, harder than anything he'd felt before.

Then he was kissing her, and she was moaning and laughing and smiling, almost delirious as another orgasm consumed her, and she felt her best friend let go of all his worries and come deep inside her, over and over.

‘Oh my God...’

He lay beside her, his face beside her thigh, just gazing at her, marveling at her beauty. She looked incredibly content, absolutely satisfied, her cheeks and chest flushed a delicate pink, her breasts rising and falling gently as she recovered her breath.

‘Nobody ever made me come like that before,’ she said, her tone one of awe, incomprehension.

‘Somebody must have,’ he laughed, stroking the soft skin of her stomach, his eyes dropping to the bewitching sight of her pink pussy, open and shining with her dew.

‘No, no one,’ she said seriously.

He trailed his finger down to her smooth, hairless mound, tracing out the topography of her intimate area. ‘It’s probably because you were all warmed up by your date,’ he suggested.

‘That might have helped,’ she agreed, ‘but it’s not the whole reason.’

‘And you went without sex for so long...’ Drew chuckled.

He watched as a little trickle of white cream dribbled from her pussy lips, and she reached down to dip a finger in it, before bringing her finger to her mouth to taste it.

‘Mmm...’ she moaned, giving him a mischievous grin. Then, ‘Can I tell you a secret?’

‘Sure.’

‘You know when I went out for a date with that guy, Vincent?’ she said. Drew felt his ears burning. ‘You know, the stockbroker with the shaven head.’

‘Uh-huh,’ Drew said, feeling himself blushing.

‘*I saw you watching us,*’ she whispered, her eyes seeming to ignite into green flames.

‘Seriously?’ he was surprised, to know. But not shocked. And now she was lying next to him, entirely naked, and he could still taste her pussy on

his lips, he didn't feel that she could be angry that he had watched her with Vincent.

She smiled, shrugged. 'I guess you had a little too much of that wine, huh? You fell asleep on my couch.'

'Yeah, something like that.'

'I thought you'd sneak away while our backs were turned, maybe you'd be all embarrassed about it,' she said, 'but you didn't. You stayed to watch.'

'You didn't stop,' he pointed out.

She smiled, 'I didn't see the point—it was clear what Vincent and I were up to. By the time I realized you were there, you'd seen everything, it wasn't as though I could cover anything up...'

'I'm sorry,' he said, earnest.

But her smile didn't falter. 'No. The thing was... I liked it. I mean, really liked it. It was the biggest thrill, seeing you watching. The way you looked at me. And... you know, I've had threesomes before... but this was you... I'd never been so turned on before... and then you were stroking yourself...'

'You could see?'

She giggled, stroking herself, now, as she remembered. 'You thought you were all safely hidden by the couch?' she said. 'You do realize you had a wall of windows behind you—I could see everything reflected in that glass.'

'Damn.'

'No, it's okay,' she said, slipping her fingers into her mouth again, tasting his cream. 'After that, it took me a while to figure out... you know... why you wanted to watch me like that. I mean, at one point I thought maybe you weren't watching me, you were watching Vincent...'

'If you could see me, you must have known I wasn't watching Vincent,' Drew said.

She nodded. 'But none of it made any sense to me. Because we were friends. We'd been friends forever, and you'd never shown any hint of attraction toward me...'

'So when you were showing me your date outfits after that,' Drew deduced, 'and suddenly you were showing me your underwear...'

'Well, I could tell you were attracted to me after that,' she laughed. 'But you know, ever since then, I haven't been able to get it out of my head—the thought of you watching me.'

'Why didn't you say anything?' he said.

'Because I was so confused. I mean, I couldn't figure it out at all, at first,' she said, shifting down on the bed a little, so she could reach his softening cock, to play with it. 'I figured out that you liked me, that you were attracted to me... but then, why didn't you say anything to me about that?'

'About liking you? I didn't want to ruin our friendship.'

'You didn't say anything about watching me, either.'

'It was embarrassing. And... I mean, you would have said I was creepy.'

'I know you. I know you so well... that's why when you were watching me... and I saw how you were looking at me... there was nothing creepy about it'

He was stiffening again, recovering from their sex in record time.

'Then you were deliberately... well, getting me to touch you...' he said.

Emma smiled, 'I couldn't resist. And by then, the way you were looking at me... and you weren't jealous at all, even when I was talking about my dates... and how you responded to watching me with Vincent... it fit a pattern.'

'A pattern?'

She lifted a leg over his thighs, and then she was lying on him, sliding down a little, and his stiffening cock slid so easily back inside her.

‘You know, I’ve dated a lot of guys,’ Emma said. Drew felt her pussy gripping his cock, somehow celebrating its rapid return to hardness.

‘Sure, of course.’

‘A couple years ago... I dated a couple,’ she said.

‘Seriously?’

‘It was pretty hot, actually,’ she said, slowly circling her hips over him to stir his cock within her.

‘You never said anything about it.’

‘It was weird,’ she laughed. ‘I wasn’t sure what to think about it. I met this guy in a club—he was seriously hot, but a few years older than me. We were dancing... and then I noticed someone watching us from the edge of the dance floor. A woman.’

‘His wife?’

Emma nodded. ‘I didn’t know that until the end of the night. I noticed her watching... but she didn’t do anything. She didn’t intervene, or tell me to get my hands off her hubby, or anything. After a while she disappeared, I didn’t see her, and I forgot about her.’

‘And then?’

‘You know... it got late... I was dancing with the guy, he had his hands all over me... we were making out... and then he asked me if I wanted to go somewhere, have some fun.’

‘So romantic,’ Drew grinned.

Emma wiggled her hips, rubbing the tip of Drew’s cock against her g-spot. ‘I already knew by then that I wanted him,’ she said. ‘And... you know, I can take care of myself. But then there was the woman again, when we walked off the dance floor.’

‘What happened?’

‘He introduced me to her, and asked if I would mind if she tagged along,’ she said. ‘I’ve never really been into women... but I’d had enough to

drink—and I wanted the guy badly enough—that I figured it could be okay.’

‘And was it?’

Emma smiled, ‘His wife was really friendly, as soon as we got out of there, but when it came to the bedroom... well, she just watched.’

‘She just watched?’

‘It wasn’t like a threesome—it was me and her husband, and she watched everything.’

‘Oh, okay.’

‘And afterward, she was really nice, and not at all bitter or jealous or anything, but I had to go because she really wanted to jump her husband. I was, like, fine, go ahead. She was all apologetic for wanting me out of there, but no sooner was I off the bed, she launched herself at her husband. Really wanted him, so badly.’

‘And you think I’m like her?’ Drew asked, amused.

Emma shrugged, ‘I saw them a couple more times, and the truth is, that normally when they went out, the husband would sit at the bar and watch his wife flirting with other guys, and then they’d take some guy home so he could watch his wife sleeping with him. That’s the more normal way around, apparently. Only, the wife wanted to see her husband with somebody else, to try and see how it felt. She liked it, but not as much as he liked her when she was cheating.’

‘Not really cheating, though, is it? If the husband’s watching.’

Emma shook her head, ‘I suppose not.’

‘And you think I’m like that?’

‘I think you’d love it more if you could watch me with someone,’ she said.

Drew laughed. ‘I don’t think Lachlan would be too happy if I was there while he slept with you.’

Chapter Fifteen

After that, Drew found he had to be careful around Emma. The temptation was to go up to her, whenever he saw her, and kiss her as though they were lovers. The trouble was, physically he felt like they were lovers—his whole body responded to her as though they were lovers.

But they were not lovers, not as far as the world around them knew. Mentally, he had to force himself to act as though they were still only friends.

If they were hanging out after work with any of their friends, they had to act as though they were still merely best friends. If they were hanging out in Drew's apartment, they had to act that way, too, in case Ray came home. If they were alone in Emma's apartment, and not expecting any of their friends to join them, the atmosphere changed.

There was real affection between them, now. They were BFFs with benefits, but the benefits weren't just a physical thing. Drew tried to resist thinking of it as love, and certainly didn't say the L-word to Emma. But it was more than just giving her a sexual outlet because Lachlan couldn't make her come.

If they were alone at night in Emma's place, she would curl up with him on the couch. Kiss him. Stroke him. And he could kiss her, put his arms around her, snuggle up with her.

‘I found this article in Elite Magazine,’ she said one evening while they were watching *Fight Club* on TV, coming to sit with him bearing a computer print-out. ‘It said a lot of men are turned on by watching their lover with somebody else.’

‘You print that article out at work?’ he laughed.

She shrugged, ‘People print tons of stuff out at work, nobody looks at what you print. And this has no pictures, so you know.’

‘Still. Risky.’

‘Check this out; this woman has an open relationship,’ she said, quoting the article: ‘my boyfriend allows me to have sex with other people. Once in a while, I document the experience, and he gets immense pleasure out of watching me. I won’t lie—I get turned on by how turned on he gets from watching me, too.’

She looked at him, sparks in her eyes. ‘That’s how it is for you and me, don’t you think?’

‘I guess so,’ he smiled. She was stroking his manhood through his pants, now.

‘Maybe I should make a sex tape with Lachlan,’ Emma said. ‘Then you could watch us.’

‘Maybe you should,’ Drew said, slipping a hand over one of her breasts, seeing her breathing deepen as a result. ‘I thought the main problem was, he’s not all that great at sex.’

‘He isn’t,’ she said, ‘but it still turns me on—knowing that I can come to you after we’re done, and tell you all about it, and that’ll turn you on. Making a sex tape for you would be hot.’

‘It would,’ he nodded, ‘you’d just have to be careful not to give the game away.’

‘It’s really helpful, this article,’ Emma said, letting out a little moan as Drew’s attention to her breasts continued. ‘It says, ‘seeing your boo get slammed by someone else confirms your boo’s desirability.’

‘‘Boo?’’

‘You know, boyfriend or girlfriend. Women’s mags use it all the time. Here: ‘No one wants to have a girlfriend or boyfriend he or she is ashamed to go out with,’’ she said, reading from the article. “After learning that neutral parties consider our partners hot, we can take a deep breath and say to ourselves, ‘my head’s on straight’.’

Drew turned her now, and kissed her. It felt so good, even just kissing her. So warm, and sweet, with that buzz that was just like some kind of drug-fueled high. ‘I know other people consider you hot,’ he smiled. ‘I don’t need to see someone fucking you just to confirm it.’

‘No,’ she nodded, ‘but it’s psychological, don’t you see? I think it means, deep down, you feel rewarded for choosing me, because you know that other people would be impressed knowing that you have me.’

‘But other people don’t know that I have you.’

‘Not yet...’ she grinned, and Drew felt his hardness throbbing. So, she did consider them as lovers, now, no longer just best friends with benefits? He did like that idea. If he forgot about the possibility of them ever breaking up, then it was appealing as ideas went.

‘So someday, you’d want people to know we’re together?’ he asked her.

‘Uh-huh,’ she said, moving one of his hands down between her legs. He could feel the heat down there, through the thick denim of her jeans. ‘Don’t you?’

‘You wouldn’t worry that... you know... if we were ever to break up...’

‘Why would we ever break up?’ she said, unfastening her belt, then her fly, so that his hand could dip down to touch her through her panties. ‘We’ve been together since we were kids. And if I’m ever tempted to sleep with another guy...’

Drew kissed her, ‘You could go straight ahead and sleep with him.’

She smiled, ‘And then I’d come back to you and tell you everything.’

He slipped down onto the floor, kneeling in front of her so he could pull off her jeans—and then her panties, which were already damp.

‘Here, it says, ‘Everything’s a game, and we want the winning trophy, even when it comes to romance,’ she read from the paper, and then moaned as Drew kissed her inner thigh. She parted her legs further, inviting him in as she continued to read: “So it makes sense that we like to compete for our partner’s attention, in the game of love... Earning the attention we deserve in the bedroom makes us place value on who we are as human beings.”

Emma stopped reading as Drew began lapping at her soaking pussy.

He still wasn’t sure about the reasons behind why he felt as he did about watching Emma sleep with other men—or even just hearing about it. But it did actually make him feel better about himself to know that he wasn’t alone in feeling this way. Actually, it was common enough that women’s magazines were writing about it.

On another occasion, Emma came home from a work trip to Cleveland bearing another article, this one from a psychology magazine.

‘Okay, this one’s based on actual interviews with couples where the husband is turned on by his wife’s infidelity,’ she said, as he gave her a back rub in front of an episode of *The Good Place*, which soon turned sexual as she peeled off her top, and then her bra.

‘It’s not infidelity if the husband’s in favor, surely?’ Drew pointed out, although he liked the thought of a wife having permission to ‘cheat’.

‘In this article the guy calls it ‘wife sharing’,’ Emma giggled. ‘Like, the husband is ‘sharing’ his wife with other guys.’

‘Okay... I can see that,’ Drew said, reaching around to gently fondle Emma’s bare breasts. They were sitting on the floor between the couch and the TV, which gave ample room for Emma to sit between Drew’s legs while he coaxed the stress out of her back muscles—and occasionally reached around to stroke her breasts.

‘This bit says that because men have all watched so much porn... they incorporate it into their marital sexuality,’ she explained, quoting, “watching your wife have sex with another man may be a next step, or progression, from watching yourselves have sex by having a mirror on the ceiling, then using a video camera during sex, and finally watching one’s spouse with someone else.’

Drew had her lie down, and remove her pants so that he could rub her thighs and her calves. He’d never really given anyone a massage before, but it wasn’t difficult to pick up. And it was enjoyable, not just to touch her like that, but to hear her moan, to see how she responded to his touch.

‘Lachlan vetoed the idea of a sex tape, by the way,’ she told him, making him laugh. ‘He said it wouldn’t be sexy.’

‘He does like to take his time getting toward the hot stuff,’ Drew pointed out, ‘Maybe over time, he’ll come round to the idea.’

‘You know, he mostly likes it with the lights off, when we sleep together?’ she said.

‘He does? He’s insane.’

‘Maybe he really doesn’t want to be reminded that he’s on the small side.’

Drew’s touching was focusing on her inner thighs by now, and soon enough, his fingers were brushing up against her searing-hot pussy, finding that she was naturally already soaking wet.

‘Here’s another: it says it’s biological,’ she said, and read, ‘After watching their wife with another man, the husband is prompted biologically to have longer, more vigorous sex, has a shorter refractory period between erections, ejaculates harder, and his ejaculate contains more sperm.’

‘Okay...’ Drew nodded.

Emma turned over, to lie on her back, and Drew began to massage her front, sweeping his hands up to touch her bare breasts, then back down over her stomach, to her thighs.

‘Nearly every couple I interviewed told me that after an episode of the wife having sex with another man, the couple felt like they were in heat,’ Emma read, and then moaned as Drew gave in to temptation and began kissing her thighs, instead of massaging them.

‘Who wrote the article?’ he asked her.

‘I don’t know... some psychologist, I think,’ she said, peering at the page. ‘David J Ley, Ph.D.’

‘Well, there you go,’ Drew laughed. ‘It’s science, huh?’

It was interesting that Emma researched the whole thing—his enjoyment of watching her, and her enjoyment of him watching her. And, that when she read him the results of her research, she often seemed to slip into the habit of referring to ‘wives’ and ‘husbands’, and the whole thing as ‘wife-sharing’.

Drew liked that she saw their relationship in such stable terms.

But at the same time, she did seem to be going ‘steady’ with Lachlan, despite the man’s uninspiring bedroom ability. And that, in itself, seemed dangerous to Drew. Whenever she spoke of Lachlan, and whenever she talked to Lachlan in front of Drew, she didn’t talk about their future together—not like she did with Drew, asking him things like where he’d want to live when he got old, what he’d want his kids to be called, and so on. Yet despite frequently complaining about sleeping with Lachlan, she seemed in no hurry to leave him.

Drew didn’t want to push her to finish it with Lachlan, either. When Emma slept with the guy, it was practically guaranteed that she’d soon end up in bed with Drew, despite her guilt over cheating. So Drew was happy.

Emma did enjoy Lachlan’s company, as did all of their friends, increasingly it seemed. But not only was she tormented by the constant guilt of cheating on Lachlan—which only grew as it became more and more clear that she and Lachlan were a ‘couple’, and she was certain they were supposed to be exclusive—she was also tormented by temptation.

‘There’s this guy at work,’ she was saying one night in Drew’s bed, lying beside him after another rampant bout of post-Lachlan sex. ‘He works in the San Francisco office, but he’s in town for a month or two to consult on a case involving a company that’s based here. He’s absolutely gorgeous...’

‘And you can’t sleep with him, huh?’ Drew smiled.

‘It’s ridiculous!’ she complained. ‘And hey—I’m pretty sure, if I got with him, he would want to make a sex tape.’

‘So just do it,’ Drew laughed. ‘I mean... you cheat on Lachlan with me... so...’

‘No, it’s different. If anyone sees me hanging out with you, it’s not a big deal. You’re my best friend, you always have been. But if somebody sees me on a date with someone else...’

‘What are the chances of somebody bumping into you on a date? It’s a pretty big city.’

‘Not that big. And anyway, I don’t think I could handle the guilt.’

‘You handle the guilt from sleeping with me.’

She sighed. ‘Somehow, I’ve come to terms with sleeping with you,’ she said. ‘As far as I’m concerned, I only do it because Lachlan is deficient in that area.’

‘Oh, okay.’ Drew sounded disappointed.

‘Well, you know, *not only*,’ she said, rubbing his crotch affectionately through the bedsheet. ‘But the point is, sleeping with you makes it possible for me to stay with Lachlan and not go crazy.’

‘We’re practically polyamorous.’

Emma said, ‘I’ve thought about it. But I think if we were polyamorous, it wouldn’t be about you being turned on by me seeing other guys... and me being turned on that you are.’

‘I don’t think Lachlan would like to feel he was in something polyamorous.’

‘No. But if he ever found out... well, it would probably be worse if I had to admit I was sleeping with more than just you.’

‘And you can’t just call it quits with Lachlan...?’ It was the closest Drew got to pressuring her to end it with the Australian.

‘He’s too nice,’ she said. ‘And I’ve been going out with him for too long. Everybody loves him. My dad thinks he’s great, and he hasn’t even met him, yet.’

‘They’ve got to understand these things don’t always work out.’

She sighed. ‘But everyone always seems so impressed I’ve gone steady with him. Everyone always says we’re so good together. I feel like I’d be breaking everyone’s hearts if I dumped him.’

Drew nodded. He wasn’t going to push the knife into his co-worker’s back on this.

The trouble was, as much as Drew enjoyed seeing Emma after she was done with Lachlan, she was increasingly spending most of her time during her evenings and weekends with the Australian, instead of with Drew.

There was also the issue of Lachlan becoming more and more cemented into their joint social circle. Everybody just liked the guy. Carrie and Ray didn’t even trouble Drew with suggestions that he should be working his way toward asking Emma out.

Emma even introduced Lachlan to her mother. It was like the two of them were drifting toward marriage.

Now Drew definitely couldn’t apply any pressure to her to get rid of Lachlan.

Then spring turned to summer, and as things progressed between the two of them, Emma started actually spending the night with Lachlan, instead of just sleeping with him and then leaving to return home. Once or twice, when the two of them were staying at Emma’s place, she ended up sneaking out in the middle of the night to visit Drew’s bed. But Lachlan

seemed to prefer her to stay over at his place, as though he felt threatened by the fact that Emma's BFF lived in an apartment so close to hers.

One night in July, Emma spent an entire evening with Drew, and it was absolutely wonderful. But somehow, it made it seem all the more obvious that things had changed between them, and that the way things had been before was really in the past.

Then, after a pizza in front of Netflix, she dropped a bombshell.

'I'm going on vacation with him.'

'Seriously?'

'Uh-huh. Two weeks in the Bahamas. We're flying out tomorrow.'

She said Lachlan had booked it ages ago, and Emma had felt too weird about it to tell Drew.

'Why did you feel weird about it?' Drew asked, although the truth was, he was feeling a little weird about it, too. Emma had always taken summer vacations with Drew. They'd gone to all kinds of places over the years. She'd never been with a boyfriend long enough to even think of booking a vacation with someone else. Until now.

'Well... you know... I usually go with you,' she said, genuinely regretful.

Drew said, 'But now you're dating him. And you've been dating him a while. I'm just your friend.'

He tried to be reassuring—although he felt his stomach being twisted up by the sense that he was losing her to another man, he did want her to be happy. And that meant enjoying her trip.

'You're not angry with me?'

He shook his head. 'Why should I be angry?' he said. 'You like him. He's a nice guy. You'll have fun in the Bahamas... I want you to have fun.'

'I won't see you for two weeks.'

'You've taken business trips longer than that before,' Drew pointed out.

'Not with another guy.'

‘Hey,’ he said, ‘I’m going to be here when you get back, so what have you got to worry about?’

Emma nodded, but he wasn’t quite sure if she was entirely happy with everything. Drew felt a little flicker of worry, that perhaps she hadn’t quite told him everything. There was a sense in her eyes that their time was limited, that something big was coming up that she couldn’t quite get her head around, and couldn’t find the words to talk about it with Drew.

They watched a movie on Netflix, and just held each other, sharing a nice bottle of red.

Then Emma went to the bathroom to freshen up, and when she came back, she was wearing only a black lacy bra, matching panties, and black stockings and garter belt.

‘Wow,’ Drew said, eyebrows raised. ‘Is this something you’re wearing for a date?’

She smiled, enjoying his eyes roaming all over her body. ‘No, it’s something I’m wearing for you,’ she said, giving him a twirl before walking slowly, so sultry, toward him, brushing her hair back over her shoulder with her hands.

He stood and kissed her, running his hands all over her, entranced by her, captivated by her, dazzled by her. She was so perfect, so exquisite.

What if this was the last time he got to sleep with her?

Once she and Lachlan had been on a full summer vacation together, they would be locked as a couple, wouldn’t they? And then they’d be on the road to real commitment. Perhaps Emma was planning on pulling herself to her senses, ending the unfaithful arrangement she had with Drew, so that someday she could be a dutiful wife.

Perhaps that was his paranoia speaking. And yet, Drew did get the sense that what he had with Emma was unusual, and not entirely realistic. Real life would have to intervene eventually.

Emma quietly grabbed hold of his hand, and led him through to her bedroom, where she had him lie on the bed so that she could pull down his jeans and his boxer shorts, allowing her to take his big, hard cock in her hands.

Wow. It felt so good. She pumped him with both hands, knowing exactly how he liked it, exactly what speed, how hard, how much pressure. Then she opened her mouth and took his top few inches inside, stretching her lips around him, sinking on his shaft as she gazed up at him.

‘Oh God... Emma... that feels so good...’

‘I’m going to miss this,’ she said, licking him slowly from base to tip. She seemed, almost, to be trying to memorize his cock. She was looking at him—looking at it—with studied focus, and then when she stretched her lips over it again, and took it into her mouth, she was gazing up at him as though trying to remember every nuance of his response to her, rather than simply registering how much he enjoyed each touch, each lick, each swirl of her tongue.

Was she committing herself to a life of mediocre sex with Lachlan? Trying to etch how it had been with Drew into her memory to provide support when she was no longer able to visit him for real?

Drew felt a touch of sadness in the air. Would he cope if she decided she could no longer see him?

He’d felt heartbreak before, but at least this time it wouldn’t be about Emma actively rejecting him. She would still be his friend, she would still like him. She just probably wouldn’t be able to continue this strange but wonderful sexual adventure.

Well, he’d always known this couldn’t happen forever. Hadn’t he?

He could hardly ask her not to go with Lachlan. He could hardly ask her to cancel her vacation. He could hardly object to her wanting to move on with her life. Who knew what she wanted? Perhaps she wanted children, and she’d decided Lachlan would be a perfect father. Drew was only a bar

manager. Lachlan was going to be a lawyer—he'd already accepted an internship with one of the best law firms in Boston, and those internships usually led to employment.

Drew figured he could at least enjoy her fully, for one last night.

Emma seemed to know exactly how long she could go down on him before he was just about ready to burst. Now, she stood up just in time so that he wasn't coming early. She stood tall, letting him take in the sight of her in that sexy black lingerie.

She quietly removed her bra, and tilted her hips as she slipped down her panties, leaving herself only in her stockings and the attached garter belt.

Then she climbed onto the bed, straddled him, and shuffled up his chest until she was kneeling over his face.

She was just magnificent. He curled his arms around her thighs, and pulled her down onto his mouth. God, how he adored her, and how he adored worshipping her like this. She pressed herself down on him, but gave him the space to explore her beautifully shaved pussy with his mouth, to indulge in her flavor before things started getting intense.

'I wish Lachlan liked doing this,' she opined, and from between her thighs, Drew raised his eyebrows to demonstrate his surprise that her beloved Australian wasn't as into oral sex as he was. 'God... I can't believe how good it feels...'

She moaned as he nibbled on her pussy lips, and reached up to touch her breasts with his hands.

Drew slid his tongue inside her, and felt a little burst of her wetness spring forth in response. As he gently penetrated her with his tongue, he found himself wondering what Lachlan did enjoy when he slept with Emma.

Emma had told Drew all about sex with the guy, but come to think of it, she'd never described the guy going down on her, only Emma going down

on Lachlan. Did the guy go in for anal sex? Emma had only ever detailed normal penetration, in various positions.

Did Lachlan think that doing it doggy-style, or occasionally with Emma on top, constituted fulfilling sex?

But then Emma was moving her hips over him, and her breathing was turning to panting, and she was pressing herself down against his mouth in a more urgent manner, and it was getting too serious for Drew to contemplate what was going on between her and Lachlan.

He grabbed her hips, and found a comfortable position where he would best cope with her demands. Then he let her go, let her take control, so that she was grinding her sweet pussy against his mouth, using him for her own ends.

It was a wild ride, but this was what he loved about Emma. She didn't do anything by half measures. She rode his face so forcefully, absolutely drenching him in the process, and yet it was an incredibly beautiful experience. It was just immense, almost like standing in the middle of a powerful thunderstorm.

And she was so gorgeous, when she came, and came hard, to Drew it was like the most wonderful accomplishment, something of which he could feel truly proud.

'I never did it like that before,' she said as she eventually dismounted—or at least, moved back down his body so that she could slip his hard cock into her burning-hot pussy.

'Never?' he grinned, not quite believing her.

'Seriously,' she said earnestly. 'I mean... I think you have to be confident the guy would enjoy it like that... I've never had *that* kind of confidence.'

A little later, she was on all fours, and he was standing by the mattress, sliding his hardness into her from behind. She said, 'Do you think you'd want to see Laura again?'

Drew thought it was a little odd. It was certainly a funny time to be bringing up the thought of another woman. He said, 'I thought...'

But Emma said, 'She was asking about you again the other day at work.'

They lay together on the bed, Emma spooned up against him so he could continue to thrust inside her, though at a more sedate pace. 'I wouldn't have thought she'd remember me,' Drew said, 'I mean, I turned her down for a second date.'

'I told her you'd been all messed up by something personal. That you'd be okay again in a few months.'

'Something personal? Like what?'

Emma giggled. 'Whatever you can think of. I didn't specify. I couldn't exactly say you were hung up on an ex-girlfriend.'

'You think I should really call her?' he said, a little shocked that Emma would want such a thing, after she'd been so uncomfortable with his first date with Laura.

'Yes,' she said, 'I think maybe you should.'

Drew felt a touch of sadness building up again. There was that sense that Emma wouldn't encourage him to date Laura—or anyone else—if she wasn't certain that she wouldn't be able to see him herself.

'You won't get jealous if I end up in bed with her one day?' he asked her straight out.

'Of course not,' she said, pushing him back onto the mattress so that she could climb onto him again, and slide his cock back inside her furnace-like pussy. 'I couldn't justify being jealous of anybody.'

It wasn't long before he could hold it back no longer, and she clamped his cock within her tight pussy, holding him there as he shot his thick cream deep into her.

And then she had to hit the shower, and though he joined her in the shower, she couldn't stay with him for long.

‘I have to go to Lachlan’s tonight,’ she said, making it seem as though she’d reversed the whole process in which she fucked her other guy first, and then went to Drew’s bed. The difference this time was that before going to Lachlan, she had to scrub herself until she was absolutely immaculate, and there was absolutely no evidence that she’d been in any way physical with another man.

And then she was gone, and Drew had to wander back to his own apartment, feeling strangely empty.

OceanofPDF.com

Chapter Sixteen

Drew was at work the following morning, doing little more than making coffees for the smattering of customers who dropped by so early, not really breakfast time, not really brunch.

He liked the quiet. It gave him a chance to think, to mull over his choices. To consider whether he'd made a big mistake.

He told himself not to worry, that it was only a two-week vacation and it meant little in the scheme of things. It was still early for Emma's relationship with Lachlan, it wasn't like they'd been dating for two years and Emma's biological clock was ticking.

Why did he feel so strongly that he was losing her?

True, he'd come around to the idea that he could date her himself, now. The way she'd been talking about wives who cheated on their husbands, with their husbands' clear approval, had sunk into his consciousness. How could it not? It showed the possibility of being in a romantic relationship with someone, but allowing them to enjoy sex with others.

Had he been an idiot not even to suggest such an arrangement for themselves? But she wasn't giving up Lachlan. He didn't want to push her to do something she didn't want to do. And it wasn't just a sex thing with Lachlan, because Lachlan's sex wasn't what was keeping her dating him.

Did she *love him*? Was that what she was hiding from Drew?

Am I merely the guy she sees on the side? She cheats on Lachlan with me, just for the sex? Sure, she's my best friend, but she only loves me as a friend, and only fucks me because I have a big dick.

What if Lachlan was the kind of guy who would willingly allow his partner to see other guys? If it was a common enough thing to get into women's magazines, it wasn't stretching it to suppose Lachlan might be that kind of guy, too.

It was only 10 o'clock, and Emma hadn't even been gone half a day, and Drew already saw himself going crazy without her. His life was so quiet without her, even when he was surrounded by people. And into that quiet crept paranoia.

It was 10 o'clock when Ray and Carrie burst into the bar, rushing in as though the world was about to end.

'There you are!' Ray said, somewhat out of breath.

'Uh... yeah, this is where I work,' Drew said, looking at them both, somewhat bemused.

Carrie, in particular, was particularly devastated by the athletic requirements of getting here rapidly, it appeared. She was gasping for oxygen, and couldn't even speak.

'Tell him, tell him!' Ray was urging her, but she was bent over at the middle, unable to talk because she was struggling so much just to breathe.

'I... you... Emma...' she groaned, and Ray patted her back, no clue how to help her.

'Something happened to Emma?' Drew asked her, feeling like he was asking Lassie what the problem was. *Has Timmy fallen down the well? Bark bark.*

'She... he's... Lachlan...'

Ray spoke for her, 'She told me she went out with Lachlan—it was just the two of them, shopping in the mall.'

'Okay... so did something happen with him?'

Ray glanced down at Carrie, who was beginning to calm down by now, but she gave him a nod. He said, 'When you were with Emma yesterday evening, Lachlan asked Carrie if she wanted to hang out—it wasn't a big deal... only, they went to the mall, and it turned out Lachlan was shopping for a ring...'

'A ring?'

Okay, now Drew did put down the glass he'd been drying.

'He was asking me... he was asking me...' Carrie said, still trying to get her breath back, acting as a poster girl for the anti-smoking lobby.

'He wanted her advice on what kind of ring to get Emma,' Ray explained, 'and she said he really ought to be talking to you, because you're Emma's best friend, right? I mean, who knows her better than you? You'd know what kind of ring she'd want.'

'A ring?' Drew was astonished. 'They've only been dating, what, a few months?'

'It feels... like a few years... for Emma,' Carrie said.

'Time slows down when you're having fun... wait a minute, that's not how it goes...' Drew said, wryly.

'She really likes him,' Carrie said earnestly. 'She's never liked somebody like that before—except for you.'

Drew felt his stomach churning. He felt like the guy who just missed the boat, standing on the dock as the great ship powered away out to sea.

'Okay, so why're you telling me now?' he said, feeling so cold.

'Okay, she's told me all about you two,' Carrie said gravely. Drew felt a knife slide into his belly, before starting to twist around.

'She did?'

Carrie said, 'I knew you guys wouldn't be able to keep your hands off each other.' She didn't seem angry. Neither did Ray. But weren't those two close with Lachlan these days?

‘It was always going to happen,’ Ray said, safe with his hindsight, but his tone of voice was reassuringly supportive considering the fact that Drew had basically been sleeping with Lachlan’s girlfriend.

‘She was telling me how much she loved you,’ Carrie told Drew, and it felt like an arrow piercing his heart. ‘But she couldn’t tell if you felt the same way... maybe you were just her best friend, and she was reading too much into everything because you’re sleeping together...’

Suzy came into the bar, ready to start her shift, and Drew gave her a quick wave and a smile, but now suggested to Ray and Carrie that they take their conversation into the office. Suzy knew Lachlan too well.

‘But... you think she’d actually say ‘yes’ to Lachlan if he popped the question?’ Drew asked them.

‘She has feelings for him,’ Carrie said. ‘She doesn’t know if it’s love, but... you know she’s been getting broody recently...?’

‘What?’ Drew exclaimed.

He was truly astounded. Sure, he’d hadn’t seen all that much of Emma recently, but she hadn’t seemed broody to him at all.

‘Sure... I mean... I was hanging out with those guys one weekend, they were going around the market together, and they were looking at all the kids’ stuff, all the baby stuff. And she’s holding stuff up to Lachlan, saying, you like this?’

‘Jesus,’ Drew said. That feeling of missing the boat had just strengthened, ten-fold. ‘But he’s only just out of law *school*.’

‘He’s from a fairly traditional background,’ Ray said. ‘I mean, not strictly religious, but...’

‘He’s Australian,’ Drew pointed out. ‘Aren’t they supposed to be all about messing around on the beach... you know... lots of hot women...?’

‘Well, he’s never been *like that*,’ Carrie said.

Drew sighed. ‘Does she know he’s going to pop the question?’ he asked them. ‘I mean... she did seem to have something on her mind yesterday... I

thought she was just nervous about going on vacation with Lachlan for the first time...'

'Lachlan made me promise not to say a word to her,' Carrie said, 'But I know she's been thinking about all this. She's been thinking about whether it's time she sorted her life out and... you know... got on with things...'

'Got on with things? She's not even thirty yet!'

Carrie sighed, 'You know how she feels about her mom.'

'Sure, of course.'

'She used to think she was just like her mom. That she couldn't ever settle on one guy... that she would always be tempted to just drop everything and run after some cute tail, just like her mom...'

'I know...'

'Well, ever since Ray dropped the bombshell that you had a crush on her...'

'What? Ray did what?' Drew was aghast.

Ray sighed, and rolled his eyes, 'It was bound to come out sooner or later,' he insisted, deflecting responsibility. 'So what... I got a little too drunk one night...'

'When was this?' Drew asked him.

'Oh... ages ago. I think right after that Halloween party at Sharon's.'

'That was before...' Drew's mind was reeling, trying to work out the timeline. So Ray had told Emma he had a crush on her before the night he'd witnessed her having sex with Vincent. The night his crush had really ignited. He said, 'I didn't have a crush on her back then,' he said.

'Sure you did,' Ray insisted. 'You just didn't know it, yet.'

'Anyway,' Carrie said, 'that was what got her started down this whole direction. She looked at you differently after that—because you two have had a relationship going forever. And she was, like, what if I could have a family with Drew?'

'Seriously?' Drew said. 'She never said anything...'

‘Well she couldn’t quite let go of all the sex back then,’ she said. ‘She was feeling the urge to have a big family of her own, because her family has always been so small... but... you know... she’s always had an eye for the fellas...’

‘Anyway...’ Ray said, jumping in, ‘The point is, then Lachlan came along and showed her that maybe she could hold down a proper relationship...’

‘And she was sleeping with you at the same time!’ Carrie laughed.

‘She wouldn’t want to settle with him...’ Drew said, aghast.

‘He’s shown her something she’s never had before,’ Carrie said, her face grave again. ‘He’s got a big family back in Australia, they’re close. And she wants a big family.’

‘Seriously?’

‘He wants lots of kids... and now she wants lots of kids...’

The door opened, and Suzy poked her head around it. ‘Coffee machine died again,’ she said.

Drew sighed, and ran his hands through his hair. ‘Okay. Turn it off at the wall, wait five minutes, then turn it on again. It should work.’

‘Okay, thanks, boss.’

When she was gone, Drew was looking at Carrie and Ray, who both seemed to be waiting for him to say something.

‘Okay,’ he said, ‘So what am I supposed to do? If Emma wants kids... if she’s in love with Lachlan... who am I to stand in her way?’

‘You’re the guy who’s been in love with her forever...’ Ray insisted.

‘Well, I’m not sure...’ Drew had to be honest—he might be in love with her now, but for most of their lives they were just friends. Best friends, sure, but still only friends.

Carrie said, ‘When I was ring shopping with Lachlan... he said a couple of things that made my ass twitch...’

‘Okay,’ Drew said, not quite sure if ass twitching was a good thing or a bad thing.

‘When I was telling him he should be getting your advice on the ring, he was, like, not happy about that. He wasn’t happy she was hanging out with you that evening, either, but at least it gave him a window to buy the ring,’ Carrie said. ‘And then he said when they were engaged, he was going to ask her to move in with him, so she wouldn’t have to see you so much anymore.’

‘He said that to you?’ Drew was shocked, yet again. And yet, if Lachlan was jealous, this was how he would act. And being jealous of another man spending time with your woman was the common thing, wasn’t it? Drew just wasn’t like that.

‘I know,’ Ray said, judgmentally.

‘And then,’ Carrie said, ‘when I was saying you guys were just friends, and you’d always been best friends, he was, like, well she won’t see him much when we move back to Australia.’

If Drew had been having a drink right now, this was the point at which he would have involuntarily spat it out, spraying it everywhere with complete surprise.

‘Wait, what?’ he said instead.

‘He’s going to insist on having the wedding in Australia,’ Carrie explained, ‘because he has so much more family there than she does here. And then they’ll stay on a while, and he thinks she’ll be so keen on being around so much family... she’ll just want to stay there with him.’

‘Jesus.’

‘Can you spell ‘manipulative’?’ Ray asked nobody in particular.

Drew stood up, pacing the room. ‘Look,’ he said. ‘I get that he’s... trying to manipulate her a little...’

‘A little?’ Carrie said.

‘But he’s still leaving it to her to make the choice,’ Drew said. ‘Who am I to tell her not to have a family, if she wants one? Not to spend the rest of her life with that guy, if she wants to?’ He sighed, feeling that Carrie and Ray had to be acting with self-interest, because if Emma went off to Australia, they would lose a friend, too.

‘You’re the guy who lights up her life,’ Carrie said. ‘When she’s around Lachlan, sure, she’s happy... but when she’s been with you...’ The redhead raised her eyebrows suggestively. ‘I mean, as soon as she finally told me you guys were sleeping together... I could tell exactly which nights she’d snuck over to see you.’

‘It’s still...’ Drew didn’t know what to say. ‘She still has to choose if she wants him, to marry him, to stay with him...’

‘And what happened last night?’ Carrie asked him. ‘Because she told me she was going over to see you to find out how you really feel about her. If you were in love with her.’

Drew shook his head, ‘She never asked me anything like that.’

‘Well, she wasn’t just going to come straight out and say it,’ Ray pointed out. ‘She would have done it subtly. You know... she had to test you... without freaking you out...’

Drew wasn’t going to tell them they’d talked about wife-sharing and polyamory. But had that been her testing him? Sounding him out about the kind of marriage they could enjoy, to try to provoke him into suggesting she marry him?

‘But she was telling me I ought to go on another date with Laura,’ Drew said, feeling a powerful sense of injustice, as well as the growing panic that Emma was gone, that he’d lost her.

‘Classic test,’ Carrie tutted.

‘How did you respond?’ Ray asked.

‘Well... I asked her if she’d get jealous if... you know... I slept with Laura...’

Now Ray and Carrie tutted. Ray said, 'The answer we were looking for was, 'no, Emma, I don't need to date somebody else because *I love you*'.'

'But...' Drew said, completely baffled.

Ray looked at Carrie and glanced at his watch. 'It's 10.15,' he said. 'Their flight takes off at noon. Plenty of time.'

'He practically has time to walk there.'

'Twenty minutes in an Uber.'

'A little light running...' Carrie suggested.

'Honey, it's five miles. Drew is pretty fit, but...'

Drew interrupted, 'Uh... what are you guys talking about?'

Ray sighed melodramatically. 'You don't see what you have to do?' he asked, rolling his eyes. Drew looked blank. 'I can see I have to be the gay friend helping to move the heterosexual romance on, even though my own emotional happiness is completely overlooked by this entire movie...'

Carrie giggled, 'You love it.'

Ray looked at Drew. 'How does any half-decent rom-com end?' he asked. 'You have to run across town—I still think you could take an Uber, the run through the airport should be enough—and then get to the girl just in time to stop her from making a terrible mistake.'

'It's just a two-week vacation,' Drew said quietly.

'She's going to marry him!' Carrie declared.

Ray had his phone in his hands, 'I'm already booking the car... it's three minutes away...'

'What am I supposed to—' Drew protested.

'Tell her how you feel!' Carrie said.

'How I feel?'

'How do you feel about her?'

'I... love her?' he said tentatively, and it was probably more of a question than he really meant it to be. He did love her. Didn't he? He was obsessed with her. He couldn't stop thinking about her. He'd just never

thought the two of them would be capable of holding down a long-term relationship.

‘You love her!’ Ray melted.

‘So go tell her!’ Carrie yelled.

‘The car’s outside already,’ Ray pointed out.

There was just too much panic in the room. Drew dashed out, apologizing to Suzy for leaving her the whole bar to deal with, and then leaped into the awaiting Prius. It was insane. It was completely crazy. Carrie and Ray had turned their obsession with trashy romantic movies into advice that had turned his life into the ending of a trashy romantic movie.

Racing along I-90 toward the waterfront, he found himself thinking what an absolute idiot he was going to look like if Carrie and Ray had got it all wrong. But by the time the car was driving through the multitude of concrete parking lots that formed the airport, it seemed like too late for him to turn back.

It was creepy, wasn’t it? What Lachlan had said about Emma. Getting her to Australia and engineering it so that she fell in love with his huge family so she’d never want to come back to America. She’d never get to see Drew again.

And after taking so long to sleep with her, why had Lachlan been so speedy with the ring?

But Drew did want Emma. He did love Emma. It wasn’t just that they had always been best friends, or that they had discovered an incredible sexual chemistry between them. She completed him. Wasn’t that from the movies, too? Jerry Maguire. God. But it was true. You. Complete. Me. He felt at peace when he was with Emma, which he didn’t feel at any other time.

And so what if she wanted to start having kids—that wasn’t such a bad idea, was it? He wanted kids, someday. It might as well be now. And what could be better than having kids with Emma?

Now he was out of the Uber car, dashing through international departures. God. He didn't even know what flight they were on—didn't even know what airline they were using. The movies never had to worry about details like this. You just turned up, there was the line of people ready to get on the plane... there was the person you were going to stop from boarding...

He searched the departure hall. He looked up flights going to the Bahamas. Nassau. There was a flight at 12.05pm. It had to be that. But it was 11 o'clock by now—they would have gone through security already, right?

He went to the line filing into security. He couldn't see them anywhere. This was not going well. He was going to have to buy a ticket somewhere if he wanted to get through there. This was ridiculous. Could he even get a ticket, and get through that enormous line at security in around an hour?

His phone buzzed. He expected it to be Ray or Carrie demanding to know if he'd sorted out the happy ever after they were expecting.

It was Emma.

Emma: Flight's delayed :-(Kinda boring sitting at the gate.

Drew sighed, and used his phone to find a last-minute air ticket. Ottawa. It wasn't horrendously expensive—but he could hear Ray and Carrie's voices in his ears by now: what did cost matter, when this was his whole life, his whole future on the line?

He printed off a boarding pass at one of the departure kiosks, and then he joined the line going into security. There was no way to speed this up. He shuffled forward at a painful pace until it was his turn to be scanned.

Now he was running, properly running, toward the gate where the Nassau flight waited. It was noon. If Emma's flight was delayed, then he still had a chance to catch her—but would she really agree not to go to the Bahamas with Lachlan, just because Drew suddenly turned up, all sweaty

and gasping for breath, telling her he loved her like some kind of drug-crazed idiot?

He was getting close to the gate now, but every step he took toward her, he felt less and less certain about what he was even doing. What he would do when he saw her.

He bumped into a woman who just came out of the restrooms, and nearly wiped out completely.

‘Sorry! So sorry!’

He was such a mess. What was Lachlan going to think? Seeing him rush in to try and stop them from going on vacation. The guy would think he was an idiot.

Drew stopped to make sure the woman he’d bumped into was okay. Her annoyance at his collision soon turned into a smile as he apologized earnestly, and checked that she was all right instead of merely running off.

Then he heard a familiar voice: ‘What are you doing here?’

Emma had walked out of the restroom.

‘Emma,’ he said, somewhat out of breath.

‘Why...’ she said, puzzled why he would be there.

Drew felt his mind go blank, panic threatening to take over completely. So what did he say to her now? In the movies, the hero could just reel off a powerfully-written, charming soliloquy to explain why he should get the girl, and not his rival. But Drew hadn’t come with any kind of speech prepared.

‘I... the other night...’ he said, glancing around to make sure Lachlan wasn’t around to hear him.

‘Yes?’ she said.

‘I... uh...’ he stammered. Thinking, Jesus. What would Ray or Carrie suggest now?

Emma raised an eyebrow, intrigued, but confused.

He said, ‘I’m... I’m sorry...’

‘Our flight’s boarding,’ she said, turning her head briefly, to indicate the people beginning to line up in front of the gate.

He nodded. ‘Have a good trip,’ he said, feeling his insides begin to collapse in on themselves. ‘Have a good... vacation.’

‘I’ll see you soon,’ she said, offering a smile that was still one of semi-bewilderment.

He felt awful, the noise of the airport was somehow amplified, overwhelming him with a terrible clamor, his skin felt all hot and itchy, as though it might flake off. He couldn’t breathe. He felt so weak, his legs were going to crumple under him.

He remembered Carrie saying, *‘Tell her how you feel!’*

Emma took a step back, toward the gate. She gave him a little wave, and started turning away from him.

Drew said, ‘I love you.’

She turned back toward him again, looking somewhat surprised.

‘I just wanted to tell you how I feel,’ he said, Carrie’s words morphing into something he could finally say to her.

‘What did you—?’ Emma said, her jaw dropping.

‘I love you,’ he said, and the feelings were rushing up from somewhere deep down, he had no idea where they came from. ‘I should have told you the other night... I just didn’t know how.’

‘But...’ Emma said, and he had the awful feeling it was all too late.

‘I love you,’ he said. ‘I just wanted you to know.’

He felt so stupid. He stepped back, smiled, trying not to let any tears actually escape and trickle down his cheek. He gave her a little wave, and nodded toward the gate, telling her it was time to go, she would be late for her flight.

He glanced over and saw Lachlan, and a dark, dark look drifted over the Australian’s face as he laid eyes on Drew.

Emma sighed, and tilted her head, mouthing something. Was she apologizing to him? And then she was turning to go, and Drew was turning to go the other way, and it really, really wasn't going to be a Hollywood ending after all.

OceanofPDF.com

Chapter Seventeen

Of course, absence makes the heart grow fonder, but Drew wasn't expecting it to hurt quite as much as it did with Emma away. She had always been there for him, and even when she went away by herself on business trips, she'd always kept fairly closely in touch. This time, Drew kept glancing at his phone, and there was nothing.

He couldn't bring himself to text her, to ask her how it was going, how nice the beach was, how good the weather was in the Bahamas. He probably would have, if they were still merely best friends. But he'd gone and dropped the 'L' word.

Had he ended the possibility of them continuing as best friends?

The thing that wrenched his stomach was that she hadn't said it back. Sure, it had all come as a surprise to her—she hadn't expected him to rush to the airport like it was some trashy Hollywood rom-com. But when he'd told her he loved her, she'd merely looked apologetic.

And now she was lounging under the Caribbean sun, on a romantic break with Lachlan, who could ask her to marry him at any point. Perhaps he'd already asked her. It was one reason why she might not have wanted to text Drew.

Drew tried his best not to feel torn up about it, though it was difficult. As well as the feelings of loss, he was also feeling somewhat stupid—

mainly because Lachlan had seen him there at the airport. Lachlan must have known he was there to try to persuade Emma not to go on her trip. And he had failed. It had been so stupid.

‘Hey, you know, marriages don’t always last forever,’ Ray said, as he and Carrie kept Drew company at the bar the evening after the airport incident.

‘Don’t say that!’ Carrie chided him. ‘She’s not going to marry Lachlan.’

Carrie looked up at Drew, who was making a Manhattan for a group of college students he had carded earlier, since they seemed so young. ‘At least you told her how you feel,’ she said, reassuringly.

‘I’m not sure if it did any good,’ Drew shrugged. ‘It just... complicates things.’

‘Nah-uh,’ the redhead shook her head. ‘It puts everything out there—it lays down your cards. Now she knows exactly what she’s dealing with.’

‘They’re going to get married, and I’ll be persona non grata for the rest of my life,’ Drew laughed. ‘I mean... you think Lachlan would want me at the wedding? You think he’d want me to ever see her again? I tried to wreck their whole relationship.’

‘She’s not going to marry him,’ Carrie insisted. ‘And even if she says ‘yes’ when he asks her, they’re not going to get married in the Bahamas. They’ll come back here, they’ll need to spend time organizing the wedding, planning on what happens after. There’ll be time to change her mind.’

‘Not if I can’t see her anymore.’

‘You know she’d never shun you, even if he tells her to,’ Ray said.

‘She would never agree to marry a guy who tells her who she can, and cannot, spend time with,’ Carrie said. ‘Look, you have nothing to worry about.’

Drew just laughed at that.

‘The only reason she’s even considered settling down with Lachlan is because she’s starting to feel the need... you know... to slow down. She wants a family, and Lachlan offers her one.’

‘A big one,’ Drew nodded, before turning to take payment for the students’ drinks order.

‘Well, at least he’s got a big something,’ Ray joked.

Drew turned to look at Carrie in surprise, ‘She told you?’

Carrie shrugged. ‘She told me a lot. She was all torn up about him—she likes him. But... you know...’

‘I can’t give her a big family,’ Drew said.

‘I don’t know... you still have plenty of time,’ Ray suggested. ‘And kids... are... not that bad.’ He didn’t sound convincing.

‘Lachlan’s just trying to overwhelm her,’ Carrie said. ‘He’s trying to make her feel like he can give her what she’s missed out on all these years—sisters, brothers, cousins... but it’s all fake. At least, it is if he’s not the one she really wants to spend the rest of her life with.’

‘It’s going to be tempting for her,’ Drew said.

‘You’re tempting for her,’ Carrie insisted. ‘Now you’ve told her how you feel... she’s got to think she would be able to settle down with you, right?’

But there was little point in talking about it over and over. Drew couldn’t predict what Emma would do, even though he’d known her almost all his life, because she’d never been in a situation like this before.

All he could do was try to keep calm, and find other things to focus on.

A few days into the trip, he couldn’t help himself, texting her a very simplistic:

Drew: Hey, how’s it going? Hope you guys are having a nice vacation!

It was innocent enough, he thought. Perhaps if she read it the right way, she would think he was telling her he supported her, whatever decision she

was making about her future. That if she wanted to marry Lachlan, he wouldn't attempt anything to prevent it.

But, a few days turned into a week, and Emma did not reply. The only way he could avoid feeling like he'd offended her, he'd hurt her, was by imagining that for some reason she couldn't get phone reception in the Bahamas, or her phone plan didn't cover foreign countries.

Carrie hadn't heard from her, either, and none of their other friends had.

'Maybe she accidentally dropped her phone in the pool,' Carrie suggested. 'Or in the sea.'

'Most iPhones are waterproof nowadays, aren't they?' Ray said. 'I dropped mine in the toilet, and it was all right.'

'So she got sand in it,' Carrie shrugged. 'She went swimming with the dolphins, and Flipper ate it.'

'She could have got sun cream in it,' Ray suggested.

Drew was trying to keep upbeat, trying not to wallow. 'She's on vacation,' he said. 'She just turned her phone off, that's all. You know... so she doesn't get any work calls, doesn't have to face all those emails.'

But he was still nervous.

Sunday morning, Drew was getting ready to go to work when his phone buzzed, and he instantly jumped for it as though attempting to score a touchdown.

A message from Emma.

Emma: Hey, I really miss you :-)

Drew felt his body fill with warmth—she missed him! It was wonderfully reassuring even to hear from her again. But the sad face emoticon at the end of her message concerned him. What if she was texting

him to tell him she could no longer see him anymore, no longer talk to him?

He tried not to panic. He had to text her back something caring, but not too heavy.

Drew: I miss you too, massively. So are you guys having a good time?

He sat on the edge of the couch, holding his phone as though he was a castaway on a desert island, and this was his only chance to connect with the rest of the world. He had given her an opportunity to say exactly what was going on. Was she going to tell him not to see her again?

His heart was beating like crazy.

Then, there was a buzz as another message arrived, and his heart froze for a moment.

Emma: I guess not... Lachlan's flying back home this morning.

Drew felt a conflict of emotions—hope was suddenly blooming inside him, optimism that Lachlan had done something wrong, revealed his dark, creepy side. Or else Emma had just flat turned him down. At the same time, he felt for Emma, if she had to deal with a relationship breaking down. And, he still felt nervous in case things hadn't gone badly with Lachlan—perhaps the guy had simply had to fly back because a relative had died.

Drew: What happened?

Emma: He asked me to marry him last night, and I said I wasn't ready for it. And then we talked about it, and I told him why I thought I wasn't ready for it, and he accused you of trying to spoil things between us and then we got into an argument... and now he's flying back :-(

Drew felt a hot flush of excitement—she'd turned Lachlan down! At the same time, he felt guilt from his role in messing things up for Emma. Perhaps if he hadn't been at the airport as they were leaving, she would have told Lachlan she wasn't ready for marriage, and Lachlan would have accepted her reasons, and agreed to wait until she was ready.

Drew: Are you okay? You want me to call you?

A few moments later, she texted back:

Emma: FaceTime?

He opened the app, and tapped Emma's name in his contact list.

And there she was, gazing out from his phone screen, so beautiful, she'd clearly had a touch of sunshine, though it didn't give her much of a tan, it made her freckles more prominent.

'Hey, it's good to see you,' he said, a trifle awkwardly, sitting back on the couch, suddenly remembering to look relaxed, not to give the game away that he was excited that Emma and Lachlan had had an argument, and he had apparently fled.

'God, I've missed you *so much*,' Emma said, breaking into the most breathtaking smile. From what he could see, she was still in bed, a large double or king with the kind of abstract art on the wall above the headboard that just screamed hotel or resort.

'How are you doing?'

She shrugged. 'I feel a little weird. I guess I never went out with someone for so long... and then had it blow up in my face.'

'Did you guys... break up?' Drew asked, trying not to seem like a vulture waiting to pick the carcass of Emma's broken relationship.

She sighed, 'I guess I see why you've been avoiding dating anyone all these years.'

'I'm sorry...' he said, pressed by his guilt. 'I shouldn't have gone to the airport... I shouldn't have... you know...'

Emma smiled warmly, 'No, don't apologize. I'm glad you did.'

'You... were?'

She said, 'It gave me... something to think about. And, I guess, when things weren't going so well with Lachlan, it gave me something to hold onto.'

'Was he angry I was there?' Drew asked her.

She laughed, 'I'll say. And he didn't even hear what you said to me.'

‘I probably shouldn’t have...’

‘No, you definitely should have... if it was true?’ she said, and now she was asking him a question, while trying not to sound as though it was a big deal. Her hopeful, fearful eyes gave her away.

‘It was true,’ he said, and her resulting smile warmed him by several degrees.

‘I never got to say it back,’ she said, pitying him. ‘You must have thought I was awful...’

‘No, not at all.’

‘I do love you, Drew. With all my heart,’ she said, and Drew felt like jumping around and shouting and telling the world.

‘Well, I know you’re feeling a little hurt right now...’ he said, concerned that she was jumping into something because she was torn up over Lachlan.

‘No,’ she said, ‘this trip has given me the chance to think. I know how I feel. And Lachlan and I... well, we’ve been arguing all week. I mean... at one point he told me I couldn’t see you anymore.’

‘So he’s flying back...?’

She nodded. ‘We had this big romantic meal, and I guess he was really trying to turn things around. He’d been planning it, though. We weren’t supposed to come here and argue all the time...’

‘What happened?’

‘The ring was in my dessert. It was... a nice ring. But by then I knew he wasn’t for me. I mean, I liked him. I had a great time with him. I liked the idea of... you know... settling down, having some kids... but I think this was me panicking. You know... I’m going to be thirty...’

‘In two years!’

‘Still... I don’t know... I’ve been really confused recently.’

‘Me too.’

‘Do you still feel confused?’ she asked.

‘No, I don’t think so,’ he said. ‘I thought you were my best friend, and that was it. I fell in love with you, and I was scared it would mean our friendship would be over.’

‘Why?’

‘Because neither of us could do long-term relationships.’

‘But now you’re not confused?’ she asked him.

He smiled. ‘Because I figure, we can do a long-term relationship when it’s with each other—we’ve been doing it practically our whole lives.’

‘Right,’ she smiled brightly.

‘And... you know, we could have kids, when we’re ready.’

‘We could,’ she nodded. ‘When we’re ready.’

He laughed, ‘I’m actually thinking sooner, rather than later.’

She laughed, too, seeming delighted at what he was suggesting. God. Kids, though. *That* was a big step.

She gazed into his eyes a moment, and he didn’t entirely know what to say next. He just enjoyed that moment. She loved him, and he loved her. They could be together forever, it wasn’t a daunting thought, because they’d already been doing it forever.

‘So are you flying back early?’ he asked her at last, when the obvious question emerged in his foggy but contented brain.

She sighed. ‘It’ll cost me five hundred bucks to catch an earlier flight,’ she said. ‘And it’s so gorgeous here.’

‘So you might as well stay,’ he said, figuring it was only another week without her. It would be hard, but doable.

‘I already spent so much on coming here,’ she said. ‘When Lachlan decided we should do something like this... well, it was all very last-minute.’

‘Expensive,’ Drew nodded. There was no way he was going to be able to afford just to fly out to be with her, either.

‘I guess it would be worth it, though... to be with you?’ she said, reconsidering now.

‘Stay, enjoy it while you can,’ he laughed, ‘I’ll be here as soon as you get back.’

‘Okay,’ she smiled. ‘I might have to call you, though, every night.’

‘Can’t wait. You can tell me about all the hot guys you’ve been flirting with.’

She giggled. ‘You’d like that, wouldn’t you?’ she said. Then, she was serious. ‘If we’re together... when I get back... do you still like the idea of me... seeing other guys as well?’

He didn’t even hesitate. ‘Of course,’ he said. ‘We’d just... you know... have to be careful our friends don’t find out.’

‘God, imagine if they found out!’

OceanofPDF.com

Chapter Eighteen

The second week of Emma's vacation was a completely different story. It wasn't just that she called him every night to chat before they went to sleep—even when Drew was on the late shift, and she had to stay up to a ridiculous hour. She was also texting him fairly constantly throughout the day, sharing her experiences, her thoughts, just being part of his life even though she was away.

It probably helped that she sent him lots of selfies of herself in various bikinis, and teased him with little reports about guys who hit on her, and her own efforts to flirt with those to whom she was attracted.

It was hot to think of her flirting with other guys. It was even hotter now, because Drew had the feeling she was really his, because they had declared their feelings for each other, because it really did look like they were together for the long-run now. It made everything seem so much more intense.

On Wednesday afternoon, Drew was working, but at the same time following along as Emma hung out with a group of frat boys from Ohio State University she'd been flirting with all week.

Emma would send him little updates, and occasional selfies throughout the afternoon, and when he could, Drew would send her little encouraging texts back. The group seemed to think Emma was just another college girl,

and Emma didn't try to correct them. She had fun with them while they fooled around at the pool, and later the beach.

When she sent him a little video clip of her wandering along the white sandy beach, azure blue ocean in the background, Drew had to hide away in a restroom stall in order to watch it. Emma looked gorgeous in a bikini that had a red top and white thong, but as the clip showed her stepping into the ocean water, it occurred to Drew that it couldn't be Emma shooting the video. He texted her.

Drew: So who's behind the camera?

Emma: He's called Mike, he's pretty cute. He wants to be a movie director someday, so I told him he could direct me.

Drew was almost hypnotized by the sight of Emma stepping into the ocean, somewhat carefully so she wasn't knocked over by the waves. Behind the camera, Mike was clearly interested in Emma's trim form, occasionally zooming in and out to highlight certain areas.

The clip showed Emma stopping once the water was waist-high, and turning to the camera to laugh flirtatiously. Then the camera turned, showing a male arm hooking around Emma's shoulders, before whirling around to reveal a selfie-type angle of Emma standing in the embrace of a tanned, toned and dark-haired guy Drew presumed was Mike.

Drew's manhood started thickening up. The two of them were standing so close... and now, Mike rested his head on Emma's shoulder, and she turned her head toward his.

They were kissing.

It was only brief, but it had Drew at full hardness in no time. Emma looked so stunning, and so excited by the prospect of a vacation fling.

Drew: So you like him, then?

Emma: He's fun. And hung. Can I play with him?

Drew: Of course xx

But the next time Drew received a video clip from her, he had to wait until his next break, and hiding away in the restroom was getting more difficult since it was beginning to get busy in the bar.

The clip showed Emma emerging from the surf, grabbing hold of Mike again for another smooch, before walking up the beach, the camera closely following her shapely ass. She had definitely been getting some sun. Now the clip cut to the sight of Emma climbing some stairs, the camera getting very close to her as she went. Was she taking him back to her room?

Drew felt his heart thumping. God, she was gorgeous. How could Lachlan have walked away from this?

Next up, the clip cut to the marble-floored lobby of the main resort building. Emma walking along fairly purposefully toward an elevator. Though she was now wearing a sarong over her bikini bottom, Drew got the distinct sense that she was taking Mike up to her room—this was just getting more and more exciting.

After seeing that clip, Drew had to almost meditate in order to calm down, and allow his hard-on to subside sufficiently to get back to work. Thankfully, having been on the day shift, it wasn't so long before he was able to head home. Emma sent him another video clip as he arrived back at his apartment building.

Then he was home, battling his way past a concerned Ray, who wanted to know how he was doing, whether he'd heard from Emma, yet, and whether he wanted to talk about it.

'I'm fine, buddy,' he said. 'Really. Just... really, really tired, you know?'

He felt bad not telling Ray or Carrie that Emma had been in touch, that things had changed, now, that she was no longer with Lachlan. But he wanted to give the appearance, if possible, that he hadn't just moved in on Lachlan's territory as soon as the guy broke up with Emma.

Ray simply shrugged, said, 'Okay, well you know where I'll be if you need to talk.'

Then he was sealed in his own room, pulling out his phone, clicking on the clip.

Here was Emma in the elevator, performing a mischievous little belly dance for the benefit of the camera, which focused on her hips before panning up to show her face as she broke out into giggles.

She looked so happy, Drew loved it. Her troubles seemed to have melted away.

Then she was exiting the elevator, her cameraman following her closely along a hallway until she stopped at a brown faux-walnut door. Inside, here was her room, grand and stylish with its floor-to-ceiling windows filled with the bright blues of the sky and the ocean, and the scorching yellow of the beach a dozen floors below.

The camera trekked over toward the windows, and then out onto a balcony overlooking the resort pool and, beyond it, the beach and the ocean.

Well yes, Drew regretted not being there with her himself. But it was too soon. Too soon.

Instead, he had the thrill of watching another man videoing Emma as she stepped out onto the balcony, and gazed out over the barrier at the ocean. Mike trailed the camera's eye all over her body, and she was smiling as he reached her face. Then he was filming her ass as he pulled off her sarong.

Now he was filming her wearing that tiny white thong, one hand emerging from behind the cameraphone to sweep over the delectable topography of her behind. Then he pulled back to get a shot of her full length, her hair blowing around in the wind so that as she turned to face the camera, she had to use both hands to brush it back over her shoulders. A

moment later, she was slipping down her bikini top to reveal her bare breasts and her stiff nipples.

‘You think anyone can see?’ she asked.

Drew felt his hardness throbbing as he watched the screen.

‘Does it matter?’ came Mike’s voice, off-screen. He pulled back to show Emma leaning against the balustrade, her gorgeous breasts exposed, and perhaps 500 yards away there was another tower from which people might look across and see what was going on.

Emma smiled, and Mike said, ‘Oh, you like it, huh? You like that someone might see.’

Mike approached her again, and now he was reaching for her bikini bottom, and Emma was tilting her hips this way and that to help him slip them down over her thighs, and off. He swept the camera all over her, glimpsing her sweet, bare pussy, before helping her remove her bikini top completely.

She smiled wickedly. The camera tilted down to show her exposed breasts, her nipples so very stiff, and then with Mike standing in front of her, her hands reaching for his crotch. She cupped the bulge in the man’s trunks, and then sank to her knees in front of it.

Drew was under the bedsheet by now, watching as the woman he loved now pulled down another man’s swim trunks to reveal his sizable cock, so stiff with its veins filled and prominent. She took it in her hands, and glanced past Mike briefly to see if she could spot anyone watching them.

Then, she gripped his cock tightly and took the tip into her mouth, gazing up at him, and the camera, before she started bobbing her head down on his length, sucking on his fat cock.

Mike moved the camera to the side to film her taking his length into her mouth, pumping his shaft with her hands. But that was the end of that clip.

There was a buzz as a text message came through.

Emma: Are you watching?

Drew nearly dropped his phone as he fumbled to reply.

Drew: I'm watching. Made it home, so I'm safely in bed. So you seem to like his cock.

Emma: Mmm nice and big. Wanna watch some more?

Drew: Please.

Emma sent through another clip, showing the same balcony as before, except that Emma was sitting on an outdoor chair, lying back, lifting her knees to offer her bare pussy to her frat boy lover. Now, Emma was holding the camera, which looked down her stomach, her thighs spread wide, her absent swimsuit leaving a slight tan line. And there was a naked Mike, kneeling in front of her, guiding his big cock to her exposed sex.

Drew caught his breath as he watched this other guy guide his cock to Emma's pussy, and then lean into her, thrusting slowly into her. Drew turned the volume up on his phone very slightly, so that he could hear Emma moan as the guy entered her.

'God, it's so huge...' she said to him as he removed his big cock from her and stroked it around the pink entrance to her pussy, spreading her wetness.

'Oh... oh... oh...'

Mike took over filming duties again to show Emma laying there, naked, as his cock disappeared into her sweet flower again and again. She was so pretty, her cheeks flushed pink as this stranger fucked her, smiling ear-to-ear. It didn't last so long, however, before he withdrew from her, and led her back into the room.

Drew watched as Emma stood by the window, offering her behind for her dark-haired lover to slide back into her, to fuck her in the slightly safer confines of the room.

The guy did well to hold the camera while he was pounding into her. To maintain that kind of focus was impressive with the obvious distraction. Was he aware Emma would send the clip to Drew?

Emma messaged him again shortly after he'd finished that clip.

Emma: So you like watching?

Drew: It's fantastic. You're so gorgeous, I wish I was there too xxx

Emma: You know, while he was filming it, all I could think about was that you'd get to see it. It made me so wet xxx

Drew: I'm so hard watching you

Emma: Here's some more xxx

Now Mike was lying on the bed, on his back, the camera gazing down his body toward his stiff dick and his toned thighs as Emma approached, clambered onto the mattress, and straddled him.

The camera focused on her exquisite breasts as she began to ride him, Emma fondling herself, squeezing her hard nipples in both hands. Then the view descended, past her stomach to her mound, and her hairless pussy as she rose and fell on him, his cock disappearing and reappearing each time between her thighs.

'Oh... oh... mmm...' Her moans were rising in pitch.

Drew watched as, on screen, Emma took the camera from Mike, lifting it high to show almost all of her as she fucked her dark-haired, tanned Lothario. The way she looked into the camera as she fucked him, Drew felt she was looking directly at him, showing him with her blazing eyes how much it turned her on to know he was watching.

Then the video cut to later—much later, presumably, since the lighting was completely different, artificial rather than daylight—and Drew was watching Emma kneeling on the floor, Mike standing over her as she sucked on his cock some more, her face looking all flushed, her hair clearly damp, suggesting they'd had a lot more sex since the last part they'd filmed. Emma was touching herself with one hand while she serviced her lover, the other hand gripping the base of his cock while she sucked him.

Mike seemed to be struggling to hold the camera straight, particularly as Emma's motion on his manhood intensified.

And then he pulled it away from her mouth, his hand gripping his own cock, and Drew watched as he unloaded spurt after spurt of thick white cream over her pretty face, making her smile and giggle as it coated her eyebrows, her nose, her cheeks. She was having a lot of fun with it, but for Drew, it seemed shocking, and in its ability to shock him, it only seemed to turn him on more.

Emma texted him:

Emma: Still watching?

Drew: Just finished. So you had a lot of fun, then!

Emma: Only wish you could have been there for afterward.

Drew: Mike probably wouldn't have wanted another guy there.

Emma: You could have hidden somewhere. Watched secretly.

Drew: So did he make you come?

Emma: You made me come. A couple of times, while I was thinking about you watching.

Drew: Where are you now?

Emma: In my room. He just went back to his room. Did you come yet?

Drew: Not yet.

Emma: Want some help getting to the end?

Drew: Sure.

And with that, Emma called him on FaceTime. She was sitting cross-legged on her bed, wearing the bikini she'd been wearing before Mike had pulled it off her, a red top and white thong. Smiling so cheerily to see him, toying with her hair and her breasts as he watched her, telling him to pull aside his bedsheet so that she could see him, see how hard he was for her.

He could hardly believe it was her, stripping off on his laptop screen, stroking herself, fondling her breasts. He could see every detail, the picture was perfect. Everything down to the freckles on her pretty face, the goosebumps over her exquisite breasts, the little glint of silver piercing her

navel, the shining wetness coating her fingers as her hand dipped down between her thighs.

‘Are you getting close?’ she said softly, making herself sigh and pant as she stroked her pussy.

‘I think so.’

‘You want me to tell you how good it felt when he was fucking me?’

‘Uh-huh...’

‘He was so big, sweetie, he was so thick...’

She sat back, opening her thighs so that he could see her fingers rubbing circles over her pink, hairless sex still wet from another man’s come.

‘I want you to come for me... will you come for me?’

But then before he came, she was coming herself, gasping for air, her face straining as the climax approached, tilting back.

Gasping, ‘Come for me... come for me...’

OceanofPDF.com

Chapter Nineteen

It would have been so easy for Emma to return home at the end of her vacation, tell everybody that things hadn't worked out between Lachlan and her, and that now she was with Drew.

Ray and Carrie would have been elated, of course.

They could have dated for a while, moved in together, maybe had a big wedding at some quaint place up in Vermont.

Fiona and Denny would have felt it was nice, having another married couple in their circle. And everybody loves a good wedding.

But the first thing Drew and Emma decided was that it was too soon after her break-up with Lachlan to come out as a bona fide couple. Lachlan had moved on to his law career, but Drew didn't want to be publicly dating Emma so soon after his employee had dated her.

There was another reason why they decided not to come out in public as a couple.

'They're never going to accept me seeing other guys while I'm supposed to be seeing you as well,' Emma said as they lay in bed together, just a few hours after her flight home had touched down at Logan Airport.

'No, they're not,' Drew agreed. 'I mean, you could take the risk, and do it in secret.'

‘Not in this city,’ she giggled. ‘Even if I take my date to the other end of town, one of them’s bound to run into us out on a date. Or I’ll be out with a friend, and we’ll run into one of my old dates.’

The trouble was, their friends were too close. Particularly when it came to Emma, somebody was always hanging out with her, chatting with her, inquiring into her life, her dating, her everything.

‘The way I see it, we have two options,’ Emma said, loving how quickly Drew got hard again after sex—just now, he was stiffening up again just fifteen minutes after coming. And the fact was, it happened because they were talking about Emma dating other guys.

‘What are those?’

‘Either we tell everybody we’re dating,’ she said, pumping his thickening shaft. ‘In which case I have to stop seeing other guys—I guess, unless I go out of town on a business trip, or something.’

‘Or...?’

She climbed up onto him, straddling him so that she could stroke his hardness with her soaking wet pussy. ‘Or...’ she said, moaning quietly as she brushed her sensitive folds down his full length, ‘we don’t tell anybody we’re dating at all... and I date other guys like before. Only... actually I’d be dating you secretly.’

‘So no real change there, then,’ Drew laughed. ‘What if you got into another Lachlan type deal?’

‘I wouldn’t see anyone for too long,’ she said, making him gasp as she slid down on his pole, taking him inside her burning-hot pussy again. ‘And I’d always know I was really with you,’ she smiled.

‘How about this...’ he said, grabbing hold of her and rolling her over onto her back, his cock still inside her. ‘I give you this... just for now...’

He sat up, still inside her, and there was a small box in his hand.

Emma gasped. She opened it to find a ring.

‘You wouldn’t have to tell anybody about it,’ he said, since she was apparently stunned into silence. ‘Then when you’re ready... you know... we could go on vacation to Vegas... or somewhere like that...’

‘Oh my God...’

She put the ring on her finger, marveling at the sparkle of the diamond. Then she grabbed him, wrestled him onto his back so she could go on top, and show off the ring in the light.

‘You know, I always wanted a Vegas wedding,’ she said, gently gyrating her hips over him as she admired her ring. ‘We’d have to have Elvis officiating.’

‘Of course.’

‘Then we’d really come back here and be *secretly married*?’

He smiled. ‘Then there’d be no doubt. For us, anyway.’

She gave him a wicked look. ‘I’d be a properly cheating wife,’ she said, and he nearly came right there and then.

Chapter Twenty

Then they were in Vegas, and it was all such a wild ride.
The lights, the drinks, the casinos.

The Elvis Wedding Chapel, last thing on a Saturday night.

As far as any of their family or friends knew, it was just a vacation they were taking together. Best friends. Sure, a full public wedding in front of all of them could be on the cards down the road, when they were ready to become the classic suburban married couple. But for now, they were having a whale of a time together, and nobody had to know they were married except them.

They were married, and Emma was flirting with Elvis all the way through the ceremony.

She'd given Drew a ring, and Elvis her phone number.

Later, they were in a bar at the MGM Grand and Drew got to watch his wife standing at the bar being hit on by all manner of guys who were in town just briefly to gamble and get laid. What a blast! He watched her chatting with the men, toying with her hair, pushing out her chest to draw their attention. And every now and then, she would text him to ask him how he was doing, whether she should try inviting one of them back to their room.

And then, later still, while they were checking out the Bellagio, Elvis texted Emma.

He'd hit his marriage quota for the day, and asked if they wanted some company. They didn't hesitate to invite him out. And he was a cool guy—more Christian Slater doing Elvis, than Elvis himself—and quickly seemed to connect with Emma, the two of them enjoying undoubted chemistry. And he wasn't put off by the fact that he had just married them that afternoon.

The way Emma was so shamelessly flirting with him quite took Drew's breath away.

As he watched Emma laughing at another thing Elvis said, Emma suddenly turned her head to check out his response to her flirting with the guy. Raising one of her eyebrows, the look she gave him was simultaneously mischievous, teasing, and wickedly erotic. She was being naughty, and she knew it. And she seemed to love the fact that Drew was enjoying every moment.

His wife. Wasn't it strange that he could call her that, now?

All it took, seemingly, was a sparkle from her green eyes, and a smirk from her pretty lips, and Drew was reminded of how much Emma enjoyed seducing attractive men—and how sexy, ultimately, Drew found her enjoyment to be in that particular direction. He watched her subtly fiddling with the little silver pendant that hung down her chest, and saw that it was guiding the dark-haired man's eyes down to that scandalous hint of exposed lace, and the way her breasts pushed out the white cotton of her shirt.

Drew felt a burn of desire inside his chest, but also a churning in the stomach that seemed like nerves. Why should he be nervous now? Emma was his wife. There was no way he could lose her to this guy, or anyone else.

The thing was, now she was his wife, everything seemed so much more intense. The wickedness, the taboo, the erotic nature of it all. The paranoid fear of loss. He felt certain he only had to ride the wave of emotions, and

then he would be okay. He wasn't jealous, was he? How could he possibly be jealous when he wanted her to seduce the guy? He wanted her to bed him, to fuck the guy senseless.

Then they were all moving on to a club, and Drew found a seat at the edge of the dance floor as Elvis led Emma out into the middle, to wow her with his moves. It felt like Uma Thurman and John Travolta doing the twist in the middle of Jack Rabbit Slim's, though with Elvis appearing as Travolta.

They danced, and took the occasional breather with a cocktail or two, and Drew learned that Elvis was actually called Josh, and that when he wasn't officiating at a wedding chapel, he was studying at the University of Nevada, Las Vegas. He was only 22, though his makeup made him look older.

As the night rolled on, the music turned slow, and Drew watched as Emma danced close with Josh, their hands spreading all over each other, Josh enjoying Emma's tight dress and Emma enjoying Josh's tight rhinestone jumpsuit. Drew liked that Emma occasionally glanced over toward him, to silently check with him that this was all okay, that he was happy for her to be fooling around with Josh, and that he was very definitely watching.

When it started getting really late, Emma had her arms flung over Josh's shoulders, and he had his hands on her behind, and the two of them were making out like teenagers in the middle of the depleted crowd on the dance floor. Drew wasn't quite expecting how insanely turned on he was at the sight of her kissing a guy right in front of him, pressing herself up against him, no doubt feeling how hard he was for her as she locked lips with him and sucked on his mouth.

And then, to Drew's complete surprise, Emma led Josh off the dance floor directly toward Drew, approached him, and, somewhat breathless, said, 'Hey, sweetie, Josh is going to come back to our room to party.'

She smiled sweetly, seeming so innocent, and for a moment Drew was completely confused about what she meant.

‘He’s going to—?’ he said, feeling like an idiot.

She laughed. ‘And he says it’s okay if you want to *watch*.’

OceanofPDF.com

Chapter Twenty-One

Even after everything that had happened so far, he felt completely unprepared for the raw emotion that surged through him as they wandered back to their room.

In the taxi, Emma had sat between them, one hand on Drew's thigh, reassuring him at first, and then as she gave in to temptation, and started making out some more with Josh, right there next to him, her hand edged upward to seek out the bulge in Drew's pants, and stroke him there.

As he heard the quiet, wet sounds of their kissing, particularly when the battered yellow Prius was sitting at traffic lights, and saw her head turned to Josh's, his hands cradling her jaw, Drew felt surprisingly out of breath.

This was Emma. *His* Emma. His wife. Kissing another guy on their wedding day.

It all felt so different than anything that had come before. It wasn't just the fact that it was going on right beside him—Emma giggling in the dark as Josh kissed her neck—the biggest change was the connection Drew now felt with Emma. She was his wife, now. His beautiful bride. It might have been at a wedding chapel, but they had pledged themselves to each other 'til death did they part. They had a marriage license. Drew felt physically and mentally bonded to her now.

Only, now she was turned facing another guy, quietly moaning and occasionally giggling as she sucked on his lips, and his hands disappeared inside her jacket, sprawling all over her breasts.

It was different than how it had been when he'd just been her friend, enjoying the strange tension of knowing she was going out on a date with another guy. It was different, even to the occasions he had watched her with another man. It was like somebody had turned the volume up, not only on the actual sound, but on his feelings, his responses.

He was still envious of the guy, getting to be the focus of her attention, to enjoy her sweet kisses like that, to make her moan and giggle. He still felt that undercurrent of gentle fear that she would really like him, that he would change her mind about her present circumstances, whisk her off her feet and take her away from him. He still felt that strange little tickle of emotional confusion at the realization that she was soon going to be fucking someone else, not him.

But now it was all totally overwhelmed by an incredible, raw excitement, the likes of which he had never felt before.

His wife was going to fuck this guy. Drew was caught up in the frenzy of her passion and her lust, the undiluted thrill of her arousal for this new partner. It felt like being on a surfboard as the most colossal wave approached, the sea level dropping as the monster sucked in all the water, preparing to throw it all back at him in a huge surge.

He felt her excitement, and it only provoked more excitement in him. He sensed her arousal for Josh, and it only drove his own arousal for her to new heights. He heard her moans, her deep breathing. He knew her nipples would be stiff as Josh's hands fondled her breasts through the opening in her shirt. He guessed she was already wet for him, her sweet pussy tingling in anticipation of getting Josh home, pulling out his cock, riding him until she was screaming. And it only made Drew want her more, it only made him desire her more, it only made him adore her more.

It only made him love her more.

For a moment, as they approached the Red Rock, where they were staying, Emma's hand stopped stroking Drew's cock through his pants, and he initially suspected that her pause meant she was too caught up in her lust for Josh to continue any kind of attention on him. But then she turned her head, gazing into his eyes, her beautiful face warm with affection, but also poised with concern, making sure this was what he wanted—even, silently, offering him the chance to take her back alone, leaving Josh forsaken by the roadside.

Drew smiled. Reassured her that this was, most definitely, what he wanted, that watching her in the throes of passion with this dark-haired stranger was most certainly the most thrilling thing that could happen for them all.

And she leaned into him, and kissed him, and it was the sweetest kiss ever. This wasn't making out, this wasn't fooling around. This wasn't a little harmless fun on a Saturday night. This was deep, passionate, connection. This was powerful, earth-shaking commitment. This was lust, but it was also adoration, worship, a pledge of her devotion.

This was love, and there was no mistaking it.

Then they were back at their resort, Josh clambering out of the taxi first, Emma breaking away from Drew to scamper out next, leaving Drew to pay the fare and then follow them in through the main entrance, his heart fluttering to see her holding Josh's hand. Her light flirtatious laughter responding to something he'd said while they walked up to the elevators toward the room where they were going to sleep together.

Had she really been telling the truth when she'd uttered those words in the club?

He says it's okay if you want to watch.

Suddenly, Drew wondered if he'd imagined it. If he'd heard her wrong.

But why else would they be here, all together? Why else would Josh be holding the elevator door so that Drew could step in with them? Why else would they start making out again as soon as the elevator door was closed, when he was standing in there with them, just a foot or two away?

Upstairs, they were lounging in an expansive Bridal Suite, and Emma was pouring white wine for them all from the mini-bar, and apologizing that they didn't have anything more exciting than that after all the fancy cocktails that evening.

And then Josh was politely asking how long they'd been together, and the question seemed to stun Drew, that Emma had been talking to this guy about their history as a couple, even as she pursued the possibility that he would sleep with her.

Josh was talking about their relationship as casually as he might ask about the weather. Emma was sitting beside Josh as though she was married to *him*, her hand lightly placed on his thigh, stroking him there while they all sipped their Chenin Blanc. And the clear intention of it all was that Josh would be having sex with her in a short while.

Emma was smiling affectionately across from the couch at Drew as he sat there on an armchair.

Drew found his heart pumping like crazy, thumping inside his chest as though trying to escape, while adrenaline surged through his system, his cock so very rock-hard inside his pants. All the while her hand was on Josh's thigh, as though she was claiming him as her territory.

And Josh didn't even raise an eyebrow that they were newlyweds, despite the fact that he was about to sleep with her himself—on their wedding night.

Emma edged forward to top up Drew's glass, which was sitting empty on the coffee table, and he smiled gratefully, before being distracted by being able to see down her shirt as she leaned over to pour the wine. She was wearing a fairly plain, black bra, but the illicit nature of his glimpse

souped up the eroticism—not to mention the idea that Emma was about to give this kind of view, and a whole lot more, to Josh some time very soon.

Drew wanted to ask Josh if he'd done this kind of thing before, the guy seemed so relaxed about it all, but then he didn't want the question to make it seem like he was a complete rookie when it came to unconventional relationships.

Instead, he asked Josh how long he'd been impersonating Elvis.

'Oh, ten, eleven months?' the guy smiled easily. 'It's something my dad used to do, growing up. So... you know... seemed like a good way to make tuition.'

Emma topped up his drink, and Drew realized that his drink was the only one empty.. Josh, and Emma herself, were hardly more than sniffing their own drinks. Drew felt his thick cock pulse at the sense that she might be trying to get him a little drunk to help him cope with watching another man sleep with her while they were in the same room. There was something strangely sexy about that thought.

When Drew put his glass down again, he was feeling the warmth of the alcohol in his bloodstream, and now that he thought about it, it had taken the edge off his fear and paranoia.

He noticed Emma was leaning into Josh now, and one of the straps of her dress had slipped off her shoulder, so that more of her bra was visible, offering an unsubtle peek at her cleavage. She was laughing at something he'd said. Drew had to focus to figure out what she was saying.

'I mean, I heard of the Best Man sneaking away for a fumble with the bride...' she was saying. Drew could hardly believe it.

'Hey, it's all good, right? I mean, if hubby's okay with it...'

The way she was sitting as the two of them flirted right in front of Drew, she was practically straddling the younger man already. Drew could hardly breathe, it was so hot.

Then she said, 'I'm gonna... go freshen up...' And she was looking at Drew. For a moment, he almost missed the fact that she had a sort of pleading look in her eyes. Then he noticed it, and raised an eyebrow to inquire whether she was okay.

'Would you... come help me with something?' she said quietly as she picked herself up from the couch.

'Uh... sure...' he said, uncertain of what she wanted. Did she need one last little chat to make sure everything was okay with all this?

Emma topped up Josh's drink for the first time, pouring him the last few drops of the wine bottle, and told him, 'I'll be back in a minute or two, okay? There's more wine in the fridge, if you like.'

Josh nodded and smiled, and then Emma was leading Drew through into the bedroom, a serious expression on her face. Drew was puzzled, thinking *surely she can't be the one thinking of backing out, worried about how it might be?*

'Hey, you okay?' he asked her, trying not to sound as though he was worried.

She put a finger to her lips, smiled, and then quietly closed the bedroom door to isolate them from Josh, who seemed happy enough to wait with his wine out there on the couch.

Then she whispered, 'Will you help me change into something a little more... *alluring?*'

Drew chuckled quietly. 'You know he doesn't care what you wear.'

'I care.'

'He just wants to tear it all off.'

'Maybe with this, he'll want me to keep it on,' she grinned, placing Drew on the end of the bed as though he was a particular bloom in a very important flower arrangement. Emma wanted to change, she wanted tonight to be perfect. This was their wedding night, after all.

He sat there and watched as she peeled off her dress, revealing her black bra, which would have been plenty sexy enough for Drew if he'd been on a first date with her. Any date with her, come to think of it. But Drew had seen her in fancier underwear.

'So you're going to be okay?' she asked, as her dress slipped off her hips, revealing her matching black panties.

'Okay?' he seemed uncertain why she would even need to ask him.

'He's going to be the first man to sleep with me on my wedding night,' she said, and it made Drew's heart thump ten times more quickly.

'Oh, right,' he said, understanding the significance. And yet his cock stiffened further to think of his *wife* bedding another man *before* her new husband got the chance. It was so wrong, and that was why it was so hot.

'I think the question is, is he really okay with me being here?' he asked her, trying to play down his nerves, make it seem like it wasn't a big deal that he wouldn't get to take his bride until Josh had first.

Emma shrugged. 'He told me he's done this before.'

'Wow,' Drew said, somewhat taken aback by the possibility of such a thing being a regular happening.

'Husbands watching their wives... it's more common than you think, apparently,' Emma smiled, and now peeled off her panties, right in front of him. He couldn't help but gaze at her bare pussy, not quite fully believing that she was really going to give it to Josh that night.

When he looked back upward, to connect with her face, she was beaming, ear-to-ear, apparently enjoying immensely how he was looking at her.

'It's kind of sexy, isn't it?' she said.

Emma seemed to be fumbling with the catch behind her bra, so Drew stood to help her. 'It's always difficult, this one,' she grinned, turning so he could tend to the catch in the middle of her back. 'If it wasn't so comfortable....'

He slipped the thing off her shoulders, and when she turned back to face him, he saw that her nipples were like bullets. Now she pulled out something crimson and lacy from a drawer in her bedside table. Stooped and lifted a foot to step into the thing, and he saw it was a pair of very small-looking panties. A g-string.

‘You like it?’ she said, modeling it for him, and it was only inches away from his face. She looked sensational, but then the thing hardly covered anything of her.

‘It looks *insane* on you,’ he said, with a grin.

She smiled, and seemed almost relieved, as well as delighted at his reaction. Taking in the adoration he gave her, his eyes unable to stop roaming all over her trim body, she slowly reached for something else from the drawer—a matching crimson-colored bra—and did not rush in putting it on.

‘This looks okay, too?’ she said, threading her arms under the straps, slipping them onto her shoulders before positioning the cups over the gorgeous swell of her breasts.

‘Amazing,’ he said, and it struck him just how important it seemed for her to gain his approval.

This wasn’t just a little sexy teasing before the main act. This wasn’t merely a bit of fun to share with her best friend-turned-lover before she temporarily gave herself to another man. She needed this, and it quite clearly turned her on that he was sanctioning what she was putting on for Josh.

Was this how it had always been? At least, since she’d known he was straight. Perhaps even longer. Was there something about him telling her this was how he wanted it that got her juices flowing?

Interesting.

She stood in front of him, looking just incredible. Her panties were tiny, and fairly sheer, so that he could see the little glint of silver that was her clit

ring. Her matching bra was sexy with its flourish of lace, but sufficiently sheer to give an impression of her nipples, and just how stiff they were.

She paused, waiting for his verdict, but although Drew would have loved to see her walk back out to that living room and offer herself to the younger man dressed like this, there was something he wanted to try first.

‘Don’t you think something’s missing?’ he said.

She looked a little startled at first, and he realized that in all their time together, he’d very rarely criticized her appearance, or her outfits, for that matter. Despite telling her which outfit was best, when she’d offered him the choice, he’d rarely been negative about any of the options she’d presented him with.

‘I don’t understand...’ she said, genuinely confused.

He tried to soften his approach a little. A suggestion, rather than a critique. He said, ‘Don’t you think he might like to see you wearing stockings?’

Emma seemed to hesitate a moment while his words sank in. Then one of her eyebrows rose slowly, and the corners of her mouth curled upward into a tentative smile.

‘Maybe...’ she said, then turned to look at Drew, the inquisitive look on her face silently asking him whether he wanted to see her in stockings, or if this was simply him honestly thinking about what someone like Josh might prefer.

‘*I* think you’d look just unbelievable in stockings,’ he said, stressing that this was his personal opinion.

Her eyes flashed. ‘As my master wishes,’ she joked, but somehow she wasn’t entirely joking. She blushed faintly as she reached into another drawer in her bedside table, and fished out something else black—a suspender belt. It didn’t quite match her bra and panties, style-wise, but the black went well enough with the crimson.

The important thing was, Emma was most certainly turned on by him asking her to do something, demanding she wear stockings. Did she have a little streak of submission in her?

He noticed in that bottom drawer, there was something scarlet in color, with a black trim. It looked like a sleep mask, except that the colors made it seem erotic, rather than practical. A blindfold, rather than a sleep mask. What else did she have in that drawer? Did she have more kinky toys in there?

He watched her put the suspender belt around her waist, and then sit beside him on the end of the bed to put on her stockings. When she was putting the second one on, he was able to stroke her leg in the first stocking, marveling at its arousing effect on him.

She enjoyed him touching her legs, she enjoyed him so clearly obsessing over her. She stood in front of him, giving him a wonderful close-up view as he helped her to attach the suspenders to the tops of her stockings. Then, finally, she stood smartly in front of him for her final inspection—turned, presenting her beautiful derriere, before completing a full 360—and then she was ready to go back out to Josh.

‘You can leave, if you want to,’ she said, offering him a final are-you-really-sure-about-this expression as they both stood by the door.

‘Why would I want to do that?’ he smiled, and she returned the smile.

He was shaking a little, though.

‘You ready?’ she smiled.

He took a deep breath, and an idea suddenly jumped out at him. She noticed, and her brow furrowed slightly in puzzlement. He darted to her bedside table, and retrieved something. Something scarlet and black.

He held it up so that she could see what it was. She smiled, and raised her eyebrows at the hint of kinkiness in his latest demand.

‘Put it on,’ he said.

‘Yes, *sir*,’ she said softly, with only the slightest hint of amusement now. He sensed that he was beginning to tap into something, something buried deep within her.

She did as he asked, slipping the blindfold on over her head, pulling it on over her eyes. She voluntarily removed her sight from the equation. And then she stood in front of the door, straight and still, awaiting his next command.

Drew told her to go in.

OceanofPDF.com

Chapter Twenty-Two

Josh was on his feet as soon as he laid eyes on her. Emma shuffled in, unsteadily, wearing crimson and black lingerie, the blindfold in place over her eyes, completely on display for the two men, though her own vision was blocked. She was trembling slightly, both apprehensive and deeply aroused by the prospects.

Drew was surprised she complied instantly with what he suggested—commanded, really. He was surprised at himself, for doing this. For guiding Emma into a room in which they were not alone, when she was quite clearly dressed for sex.

Guiding her into a room to have sex with the other man within.

Drew was also a little surprised by how completely unruffled Josh seemed by it. The easygoing younger man seemed totally at ease with Emma being in this state, and when he stood to show his willingness to take part in whatever this was, he looked to Drew with a perfectly composed deference to the other man. Almost as though he was the apprentice, and Drew was the master.

It gave Drew a confidence he wasn't expecting, enough to usher Emma into the room, and into position in front of Josh, who quietly pushed the coffee table out of the way before stepping up to her.

‘Turn to face me, Emma,’ Drew said, and took a seat opposite them on the armchair. Emma complied, without even a smirk by now. She was no longer amused by his assumed authority. She was breathing shallowly, and goosebumps had broken out over much of her smooth, soft skin though it was plenty warm enough in there. He could tell her heart was all a-flutter, too.

As she faced him, he took in the sight of her in the crimson bra and panties, the sheer material allowing him to see her almost completely.

He glanced at Josh, and gave him a curt little nod, which told him, *begin*, though it included no particular specifics.

Josh stepped up to Emma, standing behind her. Drew saw her catch her breath as the guy’s hands touched down on her shoulders.

‘You have cold hands,’ she said, smiling as Josh swept them down over her chest, briefly taking in the shape of her body.

‘They’ll soon warm up,’ Drew said, as Josh maintained a dignified, respectful silence. *The guy’s done this kind of thing before*, Drew was thinking.

‘Kiss her neck,’ Drew suddenly told him, adding, ‘she likes that.’

Josh pulled Emma’s hair back over her shoulder, brushing it out of her face with his hands, holding it away from her neck as he leaned in to carry out Drew’s command. Emma bit her lip, and tilted her head to allow the younger man access. Then she quietly sighed as she felt his lips press against her delicate neck, one arm encircling her, his strong hand pressing against her chest, cupping her breast.

Emma’s hands were clamped to Josh’s thighs behind her as he kissed her, his own hands moving to the straps of her bra. Josh’s eyes connected with Drew’s as the younger man sought permission to remove Emma’s bra.

‘Take it off,’ Drew nodded.

Emma couldn’t help breaking out into a giggle as Josh slipped the straps of her bra off her shoulders, and tugged it down to expose her bare breasts.

‘Everything okay?’ Drew asked her, as Josh leaned in to kiss her neck on the other side, his hands moving around to cover her chest.

‘Oh yes,’ she said, beaming from ear to ear as Josh gently pulled her hair back as though he was about to tie it up, then nudged his face against her cheek, one finger moving to stroke her lips.

‘Kiss her mouth,’ Drew said quietly, but firmly. Josh turned her head toward him, and his lips joined hers.

Emma kissed him back eagerly as his free hand roamed over her bare breasts. Drew could see her tongue slip into Josh’s mouth as they kissed, and it reminded him of how incredible it had felt to kiss her himself. It had seemed so dangerous at the time, somehow even more so than the oral sex they’d shared—more intimate, more categorical about their feelings for each other, and the risk that it represented for their friendship.

But they’d moved on since then, hadn’t they? Their relationship had become so much more than just a friendship.

Drew envied the younger man as he made out with Emma, but he suppressed the feeling, thinking, instead, that perhaps it was safe, now, to kiss her like that himself. Now, thanks in no small part to Josh, the idea was out there that you could have a perfectly committed long-term romantic relationship, while one of you continued to date other people. It was just that the dating had to be a shared experience.

And wasn’t this the ultimate shared experience? Drew was so hard as he watched Emma making out with Josh, her hands reaching behind her to explore the bulge in the guy’s crotch. He told her to remove the Elvis jumpsuit. Josh had a pair of boxer shorts on underneath, but nothing else.

Drew now said, ‘You can get her to kneel now, Josh.’

He could have simply asked Emma to kneel, but there was something slightly off-kilter, and therefore appealing, about carrying out his bidding via the younger man. As though he was using Josh as his toy, to pleasure Emma.

Josh took hold of one of Emma's arms behind her back, and expertly compelled her down to the floor in front of him. She smiled, biting her lip suggestively, and as she knelt there, turned her head toward him, toward his crotch, knowing exactly where it was, despite the blindfold.

'Let her suck on you,' Drew said, and Josh didn't question anything for a moment, one of his hands making a ponytail out of her hair as he held her in position.

Drew did his best to conceal a gasp, as the man pulled out his hard cock from his boxer shorts.

Emma smiled, and jumped slightly as she felt the tip of the great, hard member touch against her cheek.

Josh turned her head a little more with one hand, while he directed his cock to her lips with the other. Drew felt his heart skip, and his own hardness throb as he watched her take the other man's cock in her mouth.

God, it was so wrong. But so unbelievably hot.

Emma—*his* Emma—had another man's stiff, veiny cock in her pretty mouth. She was sinking down on it, sucking on him, and Drew was only a few feet away, watching everything. God, how he wanted her. And yet, there was so much more he wanted to try before he snatched her away from this other man.

'Show her how you like it, Josh,' Drew said, and it made Emma smile briefly, before Josh gently took her hands away from his shaft, then took hold of her head and began leading the movement of his manhood within her mouth.

Emma submissively placed her hands behind her back and opened her mouth wide as Josh began carefully, but confidently, fucking her mouth.

Emma moaned quietly, apparently enjoying being the younger man's plaything, smirking excitedly as he occasionally removed his cock from her mouth to tease her, to stroke it around her lips, her cheeks, her neck, before

returning it to the warmth of her eager mouth, lightly pumping his hips as he thrust it inside her.

‘That’s enough,’ Drew said, eventually. ‘She’ll suck you dry if you’re not careful.’

Emma, still blindfolded, giggled and wiggled her bottom mischievously at that, loving the idea of trying to suck the other man dry.

‘Take off her panties,’ Drew said, stroking the hardness in his lap now, through his pants.

Josh sat on the edge of the couch, and urged Emma up off her knees—whereupon he had her lie across his lap as though he was about to spank her. He gripped her behind in one hand, while the other arm held her about the shoulders. He kissed her cheek, and playfully slapped her behind a couple of times, making her giggle. But then he was tugging on her panties, dragging the skimpy scrap of crimson over the roundness of her behind to her thighs.

‘Is she already wet?’ Drew asked him.

Josh kissed her cheek again, while his hand moved between her buttocks, his fingers delving inside her, making her gasp.

‘Soaking,’ he replied to the older man, his fingers stroking her there. Emma bit her lip and sucked in her breath at the violation of his fingertips inside her.

‘Do you like the taste of a beautiful woman?’ Drew asked him.

‘Yes, sir.’

‘Then do it. Use your mouth on her. She loves that.’

Emma almost purred in anticipation. Josh lifted her, and slipped out from under her, placing her down on the couch, all in one movement. Then he was the one kneeling on the floor, pulling her panties off her elevated legs. Laying his eyes on her bare pussy, taking in the sight of her pink flesh, unframed by any hint of hair, topped off with that simple, wicked-looking, silver ring.

‘Oh my God...’ she breathed as his mouth touched down on her sensitive sex, and he kissed her there,

Drew moved to the other end of the couch so that he could see everything as the younger man pleased her with his mouth, lapping gently at her soft folds, making her sigh and whimper as she held her legs wide apart and upward. He leaned in, stroked her dirty blonde hair, and adjusted the blindfold slightly to ensure she could not see anything.

Emma reached up to stroke her hand down Drew’s chest, appreciative, sharing her delight with the man who had given this to her.

‘Oh...’ she moaned.

‘Does it feel good?’ Drew asked her quietly.

‘Oh God yeah... does it look good?’ she grinned, and gasped again as Josh sucked on her.

‘So hot...’

‘You like him licking my pussy?’

‘Oh yeah.’

‘So fucking good...’

She caught her breath as Josh slid a finger, then two, inside her, while his mouth focused on her clit. He fucked her with his digits, and she was moaning louder, so that it sounded as though she was pleading for permission to come.

But he said, ‘Don’t come. Not yet, honey. Don’t come yet.’

He could see her lip tremble as the command filtered through her, and she fought with her own body to suppress the oncoming orgasm.

‘Can you do that for me?’ Drew asked her.

‘Y-yes...’ she said, breathless, her brow furrowed slightly as she concentrated on holding back from full release.

Drew stroked her hair as Josh continued a little more, making it so difficult for her to keep from hitting her orgasm. She pushed the blindfold

off her face, and gazed up at Drew with sharp eyes, as though asking if he was really serious about this, and begging for him to let her come.

‘Why don’t you take him in your mouth a little more,’ Drew smiled, his tone indicating that it might help her to calm down a little, to pace herself.

Josh pulled back, stood up, and began removing his clothes. Emma gazed up at him, grinning, laughing, looking at him as though to say, *I bet you never thought we’d all end up like this.*

But then Drew was directing her back onto her knees, and Josh was fully naked this time, as she leaned forward to take his big, hard cock in her mouth. He let her handle his member a while, gripping it in her hands as she licked and sucked the end. But then he was holding her head again, keeping her hair back out of her face, slowly fucking her mouth.

Drew felt distinctly odd, being this close to another man when he was naked, with his cock so hard, while he was thrusting it into Emma’s mouth. Even directing it himself, he was a little surprised at just how overwhelming his response to it was. The curious cocktail of emotions and reactions. The faint revulsion to the presence of a naked man in their midst, tempered by the strange eroticism of that hard cock caressing Emma’s pretty face, or sliding inside her eager mouth. The envy of how Josh had to be feeling with her skillful lips wrapped around his shaft jostling with the joy of being able to sit back and watch it happening from an independent viewpoint. The fear that she adored his cock too much, countered by the pleasure of knowing she was so thrilled by the experience, her body trembling with sexual bliss. The jealousy of not being able to have her himself, while this stranger could, overwhelmed by the fact that witnessing this debauchery only made him desire Emma more, and knowing that when she was done with the younger man, she would be available for him.

‘That’s enough,’ Drew said as he watched the other man stroking his cock over Emma’s face, rubbing glistening pre-come over her forehead, her nose, her cheeks. ‘I think we’re ready for the main course.’

Josh looked up at him, and he gave a small nod. Emma rose to her feet, but only until Josh guided her down onto the couch, so that she waited on all fours for him.

Drew perched on the arm of the couch, and Emma smiled excitedly up at him as Josh sat on the edge of the couch beside her feet, planting kisses around the pleasing curves of her buttocks. Her hand went to Drew's crotch, seeking out the bulge in his pants, beaming as she found just how hard he was.

'He's going to fuck you now,' Drew said.

'You're ready for this?' she said, looking up at him earnestly.

'I'm ready.' He stroked her hair, and she stroked his bulge,

'You're ready for Josh to fuck me?'

Her words sent a shiver through Drew's entire body. 'I'm ready.'

Then she was gazing up into his eyes as Josh knelt behind her, his big cock stiff and pointed down toward her pussy. He rested his hands on her waist, and then eased forward, and Drew saw the tip of his cock nudge against her entrance—before sinking, slowly, inside.

'Oh *God*...' Emma sighed, her mouth wide as the younger man slid his throbbing cock inside her quivering pussy.

Drew felt her hand press urgently against his own hardness as the other man thrust into her. He stroked her head, reassuring her. When the other man pressed into her from behind, he pushed her up toward Drew, her head coming to rest on Drew's thigh, just an inch or two from the protrusion in his pants.

'Oh...' she moaned, as Josh sped up his thrusting into her pussy. 'His cock feels so good, sweetie... so good...'

She sighed and whimpered and clung onto Drew's thigh as Josh began to pound her. Drew could hardly believe it. He'd imagined this so many times, and here it was, actually happening. He could see everything in phenomenal detail: the pink flush in her skin, the shiver of her flesh every

time the other man thrust against her, the glistening of the man's veiny cock as he dipped it into her juicy pussy time and time again.

It was just such an incredible experience. This wasn't listening to her having sex through a wall, or the doors of their apartments: she was right with him, her head now nudging up against his hard cock as she gasped and cried. He could hear the silky sounds of her deep breathing as her body writhed under the bombardment of the other man's cock. He could hear the wet sounds of the man's shaft penetrating her and grazing up against every surface of her dripping pussy. He could smell the dark spiciness of her arousal, the slight earthiness of their perspiration, the musky funk of pure sex, fresh right before him.

'Let her go on top,' Drew ordered Josh, and he smiled, then grabbed Emma, who let out a surprised squeal as the younger man held her and lifted her, so that she went with him as he lay back on the sofa, leaving her straddling him, facing Drew, her legs wide apart so that he could see the man's shaft disappearing, again and again into her soaking, pink flower.

'Oh... oh... oh God... oh yes...'

She was stroking her clit as that enormous shaft plunged into her, again and again, but after a while she was sitting up, taking more control of the situation, and it was her riding Josh, rather than Josh thrusting up into her.

Drew moved back to the armchair to watch when she turned to face Josh, riding him straight cowgirl-style, her hair beginning to get damp with perspiration, her flushed skin a touch shiny.

It was all so vigorous, so physical, as though both of them were using each other as gym equipment for the most exhausting, yet fulfilling, workout—there was no tiring for them, the adrenaline made them immune to fatigue, the sexual arousal dulling the throb of lactic acid in their muscles.

Drew wondered if this was how Emma was when it was just her and a lover—perhaps she was going the extra distance because he was watching.

She just kept on going, panting away, sitting back on the couch as Josh knelt up to her to continue slamming his big dick into her, turning over so that her butt was raised high over the edge of the couch, so that Josh could pound into her from behind, lying along the couch on her back so that Josh could lay over her, drilling into her from above.

Drew didn't even remember at what point he pulled his own cock out of his pants, but there he was, pumping away as he saw his gorgeous Emma taking it hard from the other man—and she was just delighted to see him giving in to temptation, to reveal how hard she was making him, as he exposed his hardness to the open air.

And it was only as Josh said over and over that he was going to come, and Emma pulled away from him that Drew realized there wasn't a condom in the place.

Emma didn't seem fazed. She slid down onto the floor, and Josh looked over to Drew as he stood over her, clearly seeking permission.

Drew gave a little nod. 'You can take his come.'

She sucked gently on the man's balls as he gripped her damp hair and jacked his cock the last stretch of the way. Drew didn't quite know if she was going to take him back inside her mouth when it came time for the man to erupt—but instead, she grinned broadly, wickedly, and opened her mouth to allow Josh to come into it, and around it.

Drew caught his breath as the man began to pump thick cream over her lips, her tongue, into her mouth, and all over her face—across her cheeks, her forehead, her chin, even down onto her chest.

Emma only smiled and laughed like the naughtiest nymph in the glade, and took the tip of the man's cock into her mouth for the final spurts of his come.

Chapter Twenty-Three

Afterward, Josh gave Drew a fist bump that somehow made it seem like what they'd just done was some kind of frat-boy display of machismo—even though most men would, no doubt, feel their masculinity had been horribly violated if their woman had been taken by another, let alone as they watched.

Emma was left in a real state, her hair all mussed and sweaty, her face and chest sticky with come, and for a long while she was breathing hard to recover her breath. But she was smiling, and very content, and glowing with the unbridled beauty of a sexually satisfied woman.

'How do I look, sweetie?' she giggled, toying with her hair as though she'd come straight out of the salon.

'Incredible,' Drew smiled.

'That was fun.'

'I'll say.'

Josh was gathering his things, knowing full well when it was time to leave the couple to their own devices.

'As good as you thought it would be?' Emma asked him, wiping her face with the back of her hand, like a cat washing itself.

'Better,' he said. 'Much better. How about you?'

She grinned, and let out a long, loud, melodramatic moan. ‘I can’t believe how *insane* it was,’ she said, gazing at him with warm affection and continuing desire. ‘I mean... now that I’m your wife...’

He nodded, knowing what she meant. It was somehow just different, being married.

‘...but when you were watching me *fucking* Josh...’ she whispered the word ‘fucking’, as though she was worried her mother would overhear. ‘Jesus. It was hotter than the sun.’

Drew looked over at Josh, who was in the middle of dressing, and the guy gave him a mock salute, acknowledging his ability at firing up Emma through such unconventional means. Drew smiled back, and gave a nod of thanks.

Emma stood, and stepped over to Drew slowly, letting his eyes fall all over her freshly-fucked, naked body. ‘You know what else was seriously hot?’

‘What?’

‘Having the blindfold on. *And* having you telling us what to do.’ Emma put her hands on the arms of the armchair, and leaned over him. Drew could smell the sex on her, and it made him shiver with desire.

‘You liked that, huh?’ he chuckled.

‘Mmm-hmm.’ She leaned into him, blocking his light somewhat, her mouth slowly approaching his. She was going to kiss him. He couldn’t think of anything he’d like more at that particular moment—but at the same time, he was aware that the other man had just shot jet after jet of his come all over her face.

She didn’t give him much choice. She wiped her mouth with her other hand, brushed her damp hair back over her shoulder, and then pressed her lips against his. He breathed in the strange smell of another man’s come, but her kiss was sweet.

After a moment, she stood up again, and said, 'Will you wait, while I freshen up?'

'Sure,' he smiled.

'I won't be long,' she grinned, and scampered off toward the bedroom.

Josh was pulling on his shirt, practically ready to go.

Drew felt a little bad the guy felt like he had to scam, particularly this late. He said, 'You know, that sofa over there is a sofa-bed...'

Josh grinned, 'Oh no, it's fine.'

Drew nodded. Then, for something to say while he walked s-l-o-w-l-y toward the door, he said, 'So... I guess this is it. Good luck, buddy. She's a special one. You've done well.'

'Thanks,' Drew smiled.

Josh held up a business card, laid it on the table just inside the door. 'If you guys are ever in Vegas again... look me up, huh?'

Then he was gone, and Drew was alone in the suite with his bride.

'Drew, sweetie,' came Emma's call from the bedroom. 'You wanna come in?'

His cock throbbed in his pants.

Chapter Twenty-Four

She was lying on the bed, propped up on the pillows to watch him enter the room, a serene, confident smile on her pretty face.

She couldn't have had a shower, she hadn't had the time, and there wasn't the characteristic dampness emanating from the en suite bathroom, nor the sound of the extractor fan. But she was wearing fresh clothes—or at least fresh lingerie, which he had never seen before. Black stockings, black garters, some kind of black bodysuit or basque, it seemed particularly elegant, particularly sexy, particularly extravagant. And she was wearing a pair of black, high-heeled shoes.

'There you are,' she said, slowly running her hands over her chest, her stomach, her thighs, as though pointing out her new outfit to him. *'I was starting to think you'd fallen asleep, or something.'*

'Josh was just leaving,' he said, by way of explanation for his tardiness.

She gave a little nod, and her smile didn't falter. *'Why don't you take off your clothes?'* she said, her authoritative tone of voice, and the way she was looking at him, indicating that she was in charge now, she was going to play the leader.

'Sure,' he said, and set about unfastening the buttons on his shirt, before peeling it off to reveal a torso nicely shaped by fairly regular gym attendance.

She sat up as he removed his pants, as though she needed a better look, and a flash of her eyes told him in no uncertain terms to remove his boxer shorts, too.

After he stepped out of his boxer shorts, she was kneeling up on the bed, moving toward him, her eyes roaming all over his trim body, checking him out completely. She said, 'Now it's *your* turn to do what *I* want.'

She squeezed her breasts through the thick black lace of her basque, then shuffled toward him. Drew stepped up to the edge of the mattress, compliant, a touch apprehensive but quietly thrilled. This was his wife, but the fact was she had far more sexual experience than he did.

It could be a little intimidating, if he let it get to him.

Emma knelt up against him, running her hands through his hair before cradling his head, pulling him in for a kiss. She'd applied fresh makeup, spritzed herself lightly with perfume, but he could still detect a hint of the other man on her. His cologne, his sweat, the come that had streaked her face, her neck, her chest. He wasn't freaked out by it. It simply confirmed her rampant sexuality, her ravenous libido. It fortified his desire for her, pumping adrenaline into his bloodstream, zapping his heart to increase his pulse.

Thickening his cock as she sucked on his lips, and he on hers.

It was a long, sweet kiss, perhaps longer and sweeter than any they had yet shared. It seemed to be her way of saying they were moving on, they were no longer just friends, or even BFFs. They were lovers, through and through. Married lovers.

Then she broke away, bit her lip and gave him a half-smile that seemed full of wickedness, full of intent.

'I can smell him on you,' he breathed, trying to keep calm.

'You like that, don't you?' she grinned.

She stroked his face affectionately, but moved back a few feet from him on the bed, then turned away from him.

‘Take my panties off,’ she said, presenting him with her behind.

He’d hardly laid eyes on her in that outfit, but here he was reaching forward to peel her black panties down over her delectable rear. When they were around her thighs, she leaned forward, and then went down on all fours, facing away from him, to give him a superlative view of her pussy from behind.

He was so close to her, he could smell her arousal. He feasted on the sight of her as she lifted one knee briefly, and then the other, to help him remove her panties completely.

Then he placed his hands on the soft roundness of her shapely behind, breathing her in as he luxuriated in the smoothness of her skin, and the idea that this gorgeous woman had only just finished having sex with another man—Josh had squeezed his big cock inside this very pussy only minutes before.

‘So beautiful,’ he said quietly, and she moaned in response to his touch.

‘You can have it, if you like,’ she said, waggling her hips gently, inviting him.

He stroked her inner thighs, feeling the intense heat of her body.

‘Go on,’ she moaned.

Intoxicated by her scent, by her beauty, buzzing with adrenaline from seeing her with another man, he tilted his head upward, and pressed his mouth against her rose-flushed, glistening pussy.

She moaned again as his tongue emerged, seeking out her soft folds, lapping up her tangy nectar.

‘Oh God... oh *honey*... oh yes...’

He gripped her buttocks with both hands and devoured her, sucking on her lips, tonguing her groove, relishing her flavor, her heat, her wetness. Something about it seemed wrong—another man had just fucked her, had just penetrated her right here, sliding his big dick over and over into this

sweet pussy—and yet that taboo nature of what he was now doing only made it seem more thrilling.

Emma was sighing and panting as he sucked on her pussy, as he fucked her with his mouth, as he feasted on her well-used sex. He loved making her feel good in this way. She rocked gently, her hips swayed, as though they were on a boat navigating choppy seas.

But when she seemed to get close to orgasm, she pulled away from him slightly—just enough so that he could look, but not taste, stroke her, but not suck on her.

She turned over, lying on her back, propped up on her elbows, her legs opening to display her pussy for him.

‘Do I turn you on?’ she asked him, with a wicked smile.

‘Uh-huh,’ he said, recovering his breath.

She stroked her pussy in front of him. ‘Even after being with Josh?’

‘Uh-huh.’

‘You like that I just had his big, thick cock inside my pussy?’

‘Yes.’

‘You want another taste?’

‘Please.’

She brought her legs together, but lifted her feet so that her pussy was exposed to him as he leaned into her. He nuzzled his face between her closed thighs, pressed his mouth up against her searing-hot sex again, tasting her wet folds, kissing her there, sucking on her.

God. He’d always enjoyed going down on a woman—getting so intimate with her, so up close and personal, so intensely sexy. And yet back when he’d been properly dating, so few women had seemed to really let go and just enjoy it. Perhaps it had been because they’d still been in college, they hadn’t been so confident in themselves. Emma was just all confidence. And the way she responded to him as he made love to her with his mouth was just bewitching. Drew was obsessed with pleasuring her with his

mouth, he was hooked on making her writhe and moan and gasp and pant by sucking on her soaking pussy, he was completely addicted to her flavor.

He had no idea how long he pleased her that way, but it seemed like heaven to him. He felt so connected to her, their bond so intimate, so personal. Indulging in the wicked taboo of the freshly-fucked man-eater, while worshipping her as the exquisite goddess he had fallen so hard for over the years.

She pressed her hand to his head as he coursed his tongue through her slippery folds, clamping him to her, and finally gave in to the feelings he was provoking in her.

‘You’re gonna make me come...’ she moaned, ‘you’re gonna make me come...’

Her moans became almost growls, yelping howls with a kind of animalistic force, until the actual peak of her climax hit—whereupon she was suddenly silent, sucking in her breath through her teeth, squinting and tensing up as the full force of the orgasm exploded within her. God, she was so *wet*. Her juices were just everywhere as that tidal wave hit.

She screwed her eyes tight shut and gasped for oxygen as the powerful orgasm finally emerged from her shaking, shuddering body.

And then, as she continued shaking, she was laughing, her mouth spread in a broad smile as she laughed long and loud, her eyes opening to gaze down at him in wonder, as the full force of her climax finally subsided.

‘What?’ he said, looking up at her glowing face with a puzzled grin, wondering if she was laughing at him, or with him, whether he should be content or embarrassed. ‘Why are you *laughing*?’

‘You made me *squirt*,’ she grinned, her green eyes so wide, so sparkly.

‘Huh?’

‘Nobody’s made me do *that* since high school.’

‘*High school*?’

She giggled. ‘I never thought it would happen again.’

Her hand on his head, she pushed him away, and then managed to sit up, and lean in to kiss his mouth, apparently undaunted by the fact that his face was soaked with her arousal. He felt her hand on his stiff cock, grasping hold of his shaft, and she was moaning appreciatively as they sucked on each other's lips, enjoying how hard he was for her.

'Big enough?' he asked her when their kiss came to an end.

'You boys,' she giggled, and rolled her eyes. 'Didn't I get to tell you yet? Yours is the *perfect* size. And I'm not just saying that because I adore you.'

'Well... you know... when you have the choice of any dick in town...' he smiled.

'I'd always choose yours over anybody else's,' she said, tugging on him. 'Now, get up here on the bed.'

He did as she demanded, climbing onto the mattress, dropping onto his back so that his head crashed against the thick pillows. Then she was beside him, her hand expertly gripping his cock, taking it in her mouth for a few minutes, as though to reacquaint herself with it there, before she moved up again, to kiss his mouth and straddle his waist.

'Will you fuck me?' she asked.

'Of course,' he said.

'Even though I just fucked another guy?'

'You can fuck whoever you like, I'll always want to be next.'

She smiled, and he felt her hand on his sensitive shaft, positioning him between her thighs. Then, he heard her catch her breath as the tip of his cock touched against the scorching heat of her pussy. Then, as she gazed down at him, her big, green eyes widened and her mouth opened as she pressed herself down on him, and his throbbing hardness was slowly engulfed by her sex.

For a moment, when he was inside her the whole way, filling her completely, she just quietly paused, and both of them seemed to be taking in

that strange, wonderful milestone in their relationship. They had been BFFs, such close friends for so very long, each quietly attracted to each other while thinking they could never have what they most wanted.

But here they were, fully consummating their marriage.

She smiled sweetly. 'How does it feel? Married pussy?'

'Wonderful,' he said. '*Unbelievable.*'

She slowly rose up, and he felt the bliss of her pussy tight around his shaft—tight, wet, burning hot. He could hardly believe he was inside her. Emma. Emma was fucking him. She lifted herself until only the tip of his cock was still inside her, and then she plunged down again. God, she was gifted. Whether it was her wealth of experience or simple natural talent, he didn't know. But the way she moved on top of him, the way she gyrated her hips as she rode him, the way she carried herself, the way she presented herself to him... it was all an absolute work of art.

And when he gazed down, seeing her exquisite pussy sinking down on his shaft, taking it within her again and again, he still had the memory fresh in his mind of seeing her doing this with another man, and somehow it made the whole experience even more intense.

After a while, she lay down on him while she continued to fuck him, pressing herself against him, pushing down the top of her basque so that her breasts could escape its confines, her stiff nipples could brush against his chest while she rode him. And she kissed him some more with that mouth that had sucked on another man's cock earlier that night, and had taken stream after stream of his come.

'Does that feel good?' she breathed, propping herself up on her hands so she could look in his eyes, her smile so wide across her pretty face.

'Incredible,' he groaned.

Then, he added, 'Is it... good for you?'

She laughed. 'You know what? I never thought I could ever settle for one man.'

Now it was his turn to laugh. 'But you don't have to,' he said.

'I don't mean *settle*,' she said, 'that's not the word I mean...'

Drew held her tight, then rolled her over onto her back, laughing as he knelt between her thighs. 'I know what you mean,' he said. 'Look... as long as you're mine—and you keep coming back to me afterward—you can fuck whoever you like.'

She smiled, but there was that little crinkle between her eyebrows, she still couldn't quite work him out. 'How did I ever deserve someone as amazing as you?' she asked him, moaning quietly as he stroked her open pussy with the tip of his cock.

He laughed, 'That's my line.'

And he sank his pulsating cock deep inside her.

'*Fuck...*' she gasped, eyes wide, mouth open, body jerking and breasts shivering every time he thrust into her.

'Fuck me, sweetie... it feels so good...'

There was no way he was going to last even half as long as Josh had. The feelings he was experiencing were so intense, the sensations, the thoughts whirling around his head. This was Emma. He was making love to *Emma*. And she was now his wife.

He felt like a god.

'Come inside me,' she moaned, and he realized she was heading for another orgasm. He'd never gotten any woman to two orgasms in one occasion. But Emma had already been warmed up by another man, she was primed.

Shiny with perspiration, red in the face and chest, she panted as he continued to slam his hard cock deep into her, and now hungrily sucked on her exposed breasts. Even now, he could smell the other man on her, and it only fired him up more.

Then she was crying out, and he felt her pussy clamp even tighter around his cock, and he could hold back no longer. He felt the climax erupt

from within his core, more powerful than anything he'd ever experienced before. And then the energy was surging from his loins into his big, hard, throbbing cock, and there was no way back. He felt the hot oil pumping out, shooting time after time after time deep into the pussy of his gloriously adulterous, wonderfully sexy, devastatingly hot *wife*.

OceanofPDF.com

Chapter Twenty-Five

Then they were back home, and it felt so strange. To Emma and Drew, it felt like the biggest thing ever had just happened to them—and, yet, they couldn't tell any of their friends or family about it. Any of it.

On their way through the airport terminal, they held hands. Waiting for their luggage, they gazed at each other longingly, with wicked little smiles spread across their glowing faces.

But proceeding through the arrivals hall, everything seemed too public for them to risk anything.

They made out in the taxi like horny college students, but as they crossed the harbor, again it didn't feel safe enough for them to show any kind of affection, other than holding their hands. Even holding hands had to end when they reached the South End, and stopped outside their building.

And there was Ray, and Carrie, and Fiona and Denny lounging around Drew and Ray's apartment, waiting for them, to welcome them back with drinks and, after the initial festivities were over, a night out. And the newly married couple had to act like they weren't even dating.

It was crazy.

They all sat round a table in Wally's, the jazz club on Mass Ave, and Emma felt the conscious need to sit apart from Drew. Even furtive glances

seemed dangerous. And yet, when they both risked it, the reward seemed sensational. Just looking at each other, knowing that they were married, made them both feel like a million dollars.

Drew glanced over and saw the elegant silver band Emma wore, and he could confirm visually that the wedding hadn't been some kind of heavenly dream, that he had imagined it all. Emma could glance over and see a hint of the understated silver necklace Drew wore, on which she knew was hanging his own matching wedding ring.

They were so good—that evening and subsequent occasions out in public—at pretending to be only friends. But they had to resist the natural urge to seek approval for their marriage among their peers—and that was surprisingly difficult.

There were points that evening, and others in future, where they both wondered if there was really any point in keeping their marriage secret.

Emma even texted Drew:

Emma: Can't we just tell everyone what happened? And then I could just have a few secret affairs now and again?

Drew was tempted to simply reply in full agreement with her suggestion. But this was what they had decided to do. He simply smiled at her across the table, a kind of reassuring smile, but also a signal for her that they should see how things panned out. They could always change their minds.

And then later that very evening, they bumped into a guy Carrie knew from work—Omar—and Carrie introduced him to Emma, and there was no doubt that she was introducing him as a potential date, and suddenly both Emma and Drew knew why they were keeping their marriage a secret for now. It was ridiculously hot watching her, up close, flirting with other guys. The way she looked at them, the way they looked at her.

Wanting each other, right in front of her husband. Excited by each other. Imagining themselves in bed with each other.

Later still, there they all were, hitting the dance floor, and Emma was flirting with Omar so outrageously that there was every chance she'd invite him home for a nightcap.

And when Omar was satisfied, having given Emma something of a workout back at her place, he would leave and she would send Drew a sly little text message suggesting he sneak across the hallway and into her bed.

There was just something sexy about a really good secret.

OceanofPDF.com